

song of myself

and other poems *by* walt whitman



selected and introduced by robert hass
with a lexicon of the poem by robert hass and paul ebenkamp

s · o · n · g *of* m · y · s · e · l · f

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SELECTED AND INTRODUCED BY ROBERT HASS

WITH A LEXICON OF THE POEM BY
ROBERT HASS AND PAUL EBENKAMP

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p a r t o n e

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s o n g *o f* m y s e l f

I N T R O D U C T I O N

The first edition of *Leaves of Grass* was printed in Brooklyn by Andrew Rome in June 1855, in an edition of 795 copies paid for by the author. It was reprinted in 1856 and offered for sale by Fowler and Wells, the successful publisher of what might be thought of as New Age books and pamphlets on subjects ranging from physiology to phrenology (the science of reading people's characters from the shapes of their heads) to the salubrious effects of ocean bathing. Walt Whitman designed the book himself and had a hand in the typesetting. It was bound in green ribbed morocco cloth with the title embossed in gold. The title page did not identify the author, but the now-famous frontispiece engraving of a bearded man in an open-collared shirt and a jauntily cocked hat did. The book contained a prose introduction and twelve poems. The first poem was long—1336 lines—and untitled. *Leaves of Grass* went through eight editions in Whitman's lifetime. In the second edition of 1856 the opening poem acquired a title. It was called "Poem of Walt Whitman, an American." In 1860, it became "Walt Whitman," and that title remained until he renamed it once again. It became "Song of Myself" in the 1881 edition. The poem is reprinted here as it appeared in 1855 and as it appeared in the final edition of 1891–92. It was then and is now an astonishment, perhaps the most unprecedented poem in the English language.

It is also an important document in the history of American culture. "Song of Myself" captures in a particular voice and at a particular moment something alive, generous, and hopeful in the developing culture of the United States, and it escaped, almost immediately, the bonds of its fervent nationalism: it became a way forward in the twentieth century for poets all over the world—in Latin America and Russia and Portugal and China and India and North Africa. For all

its fame, the poem and the years during which it came into being are something of a mystery—one that has been studied by Whitman's many biographers. (My favorite is Paul Zweig's *Walt Whitman: The Making of a Poet*.) Son of an alcoholic carpenter with a large and troubled family, the young Walt Whitman had only a few years of formal education. He was an office boy at eleven, a journeyman printer at fourteen, a school master in the farm country of Long Island at seventeen, and a journalist for hire at twenty-two in the booming suburb of Brooklyn, where he also became a *flâneur*, an appreciative stroller, of Manhattan across the river, the new urban world of the crowded and bustling nineteenth century. He churned out newspaper articles and book reviews and theater and art reviews and editorials. He wrote a very mediocre and melodramatic novella on the evils of drink. He was during those years—as he described it—“simmering, simmering.” In 1855, from his reading—English romantic poetry, American poetry and philosophy, German philosophy, history, popular science—from his daydreams, from a brief stint in New Orleans as an editor and the glimpses of the country he got in his travel there and back, from his mother's Quaker heritage and his father's workingman's democratic rationalism, from the air he breathed in the streets of Brooklyn and Manhattan, their commerce and idioms, and from the flood of life he had made it his profession to observe, came this altogether unexpected poem.

The most unexpected thing about the poem was its basic technique. It is one of the first extended experiments in free verse in the English language. Whitman had to figure out how to create and sustain a new kind of formal structure for poetry. He wanted music—Galway Kinnell has remarked that Whitman's poems are so rich in vowel music it is as if they were written in Hawaiian—and he wanted something like the feel and realistic detail that was characteristic of journalism and the novel in his day, which was for him the idiom of the vivid present. He thought the poetry of a new democratic order had to have both these qualities if it was to embody new thoughts and have in it the feel of common life in cities.

And then there is the question of what *sort* of poem it is. No artist proceeds without some models of what she or he is either doing or trying not to do. Probably the rough models for “Song of Myself” are the remarkable set of odes written by English poets early in the century. Whitman had read them. Like

his poem, they are about imagination and nature, about the human relation to these powers, and like his poem they are meditative, tend to make an argument and to take surprising turns, and to dramatize the individual's relation to the imagination as a source of creative power. So it seems very likely that he had them in mind—or that they had become part of his own imagination of what serious poetry was about. But most of the odes are only a hundred or two hundred lines in length, and “Song of Myself” is a poem of thirteen hundred lines; it is as long as ten odes. It's interesting that the one significant revision Whitman made to the 1855 “Song” was to rid it of its ellipses, which gave the poem its tumultuous and cascading effect. He also slowed the poem down by dividing it into numbered sections, as the English poets had done. In the classical prehistory of the ode, separate sections marked changes in the music that accompanied recitation, and there is something of that in Whitman's making of the shifts in tone and attack in his poem. The movement from section to section really does give the poem the feel of a suite in the ode form as it swings back and forth from aria to teeming catalogue.

Some critics have thought that he may also have found his models for both the music of the poem and its formal development in the prophetic poems of the Old Testament in the King James translation—the poems of Isaiah and Jeremiah and Ezekiel. Nearer to hand were the essays of Ralph Waldo Emerson, which Whitman was steeped in. When he said he was “simmering, simmering,” he also said that it was Emerson—probably the *Essays* of 1841 and 1844—that brought him to a boil. Emerson's essays, like the Romantic odes, have the individual's relation to nature and to imagination as their subjects, and they think about these subjects in an American context. Like “Song of Myself,” the essays advance an argument without advancing the structure of an argument. They proceed by weaving together disparate thoughts, by aphorism and metaphor and repetition and sudden veerings of thought. So it is possible to say that “Song of Myself” is a Romantic ode exploded into something else by the essays of Emerson and the sweep of prophetic imagination, and then soaked in the language and imagination of nineteenth-century American journalism—though this description would leave out the richest and most surprising thing about the poem, which is its language.

The argument that “Song of Myself” makes—that we have more in common

than separates us, that that common thing is the nature that courses through us, that we and the nature of which we are a part are carried by a profoundly sexual rhythm—"Urge and urge and urge," he would write, "always the procreant urge of the world"—that the principle of nature is abundance and variety, that death is as much a part of its rhythm as birth and sexual desire are, that love—which he calls the "kelson of creation"—and sympathy—"I am attesting sympathy," he writes—"Shall I make my list of things in the house and skip the house that supports them?"—are among the deepest ways that the human imagination connects people to one another and to that larger rhythm, that the body is as important as the soul, that the teeming life of Manhattan and its working people and the immensity and diversity of the American continent embody this nature, and that it is a great leveler and hence a democratic power, and it is a power bound to supersede all previous notions of divinity, and that all this is as common as the grass—this argument is made in the ideas of the poem, in its dazzling and superabundant lists, and in its seriousness and humor and tenderness and moments of melodrama and flashes of tragedy, but also in the sheer range of its language. Whitman draws his diction from every level of written and spoken language available to him—the speech of the streets—"the blab of the pave," he calls it (an example of what I mean), the speech of the crafts, the languages of the professions, the vocabularies of science and technology and law and the pulpit. This poem about democracy and imagination, and what to make of life and death, and about a person's own wondering experience of his own existence makes its case for our common human imagination by deploying the abundance, variety and hilarity of the languages in which human beings have both described and invented the world in which they find themselves living.

s · o · n · g *of* m · y · s · e · l · f

1855

I celebrate myself,
And what I assume you shall assume,
For every atom belonging to me as good belongs to you.

I loafe and invite my soul,
I lean and loafe at my ease . . . observing a spear of summer grass.

5

Houses and rooms are full of perfumes . . . the shelves are crowded with
perfumes,
I breathe the fragrance myself, and know it and like it,
The distillation would intoxicate me also, but I shall not let it.

The atmosphere is not a perfume . . . it has no taste of the distillation . . . it
is odorless,

It is for my mouth forever . . . I am in love with it,
I will go to the bank by the wood and become undisguised and naked,
I am mad for it to be in contact with me.

10

The smoke of my own breath,
Echos, ripples, and buzzed whispers . . . loveroot, silkthread, crotch and
vine,

My respiration and inspiration . . . the beating of my heart . . . the passing of
blood and air through my lungs,
The sniff of green leaves and dry leaves, and of the shore and darkcolored
sea-rocks, and of hay in the barn,

15

The sound of the belched words of my voice words loosed to the eddies
of the wind,
A few light kisses a few embraces a reaching around of arms,
The play of shine and shade on the trees as the supple boughs wag,
The delight alone or in the rush of the streets, or along the fields and hillsides, 20
The feeling of health the full-noon trill the song of me rising from
bed and meeting the sun.

Have you reckoned a thousand acres much? Have you reckoned the earth
much?
Have you practiced so long to learn to read?
Have you felt so proud to get at the meaning of poems?

Stop this day and night with me and you shall possess the origin of all poems, 25
You shall possess the good of the earth and sun there are millions of suns
left,
You shall no longer take things at second or third hand nor look through
the eyes of the dead nor feed on the spectres in books,
You shall not look through my eyes either, nor take things from me,
You shall listen to all sides and filter them from yourself.

I have heard what the talkers were talking the talk of the beginning and 30
the end,
But I do not talk of the beginning or the end.

There was never any more inception than there is now,
Nor any more youth or age than there is now;
And will never be any more perfection than there is now,
Nor any more heaven or hell than there is now. 35

Urge and urge and urge,
Always the procreant urge of the world.

Out of the dimness opposite equals advance . . . Always substance and
increase,
Always a knit of identity . . . always distinction . . . always a breed of life.

To elaborate is no avail . . . Learned and unlearned feel that it is so.

40

Sure as the most certain sure . . . plumb in the uprights, well entretied,
braced in the beams,
Stout as a horse, affectionate, haughty, electrical,
I and this mystery here we stand.

Clear and sweet is my soul . . . and clear and sweet is all that is not my soul.

Lack one lacks both . . . and the unseen is proved by the seen,
Till that becomes unseen and receives proof in its turn.

45

Showing the best and dividing it from the worst, age vexes age,
Knowing the perfect fitness and equanimity of things, while they discuss I
am silent, and go bathe and admire myself.

Welcome is every organ and attribute of me, and of any man hearty and
clean,
Not an inch nor a particle of an inch is vile, and none shall be less familiar
than the rest.

50

I am satisfied . . . I see, dance, laugh, sing;
As God comes a loving bedfellow and sleeps at my side all night and close on
the peep of the day,
And leaves for me baskets covered with white towels bulging the house with
their plenty,
Shall I postpone my acceptance and realization and scream at my eyes,
That they turn from gazing after and down the road,

55

And forthwith cipher and show me to a cent,
Exactly the contents of one, and exactly the contents of two, and which is
ahead?

Trippers and askers surround me,
People I meet the effect upon me of my early life of the ward and
city I live in of the nation,
The latest news discoveries, inventions, societies authors old and 60
new,
My dinner, dress, associates, looks, business, compliments, dues,
The real or fancied indifference of some man or woman I love,
The sickness of one of my folks—or of myself or ill-doing or loss or
lack of money or depressions or exaltations,
They come to me days and nights and go from me again,
But they are not the Me myself. 65

Apart from the pulling and hauling stands what I am,
Stands amused, complacent, compassionating, idle, unitary,
Looks down, is erect, bends an arm on an impalpable certain rest,
Looks with its sidecurved head curious what will come next,
Both in and out of the game, and watching and wondering at it. 70

Backward I see in my own days where I sweated through fog with linguists
and contenders,
I have no mockings or arguments I witness and wait.

I believe in you my soul the other I am must not abase itself to you,
And you must not be abased to the other.

Loafe with me on the grass loose the stop from your throat, 75
Not words, not music or rhyme I want not custom or lecture, not even
the best,
Only the lull I like, the hum of your valved voice.

I mind how we lay in June, such a transparent summer morning;
You settled your head athwart my hips and gently turned over upon me,
And parted the shirt from my bosom-bone, and plunged your tongue to my 80
 barestript heart,
And reached till you felt my beard, and reached till you held my feet.

Swiftly arose and spread around me the peace and joy and knowledge that
 pass all the art and argument of the earth;
And I know that the hand of God is the elderhand of my own,
And I know that the spirit of God is the eldest brother of my own,
And that all the men ever born are also my brothers . . . and the women my 85
 sisters and lovers,
And that a kelson of the creation is love;
And limitless are leaves stiff or drooping in the fields,
And brown ants in the little wells beneath them,
And mossy scabs of the wormfence, and heaped stones, and elder and mullen
 and pokeweed.

A child said, What is the grass? fetching it to me with full hands; 90
How could I answer the child? . . . I do not know what it is any more than he.

I guess it must be the flag of my disposition, out of hopeful green stuff woven.

Or I guess it is the handkerchief of the Lord,
A scented gift and remembrancer designedly dropped,
Bearing the owner's name someway in the corners, that we may see and 95
 remark, and say Whose?

Or I guess the grass is itself a child . . . the produced babe of the vegetation.

Or I guess it is a uniform hieroglyphic,
And it means, Sprouting alike in broad zones and narrow zones,
Growing among black folks as among white,

Kanuck, Tuckahoe, Congressman, Cuff, I give them the same, I receive them
the same. 100

And now it seems to me the beautiful uncut hair of graves.

Tenderly will I use you curling grass,
It may be you transpire from the breasts of young men,
It may be if I had known them I would have loved them;
It may be you are from old people and from women, and from offspring 105
taken soon out of their mothers' laps,
And here you are the mothers' laps.

This grass is very dark to be from the white heads of old mothers,
Darker than the colorless beards of old men,
Dark to come from under the faint red roofs of mouths.

O I perceive after all so many uttering tongues! 110
And I perceive they do not come from the roofs of mouths for nothing.

I wish I could translate the hints about the dead young men and women,
And the hints about old men and mothers, and the offspring taken soon out
of their laps.

What do you think has become of the young and old men?
And what do you think has become of the women and children? 115

They are alive and well somewhere;
The smallest sprout shows there is really no death,
And if ever there was it led forward life, and does not wait at the end to arrest it,
And ceased the moment life appeared.

All goes onward and outward . . . and nothing collapses, 120
And to die is different from what any one supposed, and luckier.

Has any one supposed it lucky to be born?
I hasten to inform him or her it is just as lucky to die, and I know it.

I pass death with the dying, and birth with the new-washed babe . . . and am
not contained between my hat and boots,
And peruse manifold objects, no two alike, and every one good, 125
The earth good, and the stars good, and their adjuncts all good.

I am not an earth nor an adjunct of an earth,
I am the mate and companion of people, all just as immortal and fathomless
as myself;
They do not know how immortal, but I know.

Every kind for itself and its own . . . for me mine male and female, 130
For me all that have been boys and that love women,
For me the man that is proud and feels how it stings to be slighted,
For me the sweetheart and the old maid . . . for me mothers and the mothers
of mothers,
For me lips that have smiled, eyes that have shed tears,
For me children and the begetters of children. 135

Who need be afraid of the merge?
Undrape . . . you are not guilty to me, nor stale nor discarded,
I see through the broadcloth and gingham whether or no,
And am around, tenacious, acquisitive, tireless . . . and can never be shaken
away.

The little one sleeps in its cradle, 140
I lift the gauze and look a long time, and silently brush away flies with my
hand.

The youngster and the redfaced girl turn aside up the bushy hill,
I peeringly view them from the top.

The suicide sprawls on the bloody floor of the bedroom
It is so . . . I witnessed the corpse . . . there the pistol had fallen.

145

The blab of the pave . . . the tires of carts and sluff of bootsoles and talk of the
promenaders,

The heavy omnibus, the driver with his interrogating thumb, the clank of the
shod horses on the granite floor,

The carnival of sleighs, the clinking and shouted jokes and pelts of snowballs;

The hurrahs for popular favorites . . . the fury of roused mobs,

The flap of the curtained litter—the sick man inside, borne to the hospital,

150

The meeting of enemies, the sudden oath, the blows and fall,

The excited crowd—the policeman with his star quickly working his passage
to the centre of the crowd;

The impassive stones that receive and return so many echoes,

The souls moving along . . . are they invisible while the least atom of the
stones is visible?

What groans of overfed or half-starved who fall on the flags sunstruck or in
fits,

155

What exclamations of women taken suddenly, who hurry home and give
birth to babes,

What living and buried speech is always vibrating here . . . what howls
restrained by decorum,

Arrests of criminals, slights, adulterous offers made, acceptances, rejections
with convex lips,

I mind them or the resonance of them . . . I come again and again.

The big doors of the country-barn stand open and ready,

160

The dried grass of the harvest-time loads the slow-drawn wagon,

The clear light plays on the brown gray and green intertinged,

The armfuls are packed to the sagging mow:

I am there . . . I help . . . I came stretched atop of the load,

I felt its soft jolts . . . one leg reclined on the other,

165

I jump from the crossbeams, and seize the clover and timothy,
And roll head over heels, and tangle my hair full of wisps.

Alone far in the wilds and mountains I hunt,
Wandering amazed at my own lightness and glee,
In the late afternoon choosing a safe spot to pass the night,
Kindling a fire and broiling the freshkilled game,
Soundly falling asleep on the gathered leaves, my dog and gun by my side.

170

The Yankee clipper is under her three skysails . . . she cuts the sparkle and
scud,
My eyes settle the land . . . I bend at her prow or shout joyously from the
deck.

The boatmen and clamdiggers arose early and stopped for me,
I tucked my trowser-ends in my boots and went and had a good time,
You should have been with us that day round the chowder-kettle.

175

I saw the marriage of the trapper in the open air in the far-west . . . the bride
was a red girl,
Her father and his friends sat near by crosslegged and dumbly smoking . . .
they had moccasins to their feet and large thick blankets hanging from
their shoulders;
On a bank lounged the trapper . . . he was dressed mostly in skins . . . his
luxuriant beard and curls protected his neck,
One hand rested on his rifle . . . the other hand held firmly the wrist of the
red girl,
She had long eyelashes . . . her head was bare . . . her coarse straight locks
descended upon her voluptuous limbs and reached to her feet.

180

The runaway slave came to my house and stopped outside,
I heard his motions crackling the twigs of the woodpile,

Through the swung half-door of the kitchen I saw him limpsey and weak, 185
And went where he sat on a log, and led him in and assured him,
And brought water and filled a tub for his sweated body and bruised feet,
And gave him a room that entered from my own, and gave him some coarse
 clean clothes,
And remember perfectly well his revolving eyes and his awkwardness,
And remember putting plasters on the galls of his neck and ankles; 190
He staid with me a week before he was recuperated and passed north,
I had him sit next me at table . . . my firelock leaned in the corner.

Twenty-eight young men bathe by the shore,
Twenty-eight young men, and all so friendly,
Twenty-eight years of womanly life, and all so lonesome. 195

She owns the fine house by the rise of the bank,
She hides handsome and richly drest aft the blinds of the window.

Which of the young men does she like the best?
Ah the homeliest of them is beautiful to her.

Where are you off to, lady? for I see you, 200
You splash in the water there, yet stay stock still in your room.

Dancing and laughing along the beach came the twenty-ninth bather,
The rest did not see her, but she saw them and loved them.

The beards of the young men glistened with wet, it ran from their long hair,
Little streams passed all over their bodies. 205

An unseen hand also passed over their bodies,
It descended tremblingly from their temples and ribs.

The young men float on their backs, their white bellies swell to the sun . . .
they do not ask who seizes fast to them,
They do not know who puffs and declines with pendant and bending arch,
They do not think whom they souse with spray.

210

The butcher-boy puts off his killing-clothes, or sharpens his knife at the stall
in the market,
I loiter enjoying his repartee and his shuffle and breakdown.

Blacksmiths with grimed and hairy chests environ the anvil,
Each has his main-sledge . . . they are all out . . . there is a great heat in the
fire.

From the cinder-strewed threshold I follow their movements,
The lithe sheer of their waists plays even with their massive arms,
Overhand the hammers roll—overhand so slow—overhand so sure,
They do not hasten, each man hits in his place.

215

The negro holds firmly the reins of his four horses . . . the block swags
underneath on its tied-over chain,
The negro that drives the huge dray of the stoneyard . . . steady and tall he
stands poised on one leg on the stringpiece,
His blue shirt exposes his ample neck and breast and loosens over his
hipband,
His glance is calm and commanding . . . he tosses the slouch of his hat away
from his forehead,
The sun falls on his crispy hair and moustache . . . falls on the black of his
polish'd and perfect limbs.

220

I behold the picturesque giant and love him . . . and I do not stop there,
I go with the team also.

225

In me the caresser of life wherever moving . . . backward as well as forward
slueing,
To niches aside and junior bending.

Oxen that rattle the yoke or halt in the shade, what is that you express in your
eyes?
It seems to me more than all the print I have read in my life.

My tread scares the wood-drake and wood-duck on my distant and daylong 230
ramble,
They rise together, they slowly circle around.
. . . I believe in those winged purposes,
And acknowledge the red yellow and white playing within me,
And consider the green and violet and the tufted crown intentional;
And do not call the tortoise unworthy because she is not something else, 235
And the mocking bird in the swamp never studied the gamut, yet trills pretty
well to me,
And the look of the bay mare shames silliness out of me.

The wild gander leads his flock through the cool night,
Ya-honk! he says, and sounds it down to me like an invitation;
The pert may suppose it meaningless, but I listen closer, 240
I find its purpose and place up there toward the November sky.

The sharpfooed moose of the north, the cat on the housesill, the chickadee,
the prairie-dog,
The litter of the grunting sow as they tug at her teats,
The brood of the turkeyhen, and she with her halfspread wings,
I see in them and myself the same old law. 245

The press of my foot to the earth springs a hundred affections,
They scorn the best I can do to relate them.

I am enamoured of growing outdoors,
Of men that live among cattle or taste of the ocean or woods,
Of the builders and steerers of ships, of the wielders of axes and mauls, of the 250
 drivers of horses,
I can eat and sleep with them week in and week out.

What is commonest and cheapest and nearest and easiest is Me,
Me going in for my chances, spending for vast returns,
Adorning myself to bestow myself on the first that will take me,
Not asking the sky to come down to my goodwill, 255
Scattering it freely forever.

The pure contralto sings in the organloft,
The carpenter dresses his plank . . . the tongue of his foreplane whistles its
 wild ascending lisp,
The married and unmarried children ride home to their thanksgiving dinner,
The pilot seizes the king-pin, he heaves down with a strong arm, 260
The mate stands braced in the whaleboat, lance and harpoon are ready,
The duck-shooter walks by silent and cautious stretches,
The deacons are ordained with crossed hands at the altar,
The spinning-girl retreats and advances to the hum of the big wheel,
The farmer stops by the bars of a Sunday and looks at the oats and rye, 265
The lunatic is carried at last to the asylum a confirmed case,
He will never sleep any more as he did in the cot in his mother's bedroom;
The jour printer with gray head and gaunt jaws works at his case,
He turns his quid of tobacco, his eyes get blurred with the manuscript;
The malformed limbs are tied to the anatomist's table, 270
What is removed drops horribly in a pail;
The quadroon girl is sold at the stand . . . the drunkard nods by the barroom
 stove,
The machinist rolls up his sleeves . . . the policeman travels his beat . . . the
 gate-keeper marks who pass,

The young fellow drives the express-wagon . . . I love him though I do not
 know him;

The half-breed straps on his light boots to compete in the race, 275
 The western turkey-shooting draws old and young . . . some lean on their
 rifles, some sit on logs,
 Out from the crowd steps the marksman and takes his position and levels his
 piece;

The groups of newly-come immigrants cover the wharf or levee,
 The woollypates hoe in the sugarfield, the overseer views them from his
 saddle;

The bugle calls in the ballroom, the gentlemen run for their partners, the 280
 dancers bow to each other;
 The youth lies awake in the cedar-roofed garret and harks to the musical rain,
 The Wolverine sets traps on the creek that helps fill the Huron,
 The reformer ascends the platform, he spouts with his mouth and nose,
 The company returns from its excursion, the darkey brings up the rear and
 bears the well-riddled target,

The squaw wrapt in her yellow-hemmed cloth is offering moccasins and 285
 beadbags for sale,
 The connoisseur peers along the exhibition-gallery with halfshut eyes bent
 sideways,
 The deckhands make fast the steamboat, the plank is thrown for the
 shoregoing passengers,

The young sister holds out the skein, the elder sister winds it off in a ball and
 stops now and then for the knots,
 The one-year wife is recovering and happy, a week ago she bore her first child,
 The cleanhaired Yankee girl works with her sewing-machine or in the factory 290
 or mill,
 The nine months' gone is in the parturition chamber, her faintness and pains
 are advancing;

The pavingman leans on his twohanded rammer—the reporter's lead flies
 swiftly over the notebook—the signpainter is lettering with red and
 gold,

The canal-boy trots on the towpath—the bookkeeper counts at his desk—the
 shoemaker waxes his thread,
 The conductor beats time for the band and all the performers follow him,
 The child is baptized—the convert is making the first professions, 295
 The regatta is spread on the bay . . . how the white sails sparkle!
 The drover watches his drove, he sings out to them that would stray,
 The pedlar sweats with his pack on his back—the purchaser higgles about the
 odd cent,
 The camera and plate are prepared, the lady must sit for her daguerreotype,
 The bride unrumples her white dress, the minutehand of the clock moves 300
 slowly,
 The opium eater reclines with rigid head and just-opened lips,
 The prostitute draggles her shawl, her bonnet bobs on her tipsy and pimpled
 neck,
 The crowd laugh at her blackguard oaths, the men jeer and wink to each
 other,
 (Miserable! I do not laugh at your oaths nor jeer you.)
 The President holds a cabinet council, he is surrounded by the great 305
 secretaries,
 On the piazza walk five friendly matrons with twined arms;
 The crew of the fish-smack pack repeated layers of halibut in the hold,
 The Missourian crosses the plains toting his wares and his cattle,
 The fare-collector goes through the train—he gives notice by the jingling of
 loose change,
 The floormen are laying the floor—the tinnners are tinning the roof—the 310
 masons are calling for mortar,
 In single file each shouldering his hod pass onward the laborers;
 Seasons pursuing each other the indescribable crowd is gathered . . . it is the
 Fourth of July . . . what salutes of cannon and small arms!
 Seasons pursuing each other the plougher ploughs and the mower mows and
 the wintergrain falls in the ground;
 Off on the lakes the pikefisher watches and waits by the hole in the frozen
 surface,

The stumps stand thick round the clearing, the squatter strikes deep with his
 axe, 315
 The flatboatmen make fast toward dusk near the cottonwood or pekantrees,
 The coon-seekers go now through the regions of the Red river, or through
 those drained by the Tennessee, or through those of the Arkansas,
 The torches shine in the dark that hangs on the Chattahoochee or
 Altamahaw;
 Patriarchs sit at supper with sons and grandsons and great grandsons around
 them,
 In walls of adobe, in canvass tents, rest hunters and trappers after their day's 320
 sport.
 The city sleeps and the country sleeps,
 The living sleep for their time . . . the dead sleep for their time,
 The old husband sleeps by his wife and the young husband sleeps by his wife;
 And these one and all tend inward to me, and I tend outward to them,
 And such as it is to be of these more or less I am. 325

I am of old and young, of the foolish as much as the wise,
 Regardless of others, ever regardful of others,
 Maternal as well as paternal, a child as well as a man,
 Stuffed with the stuff that is coarse, and stuffed with the stuff that is fine,
 One of the great nations, the nation of many nations—the smallest the same 330
 and the largest the same,
 A southerner soon as a northerner, a planter nonchalant and hospitable,
 A Yankee bound my own way . . . ready for trade . . . my joints the limberest
 joints on earth and the sternest joints on earth,
 A Kentuckian walking the vale of the Elkhorn in my deerskin leggings,
 A boatman over the lakes or bays or along coasts . . . a Hoosier, a Badger, a
 Buckeye,
 A Louisianian or Georgian, a poke-easy from sandhills and pines, 335
 At home on Canadian snowshoes or up in the bush, or with fishermen off
 Newfoundland,

At home in the fleet of iceboats, sailing with the rest and tacking,
 At home on the hills of Vermont or in the woods of Maine or the Texan
 ranch,
 Comrade of Californians comrade of free northwesterners, loving their
 big proportions,
 Comrade of raftsmen and coalmen—comrade of all who shake hands and 340
 welcome to drink and meat;
 A learner with the simplest, a teacher of the thoughtfulest,
 A novice beginning experient of myriads of seasons,
 Of every hue and trade and rank, of every caste and religion,
 Not merely of the New World but of Africa Europe or Asia a wandering
 savage,
 A farmer, mechanic, or artist a gentleman, sailor, lover or quaker, 345
 A prisoner, fancy-man, rowdy, lawyer, physician or priest.

I resist anything better than my own diversity,
 And breathe the air and leave plenty after me,
 And am not stuck up, and am in my place.

The moth and the fisheggs are in their place, 350
 The suns I see and the suns I cannot see are in their place,
 The palpable is in its place and the impalpable is in its place.

These are the thoughts of all men in all ages and lands, they are not original
 with me,
 If they are not yours as much as mine they are nothing or next to nothing,
 If they do not enclose everything they are next to nothing, 355
 If they are not the riddle and the untying of the riddle they are nothing,
 If they are not just as close as they are distant they are nothing.

This is the grass that grows wherever the land is and the water is,
 This is the common air that bathes the globe.

This is the breath of laws and songs and behaviour, 360
This is the tasteless water of souls . . . this is the true sustenance,
It is for the illiterate . . . it is for the judges of the supreme court . . . it is for
the federal capitol and the state capitols,
It is for the admirable communes of literary men and composers and singers
and lecturers and engineers and savans,
It is for the endless races of working people and farmers and seamen.

This is the trill of a thousand clear cornets and scream of the octave flute and 365
strike of triangles.

I play not a march for victors only . . . I play great marches for conquered
and slain persons.

Have you heard that it was good to gain the day?
I also say it is good to fall . . . battles are lost in the same spirit in which they
are won.

I sound triumphal drums for the dead . . . I fling through my embouchures
the loudest and gayest music to them,
Vivas to those who have failed, and to those whose war-vessels sank in the 370
sea, and those themselves who sank in the sea,
And to all generals that lost engagements, and all overcome heroes, and the
numberless unknown heroes equal to the greatest heroes known.

This is the meal pleasantly set . . . this is the meat and drink for natural
hunger,
It is for the wicked just the same as the righteous . . . I make appointments
with all,
I will not have a single person slighted or left away,
The keptwoman and sponger and thief are hereby invited . . . the heavy- 375
lipped slave is invited . . . the venerealee is invited,
There shall be no difference between them and the rest.

This is the press of a bashful hand . . . this is the float and odor of hair,
This is the touch of my lips to yours . . . this is the murmur of yearning,
This is the far-off depth and height reflecting my own face,
This is the thoughtful merge of myself and the outlet again.

380

Do you guess I have some intricate purpose?
Well I have . . . for the April rain has, and the mica on the side of a rock has.

Do you take it I would astonish?
Does the daylight astonish? or the early redstart twittering through the
woods?
Do I astonish more than they?

385

This hour I tell things in confidence,
I might not tell everybody but I will tell you.

Who goes there! hankering, gross, mystical, nude?
How is it I extract strength from the beef I eat?

What is a man anyhow? What am I? and what are you?
All I mark as my own you shall offset it with your own,
Else it were time lost listening to me.

390

I do not snivel that snivel the world over,
That months are vacuums and the ground but wallow and filth,
That life is a suck and a sell, and nothing remains at the end but threadbare
crape and tears.

395

Whimpering and truckling fold with powders for invalids . . . conformity
goes to the fourth-removed,
I cock my hat as I please indoors or out.

Shall I pray? Shall I venerate and be ceremonious?

I have pried through the strata and analyzed to a hair,
And counselled with doctors and calculated close and found no sweeter fat 400
than sticks to my own bones.

In all people I see myself, none more and not one a barleycorn less,
And the good or bad I say of myself I say of them.

And I know I am solid and sound,
To me the converging objects of the universe perpetually flow,
All are written to me, and I must get what the writing means. 405

And I know I am deathless,
I know this orbit of mine cannot be swept by a carpenter's compass,
I know I shall not pass like a child's carlacue cut with a burnt stick at night.

I know I am august,
I do not trouble my spirit to vindicate itself or be understood, 410
I see that the elementary laws never apologize,
I reckon I behave no prouder than the level I plant my house by after all.

I exist as I am, that is enough,
If no other in the world be aware I sit content,
And if each and all be aware I sit content. 415

One world is aware, and by far the largest to me, and that is myself,
And whether I come to my own today or in ten thousand or ten million
years,
I can cheerfully take it now, or with equal cheerfulness I can wait.

My foothold is tenoned and mortised in granite,
I laugh at what you call dissolution, 420
And I know the amplitude of time.

I am the poet of the body,
And I am the poet of the soul.

The pleasures of heaven are with me, and the pains of hell are with me,
The first I graft and increase upon myself . . . the latter I translate into a new
tongue. 425

I am the poet of the woman the same as the man,
And I say it is as great to be a woman as to be a man,
And I say there is nothing greater than the mother of men.

I chant a new chant of dilation or pride,
We have had ducking and deprecating about enough, 430
I show that size is only development.

Have you outstript the rest? Are you the President?
It is a trifle . . . they will more than arrive there every one, and still pass on.

I am he that walks with the tender and growing night;
I call to the earth and sea half-held by the night. 435

Press close barebosomed night! Press close magnetic nourishing night!
Night of south winds! Night of the large few stars!
Still nodding night! Mad naked summer night!

Smile O voluptuous coolbreathed earth!
Earth of the slumbering and liquid trees! 440
Earth of departed sunset! Earth of the mountains misty-topt!
Earth of the vitreous pour of the full moon just tinged with blue!
Earth of shine and dark mottling the tide of the river!
Earth of the limpid gray of clouds brighter and clearer for my sake!
Far-swooping elbowed earth! Rich apple-blossomed earth! 445
Smile, for your lover comes!

Prodigal! you have given me love! . . . therefore I to you give love!
O unspeakable passionate love!

Thruster holding me tight and that I hold tight!
We hurt each other as the bridegroom and the bride hurt each other.

450

You sea! I resign myself to you also . . . I guess what you mean,
I behold from the beach your crooked inviting fingers,
I believe you refuse to go back without feeling of me;
We must have a turn together . . . I undress . . . hurry me out of sight of the
land,
Cushion me soft . . . rock me in billowy drowse,
Dash me with amorous wet . . . I can repay you.

455

Sea of stretched ground-swells!
Sea breathing broad and convulsive breaths!
Sea of the brine of life! Sea of unshovelled and always-ready graves!
Howler and scooper of storms! Capricious and dainty sea!
I am integral with you . . . I too am of one phase and of all phases.

460

Partaker of influx and efflux . . . extoler of hate and conciliation,
Extoler of amies and those that sleep in each others' arms.

I am he attesting sympathy;
Shall I make my list of things in the house and skip the house that supports
them?

465

I am the poet of commonsense and of the demonstrable and of immortality;
And am not the poet of goodness only . . . I do not decline to be the poet of
wickedness also.

Washes and razors for foofoos . . . for me freckles and a bristling beard.

What blurt is it about virtue and about vice?
Evil propels me, and reform of evil propels me . . . I stand indifferent, 470
My gait is no faultfinder's or rejecter's gait,
I moisten the roots of all that has grown.

Did you fear some scrofula out of the unflagging pregnancy?
Did you guess the celestial laws are yet to be worked over and rectified?

I step up to say that what we do is right and what we affirm is right . . . and 475
some is only the ore of right,
Witnesses of us . . . one side a balance and the antipodal side a balance,
Soft doctrine as steady help as stable doctrine,
Thoughts and deeds of the present our rouse and early start.

This minute that comes to me over the past decillions,
There is no better than it and now. 480

What behaved well in the past or behaves well today is not such a wonder,
The wonder is always and always how there can be a mean man or an infidel.

Endless unfolding of words of ages!
And mine a word of the modern . . . a word en masse.

A word of the faith that never balks, 485
One time as good as another time . . . here or henceforward it is all the same
to me.

A word of reality . . . materialism first and last imbueing.

Hurrah for positive science! Long live exact demonstration!
Fetch stonecrop and mix it with cedar and branches of lilac;
This is the lexicographer or chemist . . . this made a grammar of the old 490
cartouches,

These mariners put the ship through dangerous unknown seas,
This is the geologist, and this works with the scalpel, and this is a
mathematician.

Gentlemen I receive you, and attach and clasp hands with you,
The facts are useful and real . . . they are not my dwelling . . . I enter by
them to an area of the dwelling.

I am less the reminder of property or qualities, and more the reminder of life, 495
And go on the square for my own sake and for others' sakes,
And make short account of neuters and geldings, and favor men and women
fully equipped,
And beat the gong of revolt, and stop with fugitives and them that plot and
conspire.

Walt Whitman, an American, one of the roughs, a kosmos,
Disorderly fleshy and sensual . . . eating drinking and breeding, 500
No sentimentalist . . . no stander above men and women or apart from them
. . . no more modest than immodest.

Unscrew the locks from the doors!
Unscrew the doors themselves from their jambs!

Whoever degrades another degrades me . . . and whatever is done or said
returns at last to me,
And whatever I do or say I also return. 505

Through me the afflatus surging and surging . . . through me the current and
index.

I speak the password primeval . . . I give the sign of democracy;
By God! I will accept nothing which all cannot have their counterpart of on
the same terms.

Through me many long dumb voices,
Voices of the interminable generations of slaves, 510
Voices of prostitutes and of deformed persons,
Voices of the diseased and despairing, and of thieves and dwarfs,
Voices of cycles of preparation and accretion,
And of the threads that connect the stars—and of wombs, and of the
fatherstuff,
And of the rights of them the others are down upon, 515
Of the trivial and flat and foolish and despised,
Of fog in the air and beetles rolling balls of dung.

Through me forbidden voices,
Voices of sexes and lusts . . . voices veiled, and I remove the veil,
Voices indecent by me clarified and transfigured. 520

I do not press my finger across my mouth,
I keep as delicate around the bowels as around the head and heart,
Copulation is no more rank to me than death is.

I believe in the flesh and the appetites,
Seeing hearing and feeling are miracles, and each part and tag of me is a 525
miracle.

Divine am I inside and out, and I make holy whatever I touch or am touched
from;
The scent of these arm-pits is aroma finer than prayer,
This head is more than churches or bibles or creeds.

If I worship any particular thing it shall be some of the spread of my body;
Translucent mould of me it shall be you, 530
Shaded ledges and rests, firm masculine coulters, it shall be you,
Whatever goes to the tilth of me it shall be you,
You my rich blood, your milky stream pale strippings of my life;

Breast that presses against other breasts it shall be you,
My brain it shall be your occult convolutions, 535
Root of washed sweet-flag, timorous pond-snipe, nest of guarded duplicate
eggs, it shall be you,
Mixed tussled hay of head and beard and brawn it shall be you,
Trickling sap of maple, fibre of manly wheat, it shall be you;
Sun so generous it shall be you,
Vapors lighting and shading my face it shall be you, 540
You sweaty brooks and dews it shall be you,
Winds whose soft-tickling genitals rub against me it shall be you,
Broad muscular fields, branches of liveoak, loving lounge in my winding
paths, it shall be you,
Hands I have taken, face I have kissed, mortal I have ever touched, it shall be
you.

I dote on myself . . . there is that lot of me, and all so luscious, 545
Each moment and whatever happens thrills me with joy.

I cannot tell how my ankles bend . . . nor whence the cause of my faintest
wish,
Nor the cause of the friendship I emit . . . nor the cause of the friendship I
take again.

To walk up my stoop is unaccountable . . . I pause to consider if it really be,
That I eat and drink is spectacle enough for the great authors and schools, 550
A morning-glory at my window satisfies me more than the metaphysics of
books.

To behold the daybreak!
The little light fades the immense and diaphanous shadows,
The air tastes good to my palate.

Hefts of the moving world at innocent gambols, silently rising, freshly
exuding,
Scooting obliquely high and low. 555

Something I cannot see puts upward libidinous prongs,
Seas of bright juice suffuse heaven.

The earth by the sky staid with . . . the daily close of their junction,
The heaved challenge from the east that moment over my head, 560
The mocking taunt, See then whether you shall be master!

Dazzling and tremendous how quick the sunrise would kill me,
If I could not now and always send sunrise out of me.

We also ascend dazzling and tremendous as the sun,
We found our own my soul in the calm and cool of the daybreak. 565

My voice goes after what my eyes cannot reach,
With the twirl of my tongue I encompass worlds and volumes of worlds.

Speech is the twin of my vision . . . it is unequal to measure itself.

It provokes me forever,
It says sarcastically, Walt, you understand enough . . . why don't you let it out 570
then?

Come now I will not be tantalized . . . you conceive too much of articulation.

Do you not know how the buds beneath are folded?
Waiting in gloom protected by frost,
The dirt receding before my prophetic screams,
I underlying causes to balance them at last, 575

My knowledge my live parts . . . it keeping tally with the meaning of things,
Happiness . . . which whoever hears me let him or her set out in search of
this day.

My final merit I refuse you . . . I refuse putting from me the best I am.

Encompass worlds but never try to encompass me,
I crowd your noisiest talk by looking toward you.

580

Writing and talk do not prove me,
I carry the plenum of proof and every thing else in my face,
With the hush of my lips I confound the topmost skeptic.

I think I will do nothing for a long time but listen,
And accrue what I hear into myself . . . and let sounds contribute toward me.

585

I hear the bravuras of birds . . . the bustle of growing wheat . . . gossip of
flames . . . clack of sticks cooking my meals.

I hear the sound of the human voice . . . a sound I love,
I hear all sounds as they are tuned to their uses . . . sounds of the city and
sounds out of the city . . . sounds of the day and night;
Talkative young ones to those that like them . . . the recitative of fish-pedlars
and fruit-pedlars . . . the loud laugh of workpeople at their meals,
The angry base of disjointed friendship . . . the faint tones of the sick,
The judge with hands tight to the desk, his shaky lips pronouncing a death-
sentence,

590

The heave'yo of stevedores unlading ships by the wharves . . . the refrain of
the anchor-lifters;

The ring of alarm-bells . . . the cry of fire . . . the whirr of swift-streaking
engines and hose-carts with premonitory tinkles and colored lights,
The steam-whistle . . . the solid roll of the train of approaching cars;
The slow-march played at night at the head of the association,

595

They go to guard some corpse . . . the flag-tops are draped with black
muslin.

I hear the violincello or man's heart's complaint,
And hear the keyed cornet or else the echo of sunset.

I hear the chorus . . . it is a grand-opera . . . this indeed is music!

A tenor large and fresh as the creation fills me, 600
The orbic flex of his mouth is pouring and filling me full.

I hear the trained soprano . . . she convulses me like the climax of my
love-grip;
The orchestra whirls me wider than Uranus flies,
It wrenches unnamable ardors from my breast,
It throbs me to gulps of the farthest down horror, 605
It sails me . . . I dab with bare feet . . . they are licked by the indolent waves,
I am exposed . . . cut by bitter and poisoned hail,
Steeped amid honeyed morphine . . . my windpipe squeezed in the fakes of
death,
Let up again to feel the puzzle of puzzles,
And that we call Being. 610

To be in any form, what is that?
If nothing lay more developed the quahaug and its callous shell were enough.

Mine is no callous shell,
I have instant conductors all over me whether I pass or stop,
They seize every object and lead it harmlessly through me. 615

I merely stir, press, feel with my fingers, and am happy,
To touch my person to some one else's is about as much as I can stand.

Is this then a touch? . . . quivering me to a new identity,
Flames and ether making a rush for my veins,
Treacherous tip of me reaching and crowding to help them, 620
My flesh and blood playing out lightning, to strike what is hardly different
from myself,

On all sides prurient provokers stiffening my limbs,
Straining the udder of my heart for its withheld drip,
Behaving licentious toward me, taking no denial,
Depriving me of my best as for a purpose, 625
Unbuttoning my clothes and holding me by the bare waist,
Deluding my confusion with the calm of the sunlight and pasture fields,
Immodestly sliding the fellow-senses away,
They bribed to swap off with touch, and go and graze at the edges of me,
No consideration, no regard for my draining strength or my anger, 630
Fetching the rest of the herd around to enjoy them awhile,
Then all uniting to stand on a headland and worry me.

The sentries desert every other part of me,
They have left me helpless to a red marauder,
They all come to the headland to witness and assist against me. 635

I am given up by traitors;
I talk wildly . . . I have lost my wits . . . I and nobody else am the greatest
traitor,
I went myself first to the headland . . . my own hands carried me there.

You villain touch! what are you doing? . . . my breath is tight in its throat;
Unclench your floodgates! you are too much for me. 640

Blind loving wrestling touch! Sheathed hooded sharptoothed touch!
Did it make you ache so leaving me?

Parting tracked by arriving . . . perpetual payment of the perpetual loan,
Rich showering rain, and recompense richer afterward.

Sprouts take and accumulate . . . stand by the curb prolific and vital, 645
Landscapes projected masculine full-sized and golden.

All truths wait in all things,
They neither hasten their own delivery nor resist it,
They do not need the obstetric forceps of the surgeon,
The insignificant is as big to me as any, 650
What is less or more than a touch?

Logic and sermons never convince,
The damp of the night drives deeper into my soul.

Only what proves itself to every man and woman is so,
Only what nobody denies is so. 655

A minute and a drop of me settle my brain;
I believe the soggy clods shall become lovers and lamps,
And a compend of compends is the meat of a man or woman,
And a summit and flower there is the feeling they have for each other,
And they are to branch boundlessly out of that lesson until it becomes 660
omnific,
And until every one shall delight us, and we them.

I believe a leaf of grass is no less than the journeywork of the stars,
And the pismire is equally perfect, and a grain of sand, and the egg of the
wren,
And the tree-toad is a chef-d'œuvre for the highest,
And the running blackberry would adorn the parlors of heaven, 665
And the narrowest hinge in my hand puts to scorn all machinery,

And the cow crunching with depressed head surpasses any statue,
And a mouse is miracle enough to stagger sextillions of infidels,
And I could come every afternoon of my life to look at the farmer's girl
boiling her iron tea-kettle and baking shortcake.

I find I incorporate gneiss and coal and long-threaded moss and fruits and
grains and esculent roots,
And am stucco'd with quadrupeds and birds all over,
And have distanced what is behind me for good reasons,
And call any thing close again when I desire it.

In vain the speeding or shyness,
In vain the plutonic rocks send their old heat against my approach,
In vain the mastadon retreats beneath its own powdered bones,
In vain objects stand leagues off and assume manifold shapes,
In vain the ocean settling in hollows and the great monsters lying low,
In vain the buzzard houses herself with the sky,
In vain the snake slides through the creepers and logs,
In vain the elk takes to the inner passes of the woods,
In vain the razorbilled auk sails far north to Labrador,
I follow quickly . . . I ascend to the nest in the fissure of the cliff.

I think I could turn and live awhile with the animals . . . they are so placid
and self-contained,
I stand and look at them sometimes half the day long.

They do not sweat and whine about their condition,
They do not lie awake in the dark and weep for their sins,
They do not make me sick discussing their duty to God,
Not one is dissatisfied . . . not one is demented with the mania of owning
things,
Not one kneels to another nor to his kind that lived thousands of years ago,
Not one is respectable or industrious over the whole earth.

So they show their relations to me and I accept them;
They bring me tokens of myself . . . they evince them plainly in their
possession.

I do not know where they got those tokens,
I must have passed that way untold times ago and negligently dropt them, 695
Myself moving forward then and now and forever,
Gathering and showing more always and with velocity,
Infinite and omnigenous and the like of these among them;
Not too exclusive toward the reachers of my remembrancers,
Picking out here one that shall be my amie, 700
Choosing to go with him on brotherly terms.

A gigantic beauty of a stallion, fresh and responsive to my caresses,
Head high in the forehead and wide between the ears,
Limbs glossy and supple, tail dusting the ground,
Eyes well apart and full of sparkling wickedness . . . ears finely cut and 705
flexibly moving.

His nostrils dilate . . . my heels embrace him . . . his well built limbs tremble
with pleasure . . . we speed around and return.

I but use you a moment and then I resign you stallion . . . and do not need
your paces, and outgallop them,
And myself as I stand or sit pass faster than you.

Swift wind! Space! My Soul! Now I know it is true what I guessed at;
What I guessed when I loafed on the grass, 710
What I guessed while I lay alone in my bed . . . and again as I walked the
beach under the paling stars of the morning.

My ties and ballasts leave me . . . I travel . . . I sail . . . my elbows rest in the
sea-gaps,

I skirt the sierras . . . my palms cover continents,
I am afoot with my vision.

By the city's quadrangular houses . . . in log-huts, or camping with
lumbermen, 715
Along the ruts of the turnpike . . . along the dry gulch and rivulet bed,
Hoeing my onion-patch, and rows of carrots and parsnips . . . crossing
savannas . . . trailing in forests,
Prospecting . . . gold-digging . . . girdling the trees of a new purchase,
Scorched ankle-deep by the hot sand . . . hauling my boat down the shallow
river;
Where the panther walks to and fro on a limb overhead . . . where the buck 720
turns furiously at the hunter,
Where the rattlesnake suns his flabby length on a rock . . . where the otter is
feeding on fish,
Where the alligator in his tough pimples sleeps by the bayou,
Where the black bear is searching for roots or honey . . . where the beaver
pats the mud with his paddle-tail;
Over the growing sugar . . . over the cottonplant . . . over the rice in its low
moist field;
Over the sharp-peaked farmhouse with its scalloped scum and slender 725
shoots from the gutters;
Over the western persimmon . . . over the longleaved corn and the delicate
blueflowered flax;
Over the white and brown buckwheat, a hummer and a buzzer there with the
rest,
Over the dusky green of the rye as it ripples and shades in the breeze;
Scaling mountains . . . pulling myself cautiously up . . . holding on by low
scragged limbs,
Walking the path worn in the grass and beat through the leaves of the brush; 730
Where the quail is whistling betwixt the woods and the wheatlot,
Where the bat flies in the July eve . . . where the great goldbug drops through
the dark;

Where the flails keep time on the barn floor,
 Where the brook puts out of the roots of the old tree and flows to the
 meadow,
 Where cattle stand and shake away flies with the tremulous shuddering of
 their hides, 735
 Where the cheese-cloth hangs in the kitchen, and andirons straddle the
 hearth-slab, and cobwebs fall in festoons from the rafters;
 Where triphammers crash . . . where the press is whirling its cylinders;
 Wherever the human heart beats with terrible throes out of its ribs;
 Where the pear-shaped balloon is floating aloft . . . floating in it myself and
 looking composedly down;
 Where the life-car is drawn on the slipnoose . . . where the heat hatches
 pale-green eggs in the dented sand, 740
 Where the she-whale swims with her calves and never forsakes them,
 Where the steamship trails hindways its long pennant of smoke,
 Where the ground-shark's fin cuts like a black chip out of the water,
 Where the half-burned brig is riding on unknown currents,
 Where shells grow to her slimy deck, and the dead are corrupting below; 745
 Where the striped and starred flag is borne at the head of the regiments;
 Approaching Manhattan, up by the long-stretching island,
 Under Niagara, the cataract falling like a veil over my countenance;
 Upon a door-step . . . upon the horse-block of hard wood outside,
 Upon the race-course, or enjoying pic-nics or jigs or a good game of base- 750
 ball,
 At he-festivals with blackguard jibes and ironical license and bull-dances and
 drinking and laughter,
 At the cider-mill, tasting the sweet of the brown squash . . . sucking the juice
 through a straw,
 At apple-peelings, wanting kisses for all the red fruit I find,
 At musters and beach-parties and friendly bees and huskings and house-
 raisings;
 Where the mockingbird sounds his delicious gurgles, and cackles and 755
 screams and weeps,

Where the hay-rick stands in the barnyard, and the dry-stalks are scattered,
 and the brood-cow waits in the hovel,
 Where the bull advances to do his masculine work, and the stud to the mare,
 and the cock is treading the hen,
 Where the heifers browse, and the geese nip their food with short jerks;
 Where the sundown shadows lengthen over the limitless and lonesome
 prairie,
 Where the herds of buffalo make a crawling spread of the square miles far 760
 and near;
 Where the hummingbird shimmers . . . where the neck of the longlived
 swan is curving and winding;
 Where the laughing-gull scoots by the slappy shore and laughs her near-
 human laugh;
 Where beehives range on a gray bench in the garden half-hid by the high
 weeds;
 Where the band-necked partridges roost in a ring on the ground with their
 heads out;
 Where burial coaches enter the arched gates of a cemetery; 765
 Where winter wolves bark amid wastes of snow and icicled trees;
 Where the yellow-crowned heron comes to the edge of the marsh at night
 and feeds upon small crabs;
 Where the splash of swimmers and divers cools the warm noon;
 Where the katydid works her chromatic reed on the walnut-tree over the
 well;
 Through patches of citrons and cucumbers with silver-wired leaves, 770
 Through the salt-lick or orange glade . . . or under conical firs;
 Through the gymnasium . . . through the curtained saloon . . . through the
 office or public hall;
 Pleased with the native and pleased with the foreign . . . pleased with the
 new and old,
 Pleased with women, the homely as well as the handsome,
 Pleased with the quakeress as she puts off her bonnet and talks melodiously, 775
 Pleased with the primitive tunes of the choir of the whitewashed church,

Pleased with the earnest words of the sweating Methodist preacher, or any
 preacher . . . looking seriously at the camp-meeting;
 Looking in at the shop-windows in Broadway the whole forenoon . . .
 pressing the flesh of my nose to the thick plate-glass,
 Wandering the same afternoon with my face turned up to the clouds;
 My right and left arms round the sides of two friends and I in the middle; 780
 Coming home with the bearded and dark-cheeked bush-boy . . . riding
 behind him at the drape of the day;
 Far from the settlements studying the print of animals' feet, or the moccasin
 print;
 By the cot in the hospital reaching lemonade to a feverish patient,
 By the confined corpse when all is still, examining with a candle;
 Voyaging to every port to dicker and adventure; 785
 Hurrying with the modern crowd, as eager and fickle as any,
 Hot toward one I hate, ready in my madness to knife him;
 Solitary at midnight in my back yard, my thoughts gone from me a long
 while,
 Walking the old hills of Judea with the beautiful gentle god by my side;
 Speeding through space . . . speeding through heaven and the stars, 790
 Speeding amid the seven satellites and the broad ring and the diameter of
 eighty thousand miles,
 Speeding with tailed meteors . . . throwing fire-balls like the rest,
 Carrying the crescent child that carries its own full mother in its belly;
 Storming enjoying planning loving cautioning,
 Backing and filling, appearing and disappearing, 795
 I tread day and night such roads.

I visit the orchards of God and look at the spheric product,
 And look at quintillions ripened, and look at quintillions green.

I fly the flight of the fluid and swallowing soul,
 My course runs below the soundings of plummets. 800

I help myself to material and immaterial,
No guard can shut me off, no law can prevent me.

I anchor my ship for a little while only,
My messengers continually cruise away or bring their returns to me.

I go hunting polar furs and the seal leaping chasms with a pike-pointed
staff clinging to topples of brittle and blue. 805

I ascend to the foretruck I take my place late at night in the crow's nest
we sail through the arctic sea it is plenty light enough,
Through the clear atmosphere I stretch around on the wonderful beauty,
The enormous masses of ice pass me and I pass them the scenery is plain
in all directions,

The white-topped mountains point up in the distance I fling out my
fancies toward them;
We are about approaching some great battlefield in which we are soon to be
engaged, 810

We pass the colossal outposts of the encampments we pass with still feet
and caution;
Or we are entering by the suburbs some vast and ruined city the blocks
and fallen architecture more than all the living cities of the globe.

I am a free companion I bivouac by invading watchfires.

I turn the bridegroom out of bed and stay with the bride myself,
And tighten her all night to my thighs and lips. 815

My voice is the wife's voice, the screech by the rail of the stairs,
They fetch my man's body up dripping and drowned.

I understand the large hearts of heroes,
The courage of present times and all times;

How the skipper saw the crowded and rudderless wreck of the steamship, and 820
 death chasing it up and down the storm,
How he knuckled tight and gave not back one inch, and was faithful of days
 and faithful of nights,
And chalked in large letters on a board, Be of good cheer, We will not desert
 you;
How he saved the drifting company at last,
How the lank loose-gowned women looked when boated from the side of
 their prepared graves,
How the silent old-faced infants, and the lifted sick, and the sharp-lipped 825
 unshaved men;
All this I swallow and it tastes good . . . I like it well, and it becomes mine,
I am the man . . . I suffered . . . I was there.

The disdain and calmness of martyrs,
The mother condemned for a witch and burnt with dry wood, and her
 children gazing on;
The hounded slave that flags in the race and leans by the fence, blowing and 830
 covered with sweat,
The twinges that sting like needles his legs and neck,
The murderous buckshot and the bullets,
All these I feel or am.

I am the hounded slave . . . I wince at the bite of the dogs,
Hell and despair are upon me . . . crack and again crack the marksmen, 835
I clutch the rails of the fence . . . my gore dribs thinned with the ooze of my
 skin,
I fall on the weeds and stones,
The riders spur their unwilling horses and haul close,
They taunt my dizzy ears . . . they beat me violently over the head with their
 whip-stocks.

Agonies are one of my changes of garments;
I do not ask the wounded person how he feels . . . I myself become the
wounded person,
My hurt turns livid upon me as I lean on a cane and observe. 840

I am the mashed fireman with breastbone broken . . . tumbling walls buried
me in their debris,
Heat and smoke I inspired . . . I heard the yelling shouts of my comrades,
I heard the distant click of their picks and shovels;
They have cleared the beams away . . . they tenderly lift me forth. 845

I lie in the night air in my red shirt . . . the pervading hush is for my sake,
Painless after all I lie, exhausted but not so unhappy,
White and beautiful are the faces around me . . . the heads are bared of their
fire-caps,
The kneeling crowd fades with the light of the torches. 850

Distant and dead resuscitate,
They show as the dial or move as the hands of me . . . and I am the clock
myself.

I am an old artillerist, and tell of some fort's bombardment . . . and am there
again.

Again the reveille of drummers . . . again the attacking cannon and mortars
and howitzers,
Again the attacked send their cannon responsive. 855

I take part . . . I see and hear the whole,
The cries and curses and roar . . . the plaudits for well aimed shots,
The ambulanza slowly passing and trailing its red drip,
Workmen searching after damages and to make indispensable repairs,

The fall of grenades through the rent roof . . . the fan-shaped explosion, 860
The whizz of limbs heads stone wood and iron high in the air.

Again gurgles the mouth of my dying general . . . he furiously waves with his
hand,
He gasps through the clot . . . Mind not me . . . mind . . . the
entrenchments.

I tell not the fall of Alamo . . . not one escaped to tell the fall of Alamo,
The hundred and fifty are dumb yet at Alamo. 865

Hear now the tale of a jetblack sunrise,
Hear of the murder in cold blood of four hundred and twelve young men.

Retreating they had formed in a hollow square with their baggage for
breastworks,
Nine hundred lives out of the surrounding enemy's nine times their number
was the price they took in advance,
Their colonel was wounded and their ammunition gone, 870
They treated for an honorable capitulation, received writing and seal, gave up
their arms, and marched back prisoners of war.

They were the glory of the race of rangers,
Matchless with a horse, a rifle, a song, a supper or a courtship,
Large, turbulent, brave, handsome, generous, proud and affectionate,
Bearded, sunburnt, dressed in the free costume of hunters, 875
Not a single one over thirty years of age.

The second Sunday morning they were brought out in squads and massacred
. . . it was beautiful early summer,
The work commenced about five o'clock and was over by eight.

None obeyed the command to kneel,
Some made a mad and helpless rush . . . some stood stark and straight, 880
A few fell at once, shot in the temple or heart . . . the living and dead lay
together,
The maimed and mangled dug in the dirt . . . the new-comers saw them
there;
Some half-killed attempted to crawl away,
These were dispatched with bayonets or battered with the blunts of muskets;
A youth not seventeen years old seized his assassin till two more came to 885
release him,
The three were all torn, and covered with the boy's blood.

At eleven o'clock began the burning of the bodies;
And that is the tale of the murder of the four hundred and twelve young men,
And that was a jetblack sunrise.

Did you read in the seabooks of the oldfashioned frigate-fight? 890
Did you learn who won by the light of the moon and stars?

Our foe was no skulk in his ship, I tell you,
His was the English pluck, and there is no tougher or truer, and never was,
and never will be;
Along the lowered eve he came, horribly raking us.

We closed with him . . . the yards entangled . . . the cannon touched, 895
My captain lashed fast with his own hands.

We had received some eighteen-pound shots under the water,
On our lower-gun-deck two large pieces had burst at the first fire, killing all
around and blowing up overhead.

Ten o'clock at night, and the full moon shining and the leaks on the gain, and
five feet of water reported,

The master-at-arms loosing the prisoners confined in the after-hold to give
them a chance for themselves. 900

The transit to and from the magazine was now stopped by the sentinels,
They saw so many strange faces they did not know whom to trust.

Our frigate was afire . . . the other asked if we demanded quarters? if our
colors were struck and the fighting done?

I laughed content when I heard the voice of my little captain,
We have not struck, he composedly cried, We have just begun our part of the 905
fighting.

Only three guns were in use,
One was directed by the captain himself against the enemy's mainmast,
Two well-served with grape and canister silenced his musketry and cleared
his decks.

The tops alone seconded the fire of this little battery, especially the maintop,
They all held out bravely during the whole of the action. 910

Not a moment's cease,
The leaks gained fast on the pumps . . . the fire eat toward the powder-
magazine,
One of the pumps was shot away . . . it was generally thought we were
sinking.

Serene stood the little captain,
He was not hurried . . . his voice was neither high nor low, 915
His eyes gave more light to us than our battle-lanterns.

Toward twelve at night, there in the beams of the moon they surrendered
to us.

Stretched and still lay the midnight,
 Two great hulls motionless on the breast of the darkness,
 Our vessel riddled and slowly sinking . . . preparations to pass to the one we 920
 had conquered,
 The captain on the quarter deck coldly giving his orders through a
 countenance white as a sheet,
 Near by the corpse of the child that served in the cabin,
 The dead face of an old salt with long white hair and carefully curled
 whiskers,
 The flames spite of all that could be done flickering aloft and below,
 The husky voices of the two or three officers yet fit for duty, 925
 Formless stacks of bodies and bodies by themselves . . . dabs of flesh upon
 the masts and spars,
 The cut of cordage and dangle of rigging . . . the slight shock of the soothe of
 waves,
 Black and impassive guns, and litter of powder-parcels, and the strong scent,
 Delicate sniffs of the seabreeze . . . smells of sedgy grass and fields by the
 shore . . . death-messages given in charge to survivors,
 The hiss of the surgeon's knife and the gnawing teeth of his saw, 930
 The wheeze, the cluck, the swash of falling blood . . . the short wild scream,
 the long dull tapering groan,
 These so . . . these irretrievable.

O Christ! My fit is mastering me!
 What the rebel said gaily adjusting his throat to the rope-noose,
 What the savage at the stump, his eye-sockets empty, his mouth spirting 935
 whoops and defiance,
 What stills the traveler come to the vault at Mount Vernon,
 What sobers the Brooklyn boy as he looks down the shores of the Wallabout
 and remembers the prison ships,
 What burnt the gums of the redcoat at Saratoga when he surrendered his
 brigades,

These become mine and me every one, and they are but little,
I become as much more as I like.

940

I become any presence or truth of humanity here,
And see myself in prison shaped like another man,
And feel the dull unintermitted pain.

For me the keepers of convicts shoulder their carbines and keep watch,
It is I let out in the morning and barred at night.

945

Not a mutineer walks handcuffed to the jail, but I am handcuffed to him and
walk by his side,
I am less the jolly one there, and more the silent one with sweat on my
twitching lips.

Not a youngster is taken for larceny, but I go up too and am tried and
sentenced.

Not a cholera patient lies at the last gasp, but I also lie at the last gasp,
My face is ash-colored, my sinews gnarl . . . away from me people retreat.

950

Askers embody themselves in me, and I am embodied in them,
I project my hat and sit shamefaced and beg.

I rise extatic through all, and sweep with the true gravitation,
The whirling and whirling is elemental within me.

Somehow I have been stunned. Stand back!
Give me a little time beyond my cuffed head and slumbers and dreams and
gaping,
I discover myself on a verge of the usual mistake.

955

That I could forget the mockers and insults!
That I could forget the trickling tears and the blows of the bludgeons and
hammers!
That I could look with a separate look on my own crucifixion and bloody
crowning! 960

I remember . . . I resume the overstaid fraction,
The grave of rock multiplies what has been confided to it . . . or to any
graves,
The corpses rise . . . the gashes heal . . . the fastenings roll away.

I troop forth replenished with supreme power, one of an average unending
procession,
We walk the roads of Ohio and Massachusetts and Virginia and Wisconsin 965
and New York and New Orleans and Texas and Montreal and San
Francisco and Charleston and Savannah and Mexico,
Inland and by the seacoast and boundary lines . . . and we pass the boundary
lines.

Our swift ordinances are on their way over the whole earth,
The blossoms we wear in our hats are the growth of two thousand years.

Eleves I salute you,
I see the approach of your numberless gangs . . . I see you understand 970
yourselves and me,
And know that they who have eyes are divine, and the blind and lame are
equally divine,
And that my steps drag behind yours yet go before them,
And are aware how I am with you no more than I am with everybody.

The friendly and flowing savage . . . Who is he?
Is he waiting for civilization or past it and mastering it? 975

Is he some southwesterner raised outdoors? Is he Canadian?
Is he from the Mississippi country? or from Iowa, Oregon or California? or
from the mountains? or prairie life or bush-life? or from the sea?

Wherever he goes men and women accept and desire him,
They desire he should like them and touch them and speak to them and stay
with them.

Behaviour lawless as snow-flakes . . . words simple as grass . . . uncombed 980
head and laughter and naivete;
Slowstepping feet and the common features, and the common modes and
emanations,
They descend in new forms from the tips of his fingers,
They are wafted with the odor of his body or breath . . . they fly out of the
glance of his eyes.

Flaunt of the sunshine I need not your bask . . . lie over,
You light surfaces only . . . I force the surfaces and the depths also. 985

Earth! you seem to look for something at my hands,
Say old topknot! what do you want?

Man or woman! I might tell how I like you, but cannot,
And might tell what it is in me and what it is in you, but cannot,
And might tell the pinings I have . . . the pulse of my nights and days. 990

Behold I do not give lectures or a little charity,
What I give I give out of myself.

You there, impotent, loose in the knees, open your scarfed chops till I blow
grit within you,
Spread your palms and lift the flaps of your pockets,

I am not to be denied . . . I compel . . . I have stores plenty and to spare,
And any thing I have I bestow.

995

I do not ask who you are . . . that is not important to me,
You can do nothing and be nothing but what I will infold you.

To a drudge of the cottonfields or emptier of privies I lean . . . on his right
cheek I put the family kiss,
And in my soul I swear I never will deny him.

1000

On women fit for conception I start bigger and nimbler babes,
This day I am jetting the stuff of far more arrogant republics.

To any one dying . . . thither I speed and twist the knob of the door,
Turn the bedclothes toward the foot of the bed,
Let the physician and the priest go home.

1005

I seize the descending man . . . I raise him with resistless will.

O despairer, here is my neck,
By God! you shall not go down! Hang your whole weight upon me.

I dilate you with tremendous breath . . . I buoy you up;
Every room of the house do I fill with an armed force . . . lovers of me,
bafflers of graves:

1010

Sleep! I and they keep guard all night;
Not doubt, not decease shall dare to lay finger upon you,
I have embraced you, and henceforth possess you to myself,
And when you rise in the morning you will find what I tell you is so.

I am he bringing help for the sick as they pant on their backs,
And for strong upright men I bring yet more needed help.

1015

I heard what was said of the universe,
Heard it and heard of several thousand years;
It is middling well as far as it goes . . . but is that all?

Magnifying and applying come I, 1020
Outbidding at the start the old cautious hucksters,
The most they offer for mankind and eternity less than a spirt of my own
 seminal wet,
Taking myself the exact dimensions of Jehovah and laying them away,
Lithographing Kronos and Zeus his son, and Hercules his grandson,
Buying drafts of Osiris and Isis and Belus and Brahma and Adonai, 1025
In my portfolio placing Manito loose, and Allah on a leaf, and the crucifix
 engraved,
With Odin, and the hideous-faced Mexitli, and all idols and images,
Honestly taking them all for what they are worth, and not a cent more,
Admitting they were alive and did the work of their day,
Admitting they bore mites as for unfledged birds who have now to rise and 1030
 fly and sing for themselves,
Accepting the rough deific sketches to fill out better in myself . . . bestowing
 them freely on each man and woman I see,
Discovering as much or more in a framer framing a house,
Putting higher claims for him there with his rolled-up sleeves, driving the
 mallet and chisel;
Not objecting to special revelations . . . considering a curl of smoke or a hair
 on the back of my hand as curious as any revelation;
Those ahold of fire-engines and hook-and-ladder ropes more to me than the 1035
 gods of the antique wars,
Minding their voices peal through the crash of destruction,
Their brawny limbs passing safe over charred laths . . . their white foreheads
 whole and unhurt out of the flames;
By the mechanic's wife with her babe at her nipple interceding for every
 person born;

Three scythes at harvest whizzing in a row from three lusty angels with shirts
 bagged out at their waists;
 The snag-toothed hostler with red hair redeeming sins past and to come, 1040
 Selling all he possesses and traveling on foot to fee lawyers for his brother and
 sit by him while he is tried for forgery:
 What was strewn in the amplest strewing the square rod about me, and not
 filling the square rod then;
 The bull and the bug never worshipped half enough,
 Dung and dirt more admirable than was dreamed,
 The supernatural of no account . . . myself waiting my time to be one of the 1045
 supremes,
 The day getting ready for me when I shall do as much good as the best, and
 be as prodigious,
 Guessing when I am it will not tickle me much to receive puffs out of pulpit
 or print;
 By my life-lumps! becoming already a creator!
 Putting myself here and now to the ambushed womb of the shadows!

. . . A call in the midst of the crowd, 1050
 My own voice, orotund sweeping and final.

Come my children,
 Come my boys and girls, and my women and household and intimates,
 Now the performer launches his nerve . . . he has passed his prelude on the
 reeds within.

Easily written loosefingered chords! I feel the thrum of their climax and 1055
 close.

My head evolves on my neck,
 Music rolls, but not from the organ . . . folks are around me, but they are no
 household of mine.

Ever the hard and unsunk ground,
Ever the eaters and drinkers . . . ever the upward and downward sun . . .
 ever the air and the ceaseless tides,
Ever myself and my neighbors, refreshing and wicked and real, 1060
Ever the old inexplicable query . . . ever that thorned thumb—that breath of
 itches and thirsts,
Ever the vexer's hoot! hoot! till we find where the sly one hides and bring him
 forth;
Ever love . . . ever the sobbing liquid of life,
Ever the bandage under the chin . . . ever the tressels of death.

Here and there with dimes on the eyes walking, 1065
To feed the greed of the belly the brains liberally spooning,
Tickets buying or taking or selling, but in to the feast never once going;
Many sweating and ploughing and thrashing, and then the chaff for payment
 receiving,
A few idly owning, and they the wheat continually claiming.

This is the city . . . and I am one of the citizens; 1070
Whatever interests the rest interests me . . . politics, churches, newspapers,
 schools,
Benevolent societies, improvements, banks, tariffs, steamships, factories,
 markets,
Stocks and stores and real estate and personal estate.

They who piddle and patter here in collars and tailed coats . . . I am aware
 who they are . . . and that they are not worms or fleas,
I acknowledge the duplicates of myself under all the scrape-lipped and 1075
 pipe-legged concealments.

The weakest and shallowest is deathless with me,
What I do and say the same waits for them,
Every thought that flounders in me the same flounders in them.

I know perfectly well my own egotism,
And know my omniverous words, and cannot say any less, 1080
And would fetch you whoever you are flush with myself.

My words are words of a questioning, and to indicate reality;
This printed and bound book . . . but the printer and the printing-office boy?
The marriage estate and settlement . . . but the body and mind of the
 bridegroom? also those of the bride?
The panorama of the sea . . . but the sea itself? 1085
The well-taken photographs . . . but your wife or friend close and solid in
 your arms?
The fleet of ships of the line and all the modern improvements . . . but the
 craft and pluck of the admiral?
The dishes and fare and furniture . . . but the host and hostess, and the look
 out of their eyes?
The sky up there . . . yet here or next door or across the way?
The saints and sages in history . . . but you yourself? 1090
Sermons and creeds and theology . . . but the human brain, and what is
 called reason, and what is called love, and what is called life?

I do not despise you priests;
My faith is the greatest of faiths and the least of faiths,
Enclosing all worship ancient and modern, and all between ancient and
 modern,
Believing I shall come again upon the earth after five thousand years, 1095
Waiting responses from oracles . . . honoring the gods . . . saluting the sun,
Making a fetish of the first rock or stump . . . powowing with sticks in the
 circle of obis,
Helping the lama or brahmin as he trims the lamps of the idols,
Dancing yet through the streets in a phallic procession . . . rapt and austere
 in the woods, a gymnosophist,
Drinking mead from the skull-cup . . . to shasta and vedas admiranant . . . 1100
 minding the koran,

Walking the teokallis, spotted with gore from the stone and knife—beating
the serpent-skin drum;
Accepting the gospels, accepting him that was crucified, knowing assuredly
that he is divine,
To the mass kneeling—to the puritan's prayer rising—sitting patiently in a
pew,
Ranting and frothing in my insane crisis—waiting dead-like till my spirit
arouses me;
Looking forth on pavement and land, and outside of pavement and land,
Belonging to the winders of the circuit of circuits.

1105

One of that centripetal and centrifugal gang,
I turn and talk like a man leaving charges before a journey.

Down-hearted doubters, dull and excluded,
Frivolous sullen moping angry affected disheartened atheistical,
I know every one of you, and know the unspoken interrogatories,
By experience I know them.

1110

How the flukes splash!
How they contort rapid as lightning, with spasms and spouts of blood!

Be at peace bloody flukes of doubters and sullen mopers,
I take my place among you as much as among any;
The past is the push of you and me and all precisely the same,
And the night is for you and me and all,
And what is yet untried and afterward is for you and me and all.

1115

I do not know what is untried and afterward,
But I know it is sure and alive and sufficient.

1120

Each who passes is considered, and each who stops is considered, and not a
single one can it fail.

It cannot fail the young man who died and was buried,
Nor the young woman who died and was put by his side,
Nor the little child that peeped in at the door and then drew back and was
 never seen again,
Nor the old man who has lived without purpose, and feels it with bitterness
 worse than gall,
Nor him in the poorhouse tubercled by rum and the bad disorder,
Nor the numberless slaughtered and wrecked . . . nor the brutish koboo,
 called the ordure of humanity,
Nor the sacs merely floating with open mouths for food to slip in,
Nor any thing in the earth, or down in the oldest graves of the earth,
Nor any thing in the myriads of spheres, nor one of the myriads of myriads
 that inhabit them,
Nor the present, nor the least wisp that is known.

It is time to explain myself . . . let us stand up.

The clock indicates the moment . . . but what does eternity indicate?

Eternity lies in bottomless reservoirs . . . its buckets are rising forever and ever,
They pour and they pour and they exhale away.

Births have brought us richness and variety,
And other births will bring us richness and variety.

I do not call one greater and one smaller,
That which fills its period and place is equal to any.

Were mankind murderous or jealous upon you my brother or my sister?
I am sorry for you . . . they are not murderous or jealous upon me; 1145
All has been gentle with me I keep no account with lamentation;
What have I to do with lamentation?

I am an acme of things accomplished, and I an encloser of things to be.

My feet strike an apex of the apices of the stairs,
On every step bunches of ages, and larger bunches between the steps, 1150
All below duly traveled—and still I mount and mount.

Rise after rise bow the phantoms behind me,
Afar down I see the huge first Nothing, the vapor from the nostrils of death,
I know I was even there . . . I waited unseen and always,
And slept while God carried me through the lethargic mist, 1155
And took my time . . . and took no hurt from the foetid carbon.

Long I was hugged close . . . long and long.

Immense have been the preparations for me,
Faithful and friendly the arms that have helped me.

Cycles ferried my cradle, rowing and rowing like cheerful boatmen; 1160
For room to me stars kept aside in their own rings,
They sent influences to look after what was to hold me.

Before I was born out of my mother generations guided me,
My embryo has never been torpid . . . nothing could overlay it;
For it the nebula cohered to an orb . . . the long slow strata piled to rest it on 1165
. . . vast vegetables gave it sustenance,
Monstrous sauroids transported it in their mouths and deposited it with care.

All forces have been steadily employed to complete and delight me,
Now I stand on this spot with my soul.

Span of youth! Ever-pushed elasticity! Manhood balanced and florid and full!

My lovers suffocate me!

1170

Crowding my lips, and thick in the pores of my skin,

Jostling me through streets and public halls . . . coming naked to me at
night,

Crying by day Ahoy from the rocks of the river . . . swinging and chirping
over my head,

Calling my name from flowerbeds or vines or tangled underbrush,

Or while I swim in the bath . . . or drink from the pump at the corner . . . or
the curtain is down at the opera . . . or I glimpse at a woman's face in
the railroad car;

1175

Lighting on every moment of my life,

Bussing my body with soft and balsamic busses,

Noiselessly passing handfuls out of their hearts and giving them to be mine.

Old age superbly rising! Ineffable grace of dying days!

Every condition promulges not only itself . . . it promulges what grows after
and out of itself,

1180

And the dark hush promulges as much as any.

I open my scuttle at night and see the far-sprinkled systems,

And all I see, multiplied as high as I can cipher, edge but the rim of the
farther systems.

Wider and wider they spread, expanding and always expanding,

Outward and outward and forever outward.

1185

My sun has his sun, and round him obediently wheels,
He joins with his partners a group of superior circuit,
And greater sets follow, making specks of the greatest inside them.

There is no stoppage, and never can be stoppage;
If I and you and the worlds and all beneath or upon their surfaces, and all the 1190
palpable life, were this moment reduced back to a pallid float, it would
not avail in the long run,
We should surely bring up again where we now stand,
And as surely go as much farther, and then farther and farther.

A few quadrillions of eras, a few octillions of cubic leagues, do not hazard the
span, or make it impatient,
They are but parts . . . any thing is but a part.

See ever so far . . . there is limitless space outside of that, 1195
Count ever so much . . . there is limitless time around that.

Our rendezvous is fitly appointed . . . God will be there and wait till we
come.

I know I have the best of time and space—and that I was never measured,
and never will be measured.

I tramp a perpetual journey,
My signs are a rain-proof coat and good shoes and a staff cut from the woods; 1200
No friend of mine takes his ease in my chair,
I have no chair, nor church nor philosophy;
I lead no man to a dinner-table or library or exchange,
But each man and each woman of you I lead upon a knoll,
My left hand hooks you round the waist, 1205
My right hand points to landscapes of continents, and a plain public road.

Not I, not any one else can travel that road for you,
You must travel it for yourself.

It is not far . . . it is within reach,
Perhaps you have been on it since you were born, and did not know, 1210
Perhaps it is every where on water and on land.

Shoulder your duds, and I will mine, and let us hasten forth;
Wonderful cities and free nations we shall fetch as we go.

If you tire, give me both burdens, and rest the chuff of your hand on my hip,
And in due time you shall repay the same service to me; 1215
For after we start we never lie by again.

This day before dawn I ascended a hill and looked at the crowded heaven,
And I said to my spirit, When we become the enfolders of those orbs and the
pleasure and knowledge of every thing in them, shall we be filled and
satisfied then?
And my spirit said No, we level that lift to pass and continue beyond.

You are also asking me questions, and I hear you; 1220
I answer that I cannot answer . . . you must find out for yourself.

Sit awhile wayfarer,
Here are biscuits to eat and here is milk to drink,
But as soon as you sleep and renew yourself in sweet clothes I will certainly
kiss you with my goodbye kiss and open the gate for your egress hence.

Long enough have you dreamed contemptible dreams, 1225
Now I wash the gum from your eyes,
You must habit yourself to the dazzle of the light and of every moment of
your life

Long have you timidly waded, holding a plank by the shore,
Now I will you to be a bold swimmer,
To jump off in the midst of the sea, and rise again and nod to me and shout, 1230
and laughingly dash with your hair.

I am the teacher of athletes,
He that by me spreads a wider breast than my own proves the width of my
own,
He most honors my style who learns under it to destroy the teacher.

The boy I love, the same becomes a man not through derived power but in
his own right,
Wicked, rather than virtuous out of conformity or fear, 1235
Fond of his sweetheart, relishing well his steak,
Unrequited love or a slight cutting him worse than a wound cuts,
First rate to ride, to fight, to hit the bull's eye, to sail a skiff, to sing a song or
play on the banjo,
Preferring scars and faces pitted with smallpox over all latherers and those
that keep out of the sun.

I teach straying from me, yet who can stray from me? 1240
I follow you whoever you are from the present hour;
My words itch at your ears till you understand them.

I do not say these things for a dollar, or to fill up the time while I wait for a
boat;
It is you talking just as much as myself . . . I act as the tongue of you,
It was tied in your mouth . . . in mine it begins to be loosened. 1245

I swear I will never mention love or death inside a house,
And I swear I never will translate myself at all, only to him or her who
privately stays with me in the open air.

If you would understand me go to the heights or water-shore,
The nearest gnat is an explanation and a drop or the motion of waves a key,
The maul the oar and the handsaw second my words.

1250

No shuttered room or school can commune with me,
But roughs and little children better than they.

The young mechanic is closest to me . . . he knows me pretty well,
The woodman that takes his axe and jug with him shall take me with him all
day,

1255

The farmboy ploughing in the field feels good at the sound of my voice,
In vessels that sail my words must sail . . . I go with fishermen and seamen,
and love them,

My face rubs to the hunter's face when he lies down alone in his blanket,
The driver thinking of me does not mind the jolt of his wagon,
The young mother and old mother shall comprehend me,
The girl and the wife rest the needle a moment and forget where they are,
They and all would resume what I have told them.

1260

I have said that the soul is not more than the body,
And I have said that the body is not more than the soul,
And nothing, not God, is greater to one than one's-self is,
And whoever walks a furlong without sympathy walks to his own funeral,
dressed in his shroud,

1265

And I or you pocketless of a dime may purchase the pick of the earth,
And to glance with an eye or show a bean in its pod confounds the learning
of all times,

And there is no trade or employment but the young man following it may
become a hero,

And there is no object so soft but it makes a hub for the wheeled universe,
And any man or woman shall stand cool and supercilious before a million
universes.

1270

And I call to mankind, Be not curious about God,
For I who am curious about each am not curious about God,
No array of terms can say how much I am at peace about God and about
death.

I hear and behold God in every object, yet I understand God not in the least,
Nor do I understand who there can be more wonderful than myself.

1275

Why should I wish to see God better than this day?
I see something of God each hour of the twenty-four, and each moment then,
In the faces of men and women I see God, and in my own face in the glass;
I find letters from God dropped in the street, and every one is signed by
God's name,
And I leave them where they are, for I know that others will punctually come
forever and ever.

1280

And as to you death, and you bitter hug of mortality . . . it is idle to try to
alarm me.

To his work without flinching the accoucheur comes,
I see the elderhand pressing receiving supporting,
I recline by the sills of the exquisite flexible doors . . . and mark the outlet,
and mark the relief and escape.

And as to you corpse I think you are good manure, but that does not offend
me,

1285

I smell the white roses sweetscented and growing,
I reach to the leafy lips . . . I reach to the polished breasts of melons.

And as to you life, I reckon you are the leavings of many deaths,
No doubt I have died myself ten thousand times before.

I hear you whispering there O stars of heaven, 1290
O suns . . . O grass of graves . . . O perpetual transfers and promotions . . .
if you do not say anything how can I say anything?

Of the turbid pool that lies in the autumn forest,
Of the moon that descends the steeps of the sougning twilight,
Toss, sparkles of day and dusk . . . toss on the black stems that decay in the muck,
Toss to the moaning gibberish of the dry limbs. 1295

I ascend from the moon . . . I ascend from the night,
And perceive of the ghastly glitter the sunbeams reflected,
And debouch to the steady and central from the offspring great or small.

There is that in me . . . I do not know what it is . . . but I know it is in me.

Wrenched and sweaty . . . calm and cool then my body becomes; 1300
I sleep . . . I sleep long.

I do not know it . . . it is without name . . . it is a word unsaid,
It is not in any dictionary or utterance or symbol.

Something it swings on more than the earth I swing on,
To it the creation is the friend whose embracing awakes me. 1305

Perhaps I might tell more . . . Outlines! I plead for my brothers and sisters.

Do you see O my brothers and sisters?
It is not chaos or death . . . it is form and union and plan . . . it is eternal life
. . . it is happiness.

The past and present wilt . . . I have filled them and emptied them,
And proceed to fill my next fold of the future. 1310

Listener up there! Here you . . . what have you to confide to me?
Look in my face while I snuff the sidle of evening,
Talk honestly, for no one else hears you, and I stay only a minute longer.

Do I contradict myself?
Very well then . . . I contradict myself;
I am large . . . I contain multitudes.

1315

I concentrate toward them that are nigh . . . I wait on the door-slab.

Who has done his day's work and will soonest be through with his supper?
Who wishes to walk with me?

Will you speak before I am gone? Will you prove already too late?

1320

The spotted hawk swoops by and accuses me . . . he complains of my gab and
my loitering.

I too am not a bit tamed . . . I too am untranslatable,
I sound my barbaric yawp over the roofs of the world.

The last scud of day holds back for me,
It flings my likeness after the rest and true as any on the shadowed wilds,
It coaxes me to the vapor and the dusk.

1325

I depart as air . . . I shake my white locks at the runaway sun,
I effuse my flesh in eddies and drift it in lacy jags.

I bequeath myself to the dirt to grow from the grass I love,
If you want me again look for me under your bootsoles.

1330

You will hardly know who I am or what I mean,
But I shall be good health to you nevertheless,
And filter and fibre your blood.

Failing to fetch me at first keep encouraged,
Missing me one place search another,
I stop some where waiting for you

1335

s · o · n · g *of* m · y · s · e · l · f

Deathbed Edition: 1891

~ 1 ~

I celebrate myself, and sing myself,
And what I assume you shall assume,
For every atom belonging to me as good belongs to you.

I loafe and invite my soul,
I lean and loafe at my ease observing a spear of summer grass.

5

My tongue, every atom of my blood, form'd from this soil, this air,
Born here of parents born here from parents the same, and their parents the
same,
I, now thirty-seven years old in perfect health begin,
Hoping to cease not till death.

Creeds and schools in abeyance,
Retiring back a while sufficed at what they are, but never forgotten,
I harbor for good or bad, I permit to speak at every hazard,
Nature without check with original energy.

10

~ 2 ~

Houses and rooms are full of perfumes, the shelves are crowded with
perfumes,
I breathe the fragrance myself and know it and like it,
The distillation would intoxicate me also, but I shall not let it.

The atmosphere is not a perfume, it has no taste of the distillation, it is
odorless,
It is for my mouth forever, I am in love with it, 5
I will go to the bank by the wood and become undisguised and naked,
I am mad for it to be in contact with me.

The smoke of my own breath,
Echoes, ripples, buzz'd whispers, love-root, silk-thread, crotch and vine,
My respiration and inspiration, the beating of my heart, the passing of blood 10
and air through my lungs,
The sniff of green leaves and dry leaves, and of the shore and dark-color'd sea-
rocks, and of hay in the barn,
The sound of the belch'd words of my voice loos'd to the eddies of the wind,
A few light kisses, a few embraces, a reaching around of arms,
The play of shine and shade on the trees as the supple boughs wag,
The delight alone or in the rush of the streets, or along the fields and hill- 15
sides,
The feeling of health, the full-noon trill, the song of me rising from bed and
meeting the sun.

Have you reckon'd a thousand acres much? have you reckon'd the earth
much?
Have you practis'd so long to learn to read?
Have you felt so proud to get at the meaning of poems?

Stop this day and night with me and you shall possess the origin of all poems, 20
You shall possess the good of the earth and sun, (there are millions of suns
left,)
You shall no longer take things at second or third hand, nor look through the
eyes of the dead, nor feed on the spectres in books,
You shall not look through my eyes either, nor take things from me,
You shall listen to all sides and filter them from your self.

I have heard what the talkers were talking, the talk of the beginning and the
end,

But I do not talk of the beginning or the end.

There was never any more inception than there is now,
Nor any more youth or age than there is now,
And will never be any more perfection than there is now,
Nor any more heaven or hell than there is now.

5

Urge and urge and urge,
Always the procreant urge of the world.

Out of the dimness opposite equals advance, always substance and increase,
always sex,
Always a knit of identity, always distinction, always a breed of life.

10

To elaborate is no avail, learn'd and unlearn'd feel that it is so.

Sure as the most certain sure, plumb in the uprights, well entretied, braced in
the beams,
Stout as a horse, affectionate, haughty, electrical,
I and this mystery here we stand.

Clear and sweet is my soul, and clear and sweet is all that is not my soul.

15

Lack one lacks both, and the unseen is proved by the seen,
Till that becomes unseen and receives proof in its turn.

Showing the best and dividing it from the worst age vexes age,
Knowing the perfect fitness and equanimity of things, while they discuss I
am silent, and go bathe and admire myself.

Welcome is every organ and attribute of me, and of any man hearty and clean, 20
Not an inch nor a particle of an inch is vile, and none shall be less familiar
than the rest.

I am satisfied—I see, dance, laugh, sing;
As the hugging and loving bed-fellow sleeps at my side through the night,
and withdraws at the peep of the day with stealthy tread,
Leaving me baskets cover'd with white towels swelling the house with their
plenty,
Shall I postpone my acceptation and realization and scream at my eyes, 25
That they turn from gazing after and down the road,
And forthwith cipher and show me to a cent,
Exactly the value of one and exactly the value of two, and which is ahead?

~ 4 ~

Trippers and askers surround me,
People I meet, the effect upon me of my early life or the ward and city I live
in, or the nation,
The latest dates, discoveries, inventions, societies, authors old and new,
My dinner, dress, associates, looks, compliments, dues,
The real or fancied indifference of some man or woman I love, 5
The sickness of one of my folks or of myself, or ill-doing or loss or lack of
money, or depressions or exaltations,
Battles, the horrors of fratricidal war, the fever of doubtful news, the fitful
events;
These come to me days and nights and go from me again,
But they are not the Me myself.

Apart from the pulling and hauling stands what I am, 10
Stands amused, complacent, compassionating, idle, unitary,
Looks down, is erect, or bends an arm on an impalpable certain rest,
Looking with side-curved head curious what will come next,
Both in and out of the game and watching and wondering at it.

Backward I see in my own days where I sweated through fog with linguists 15
and contenders,
I have no mockings or arguments, I witness and wait.

~ 5 ~

I believe in you my soul, the other I am must not abase itself to you,
And you must not be abased to the other.

Loafe with me on the grass, loose the stop from your throat,
Not words, not music or rhyme I want, not custom or lecture, not even the
best,
Only the lull I like, the hum of your valved voice. 5

I mind how once we lay such a transparent summer morning,
How you settled your head athwart my hips and gently turn'd over upon me,
And parted the shirt from my bosom-bone, and plunged your tongue to my
bare-stript heart,
And reach'd till you felt my beard, and reach'd till you held my feet.

Swiftly arose and spread around me the peace and knowledge that pass all the 10
argument of the earth,
And I know that the hand of God is the promise of my own,
And I know that the spirit of God is the brother of my own,
And that all the men ever born are also my brothers, and the women my
sisters and lovers,
And that a kelson of the creation is love,
And limitless are leaves stiff or drooping in the fields, 15
And brown ants in the little wells beneath them,
And mossy scabs of the worm fence, heap'd stones, elder, mullein and
poke-weed.

A child said *What is the grass?* fetching it to me with full hands;
How could I answer the child? I do not know what it is any more than he.

I guess it must be the flag of my disposition, out of hopeful green stuff woven.

Or I guess it is the handkerchief of the Lord,
A scented gift and remembrancer designedly dropt, 5
Bearing the owner's name someway in the corners, that we may see and
remark, and say *Whose?*

Or I guess the grass is itself a child, the produced babe of the vegetation.

Or I guess it is a uniform hieroglyphic,
And it means, Sprouting alike in broad zones and narrow zones,
Growing among black folks as among white, 10
Kanuck, Tuckahoe, Congressman, Cuff, I give them the same, I receive them
the same.

And now it seems to me the beautiful uncut hair of graves.

Tenderly will I use you curling grass,
It may be you transpire from the breasts of young men,
It may be if I had known them I would have loved them,
It may be you are from old people, or from offspring taken soon out of their 15
mothers' laps,
And here you are the mothers' laps.

This grass is very dark to be from the white heads of old mothers,
Darker than the colorless beards of old men,
Dark to come from under the faint red roofs of mouths. 20

O I perceive after all so many uttering tongues,
And I perceive they do not come from the roofs of mouths for nothing.

I wish I could translate the hints about the dead young men and women,
And the hints about old men and mothers, and the offspring taken soon out
of their laps.

What do you think has become of the young and old men?
And what do you think has become of the women and children?

25

They are alive and well somewhere,
The smallest sprout shows there is really no death,
And if ever there was it led forward life, and does not wait at the end to arrest
it,
And ceas'd the moment life appear'd.

30

All goes onward and outward, nothing collapses,
And to die is different from what any one supposed, and luckier.

~ 7 ~

Has any one supposed it lucky to be born?
I hasten to inform him or her it is just as lucky to die, and I know it.

I pass death with the dying and birth with the new-wash'd babe, and am not
contain'd between my hat and boots,
And peruse manifold objects, no two alike and every one good,
The earth good and the stars good, and their adjuncts all good.

5

I am not an earth nor an adjunct of an earth,
I am the mate and companion of people, all just as immortal and fathomless
as myself,
(They do not know how immortal, but I know.)

Every kind for itself and its own, for me mine male and female,
For me those that have been boys and that love women, 10
For me the man that is proud and feels how it stings to be slighted,
For me the sweet-heart and the old maid, for me mothers and the mothers of
mothers,
For me lips that have smiled, eyes that have shed tears,
For me children and the begetters of children.

Undrape! you are not guilty to me, nor stale nor discarded, 15
I see through the broadcloth and gingham whether or no,
And am around, tenacious, acquisitive, tireless, and cannot be shaken away.

~ 8 ~

The little one sleeps in its cradle,
I lift the gauze and look a long time, and silently brush away flies with my hand.

The youngster and the red-faced girl turn aside up the bushy hill,
I peeringly view them from the top.

The suicide sprawls on the bloody floor of the bedroom, 5
I witness the corpse with its dabbled hair, I note where the pistol has fallen.

The blab of the pave, tires of carts, sluff of boot-soles, talk of the
promenaders,
The heavy omnibus, the driver with his interrogating thumb, the clank of the
shod horses on the granite floor,
The snow-sleighs, clinking, shouted jokes, pelts of snow-balls,
The hurrahs for popular favorites, the fury of rous'd mobs, 10
The flap of the curtain'd litter, a sick man inside borne to the hospital,
The meeting of enemies, the sudden oath, the blows and fall,
The excited crowd, the policeman with his star quickly working his passage to
the centre of the crowd,
The impassive stones that receive and return so many echoes,

What groans of over-fed or half-starv'd who fall sunstruck or in fits, 15
What exclamations of women taken suddenly who hurry home and give
 birth to babes,
What living and buried speech is always vibrating here, what howls restrain'd
 by decorum,
Arrests of criminals, slights, adulterous offers made, acceptances, rejections
 with convex lips,
I mind them or the show or resonance of them—I come and I depart.

~ 9 ~

The big doors of the country barn stand open and ready,
The dried grass of the harvest-time loads the slow-drawn wagon,
The clear light plays on the brown gray and green intertinged,
The armfuls are pack'd to the sagging mow.

I am there, I help, I came stretch'd atop of the load, 5
I felt its soft jolts, one leg reclined on the other,
I jump from the cross-beams and seize the clover and timothy,
And roll head over heels and tangle my hair full of wisps.

~ 10 ~

Alone far in the wilds and mountains I hunt,
Wandering amazed at my own lightness and glee,
In the late afternoon choosing a safe spot to pass the night,
Kindling a fire and broiling the fresh-kill'd game,
Falling asleep on the gather'd leaves with my dog and gun by my side. 5

The Yankee clipper is under her sky-sails, she cuts the sparkle and scud,
My eyes settle the land, I bend at her prow or shout joyously from the deck.

The boatmen and clam-diggers arose early and stopt for me,
I tuck'd my trowser-ends in my boots and went and had a good time;
You should have been with us that day round the chowder-kettle. 10

I saw the marriage of the trapper in the open air in the far west, the bride was
a red girl,
Her father and his friends sat near cross-legged and dumbly smoking, they
had moccasins to their feet and large thick blankets hanging from their
shoulders,
On a bank lounged the trapper, he was drest mostly in skins, his luxuriant
beard and curls protected his neck, he held his bride by the hand,
She had long eyelashes, her head was bare, her coarse straight locks
descended upon her voluptuous limbs and reach'd to her feet.

The runaway slave came to my house and stopt outside, 15
I heard his motions crackling the twigs of the woodpile,
Through the swung half-door of the kitchen I saw him limpsy and weak,
And went where he sat on a log and led him in and assured him,
And brought water and fill'd a tub for his sweated body and bruise'd feet,
And gave him a room that enter'd from my own, and gave him some coarse 20
clean clothes,
And remember perfectly well his revolving eyes and his awkwardness,
And remember putting plasters on the galls of his neck and ankles;
He staid with me a week before he was recuperated and pass'd north,
I had him sit next me at table, my fire-lock lean'd in the corner.

~ 11 ~

Twenty-eight young men bathe by the shore,
Twenty-eight young men and all so friendly;
Twenty-eight years of womanly life and all so lonesome.

She owns the fine house by the rise of the bank,
She hides handsome and richly drest aft the blinds of the window. 5

Which of the young men does she like the best?
Ah the homeliest of them is beautiful to her.

Where are you off to, lady? for I see you,
You splash in the water there, yet stay stock still in your room.

Dancing and laughing along the beach came the twenty-ninth bather, 10
The rest did not see her, but she saw them and loved them.

The beards of the young men glisten'd with wet, it ran from their long hair,
Little streams pass'd all over their bodies.

An unseen hand also pass'd over their bodies,
It descended tremblingly from their temples and ribs. 15

The young men float on their backs, their white bellies bulge to the sun, they
do not ask who seizes fast to them,
They do not know who puffs and declines with pendant and bending arch,
They do not think whom they souse with spray.

~ 12 ~

The butcher-boy puts off his killing-clothes, or sharpens his knife at the stall
in the market,
I loiter enjoying his repartee and his shuffle and break-down.

Blacksmiths with grimed and hairy chests environ the anvil,
Each has his main-sledge, they are all out, there is a great heat in the fire.

From the cinder-strew'd threshold I follow their movements, 5
The lithe sheer of their waists plays even with their massive arms,
Overhand the hammers swing, overhand so slow, overhand so sure,
They do not hasten, each man hits in his place.

~ 13 ~

The negro holds firmly the reins of his four horses, the block swags
underneath on its tied-over chain,

The negro that drives the long dray of the stone-yard, steady and tall he
stands pois'd on one leg on the string-piece,
His blue shirt exposes his ample neck and breast and loosens over his
hip-band,
His glance is calm and commanding, he tosses the slouch of his hat away
from his forehead,
The sun falls on his crispy hair and mustache, falls on the black of his polish'd 5
and perfect limbs.

I behold the picturesque giant and love him, and I do not stop there,
I go with the team also.

In me the caresser of life wherever moving, backward as well as forward
sluing,
To niches aside and junior bending, not a person or object missing,
Absorbing all to myself and for this song. 10

Oxen that rattle the yoke and chain or halt in the leafy shade, what is that you
express in your eyes?
It seems to me more than all the print I have read in my life.

My tread scares the wood-drake and wood-duck on my distant and day-long
ramble,
They rise together, they slowly circle around.

I believe in those wing'd purposes, 15
And acknowledge red, yellow, white, playing within me,
And consider green and violet and the tufted crown intentional,
And do not call the tortoise unworthy because she is not something else,
And the jay in the woods never studied the gamut, yet trills pretty well to me,
And the look of the bay mare shames silliness out of me. 20

~ 14 ~

The wild gander leads his flock through the cool night,
Ya-honk he says, and sounds it down to me like an invitation,
The pert may suppose it meaningless, but I listening close,
Find its purpose and place up there toward the wintry sky.

The sharp-hoof'd moose of the north, the cat on the house-sill, the chickadee, 5
the prairie-dog,

The litter of the grunting sow as they tug at her teats,
The brood of the turkey-hen and she with her half-spread wings,
I see in them and myself the same old law.

The press of my foot to the earth springs a hundred affections,
They scorn the best I can do to relate them. 10

I am enamour'd of growing out-doors,
Of men that live among cattle or taste of the ocean or woods,
Of the builders and steerers of ships and the wielders of axes and mauls, and
the drivers of horses,
I can eat and sleep with them week in and week out.

What is commonest, cheapest, nearest, easiest, is Me, 15
Me going in for my chances, spending for vast returns,
Adorning myself to bestow myself on the first that will take me,
Not asking the sky to come down to my good will,
Scattering it freely forever.

~ 15 ~

The pure contralto sings in the organ loft,
The carpenter dresses his plank, the tongue of his foreplane whistles its wild
ascending lisp,
The married and unmarried children ride home to their Thanksgiving dinner,
The pilot seizes the king-pin, he heaves down with a strong arm,

The mate stands braced in the whale-boat, lance and harpoon are ready, 5
 The duck-shooter walks by silent and cautious stretches,
 The deacons are ordain'd with cross'd hands at the altar,
 The spinning-girl retreats and advances to the hum of the big wheel,
 The farmer stops by the bars as he walks on a First-day loafe and looks at the
 oats and rye,
 The lunatic is carried at last to the asylum a confirm'd case, 10
 (He will never sleep any more as he did in the cot in his mother's bed-room;)
 The jour printer with gray head and gaunt jaws works at his case,
 He turns his quid of tobacco while his eyes blurr with the manuscript;
 The malform'd limbs are tied to the surgeon's table,
 What is removed drops horribly in a pail; 15
 The quadroon girl is sold at the auction-stand, the drunkard nods by the
 bar-room stove,
 The machinist rolls up his sleeves, the policeman travels his beat, the gate-
 keeper marks who pass,
 The young fellow drives the express-wagon, (I love him, though I do not
 know him;)
 The half-breed straps on his light boots to compete in the race,
 The western turkey-shooting draws old and young, some lean on their rifles, 20
 some sit on logs,
 Out from the crowd steps the marksman, takes his position, levels his piece;
 The groups of newly-come immigrants cover the wharf or levee,
 As the woolly-pates hoe in the sugar-field, the overseer views them from his
 saddle,
 The bugle calls in the ball-room, the gentlemen run for their partners, the
 dancers bow to each other,
 The youth lies awake in the cedar-roof'd garret and harks to the musical rain, 25
 The Wolverine sets traps on the creek that helps fill the Huron,
 The squaw wrapt in her yellow-hemm'd cloth is offering moccasins and
 bead-bags for sale,
 The connoisseur peers along the exhibition-gallery with half-shut eyes bent
 sideways,

As the deck-hands make fast the steamboat the plank is thrown for the
 shore-going passengers,
 The young sister holds out the skein while the elder sister winds it off in a 30
 ball, and stops now and then for the knots,
 The one-year wife is recovering and happy having a week ago borne her first
 child,
 The clean-hair'd Yankee girl works with her sewing-machine or in the factory
 or mill,
 The paving-man leans on his two-handed rammer, the reporter's lead flies
 swiftly over the note-book, the sign-painter is lettering with blue and
 gold,
 The canal boy trots on the tow-path, the book-keeper counts at his desk, the
 shoemaker waxes his thread,
 The conductor beats time for the band and all the performers follow him, 35
 The child is baptized, the convert is making his first professions,
 The regatta is spread on the bay, the race is begun, (how the white sails
 sparkle!)
 The drover watching his drove sings out to them that would stray,
 The pedler sweats with his pack on his back, (the purchaser haggling about
 the odd cent;)
 The bride unrumpled her white dress, the minute-hand of the clock moves 40
 slowly,
 The opium-eater reclines with rigid head and just-open'd lips,
 The prostitute draggles her shawl, her bonnet bobs on her tipsy and pimpled
 neck,
 The crowd laugh at her blackguard oaths, the men jeer and wink to each
 other,
 (Miserable! I do not laugh at your oaths nor jeer you;)
 The President holding a cabinet council is surrounded by the great 45
 Secretaries,
 On the piazza walk three matrons stately and friendly with twined arms,
 The crew of the fish-smack pack repeated layers of halibut in the hold,
 The Missourian crosses the plains toting his wares and his cattle,

As the fare-collector goes through the train he gives notice by the jingling of
loose change,

The floor-men are laying the floor, the tinnners are tinning the roof, the
masons are calling for mortar, 50

In single file each shouldering his hod pass onward the laborers;

Seasons pursuing each other the indescribable crowd is gather'd, it is the
fourth of Seventh-month, (what salutes of cannon and small arms!)

Seasons pursuing each other the plougher ploughs, the mower mows, and the
winter-grain falls in the ground;

Off on the lakes the pike-fisher watches and waits by the hole in the frozen
surface,

The stumps stand thick round the clearing, the squatter strikes deep with his
axe, 55

Flatboatmen make fast towards dusk near the cotton-wood or pecan-trees,

Coon-seekers go through the regions of the Red river or through those
drain'd by the Tennessee, or through those of the Arkansas,

Torches shine in the dark that hangs on the Chattahooche or Altamahaw,

Patriarchs sit at supper with sons and grandsons and great-grandsons around
them,

In walls of adobie, in canvas tents, rest hunters and trappers after their day's
sport, 60

The city sleeps and the country sleeps,

The living sleep for their time, the dead sleep for their time,

The old husband sleeps by his wife and the young husband sleeps by his wife;

And these tend inward to me, and I tend outward to them,

And such as it is to be of these more or less I am, 65

And of these one and all I weave the song of myself.

~ 16 ~

I am of old and young, of the foolish as much as the wise,

Regardless of others, ever regardful of others,

Maternal as well as paternal, a child as well as a man,

Stuff'd with the stuff that is coarse and stuff'd with the stuff that is fine,

One of the Nation of many nations, the smallest the same and the largest the same, 5
 A Southerner soon as a Northerner, a planter nonchalant and hospitable
 down by the Oconee I live,
 A Yankee bound my own way ready for trade, my joints the limberest joints
 on earth and the sternest joints on earth,
 A Kentuckian walking the vale of the Elkhorn in my deer-skin leggings, a
 Louisianian or Georgian,
 A boatman over lakes or bays or along coasts, a Hoosier, Badger, Buckeye;
 At home on Kanadian snow-shoes or up in the bush, or with fishermen off 10
 Newfoundland,
 At home in the fleet of ice-boats, sailing with the rest and tacking,
 At home on the hills of Vermont or in the woods of Maine, or the Texan
 ranch,
 Comrade of Californians, comrade of free North-Westerners, (loving their
 big proportions,)
 Comrade of raftsmen and coalmen, comrade of all who shake hands and
 welcome to drink and meat,
 A learner with the simplest, a teacher of the thoughtfulest, 15
 A novice beginning yet experient of myriads of seasons,
 Of every hue and caste am I, of every rank and religion,
 A farmer, mechanic, artist, gentleman, sailor, quaker,
 Prisoner, fancy-man, rowdy, lawyer, physician, priest.

 I resist any thing better than my own diversity, 20
 Breathe the air but leave plenty after me,
 And am not stuck up, and am in my place.

 (The moth and the fish-eggs are in their place,
 The bright suns I see and the dark suns I cannot see are in their place,
 The palpable is in its place and the impalpable is in its place.) 25

~ 17 ~

These are really the thoughts of all men in all ages and lands, they are not
original with me,
If they are not yours as much as mine they are nothing, or next to nothing,
If they are not the riddle and the untying of the riddle they are nothing,
If they are not just as close as they are distant they are nothing.

This is the grass that grows wherever the land is and the water is, 5
This the common air that bathes the globe.

~ 18 ~

With music strong I come, with my cornets and my drums,
I play not marches for accepted victors only, I play marches for conquer'd and
slain persons.

Have you heard that it was good to gain the day?
I also say it is good to fall, battles are lost in the same spirit in which they are
won.

I beat and pound for the dead, 5
I blow through my embouchures my loudest and gayest for them.

Vivas to those who have fail'd!
And to those whose war-vessels sank in the sea!
And to those themselves who sank in the sea!
And to all generals that lost engagements, and all overcome heroes! 10
And the numberless unknown heroes equal to the greatest heroes known!

~ 19 ~

This is the meal equally set, this the meat for natural hunger,
It is for the wicked just the same as the righteous, I make appointments with
all,
I will not have a single person slighted or left away,

The kept-woman, sponger, thief, are hereby invited,
The heavy-lipp'd slave is invited, the venerealee is invited; 5
There shall be no difference between them and the rest.

This is the press of a bashful hand, this the float and odor of hair,
This the touch of my lips to yours, this the murmur of yearning,
This the far-off depth and height reflecting my own face,
This the thoughtful merge of myself, and the outlet again. 10

Do you guess I have some intricate purpose?
Well I have, for the Fourth-month showers have, and the mica on the side of
a rock has.

Do you take it I would astonish?
Does the daylight astonish? does the early redstart twittering through the
woods?
Do I astonish more than they? 15

This hour I tell things in confidence,
I might not tell everybody, but I will tell you.

~ 20 ~

Who goes there? hankering, gross, mystical, nude;
How is it I extract strength from the beef I eat?

What is a man anyhow? what am I? what are you?

All I mark as my own you shall offset it with your own,
Else it were time lost listening to me. 5

I do not snivel that snivel the world over,
The months are vacuums and the ground but wallow and filth.

Whimpering and truckling fold with powders for invalids, conformity goes
to the fourth-remov'd,
I wear my hat as I please indoors or out.

Why should I pray? why should I venerate and be ceremonious? 10

Having pried through the strata, analyzed to a hair, counsel'd with doctors
and calculated close,
I find no sweeter fat than sticks to my own bones.

In all people I see myself, none more and not one a barley-corn less,
And the good or bad I say of myself I say of them.

I know I am solid and sound, 15
To me the converging objects of the universe perpetually flow,
All are written to me, and I must get what the writing means.

I know I am deathless,
I know this orbit of mine cannot be swept by a carpenter's compass,
I know I shall not pass like a child's carlacue cut with a burnt stick at night. 20

I know I am august,
I do not trouble my spirit to vindicate itself or be understood,
I see that the elementary laws never apologize,
(I reckon I behave no prouder than the level I plant my house by, after all.)

I exist as I am, that is enough, 25
If no other in the world be aware I sit content,
And if each and all be aware I sit content.

One world is aware and by far the largest to me, and that is myself,
And whether I come to my own to-day or in ten thousand or ten million years,
I can cheerfully take it now, or with equal cheerfulness I can wait. 30

My foothold is tenon'd and mortis'd in granite,
I laugh at what you call dissolution,
And I know the amplitude of time.

~ 21 ~

I am the poet of the Body and I am the poet of the Soul,
The pleasures of heaven are with me and the pains of hell are with me,
The first I graft and increase upon myself, the latter I translate into new
tongue.

I am the poet of the woman the same as the man,
And I say it is as great to be a woman as to be a man,
And I say there is nothing greater than the mother of men.

5

I chant the chant of dilation or pride,
We have had ducking and deprecating about enough,
I show that size is only development.

Have you outstript the rest? are you the President?
It is a trifle, they will more than arrive there every one, and still pass on.

10

I am he that walks with the tender and growing night,
I call to the earth and sea half-held by the night.

Press close bare-bosom'd night—press close magnetic nourishing night!
Night of south winds—night of the large few stars!
Still nodding night—mad naked summer night.

15

Smile O voluptuous cool-breath'd earth!
Earth of the slumbering and liquid trees!
Earth of departed sunset—earth of the mountains misty-topt!
Earth of the vitreous pour of the full moon just tinged with blue!
Earth of shine and dark mottling the tide of the river!

20

Earth of the limpid gray of clouds brighter and clearer for my sake!
Far-swooping elbow'd earth—rich apple-blossom'd earth!
Smile, for your lover comes.

Prodigal, you have given me love—therefore I to you give love!
O unspeakable passionate love.

25

~ 22 ~

You sea! I resign myself to you also—I guess what you mean,
I behold from the beach your crooked fingers,
I believe you refuse to go back without feeling of me,
We must have a turn together, I undress, hurry me out of sight of the land,
Cushion me soft, rock me in billowy drowse,
Dash me with amorous wet, I can repay you.

5

Sea of stretch'd ground-swells,
Sea breathing broad and convulsive breaths,
Sea of the brine of life and of unshovel'd yet always-ready graves,
Howler and scooper of storms, capricious and dainty sea,
I am integral with you, I too am of one phase and of all phases.

10

Partaker of influx and efflux I, extoller of hate and conciliation,
Extoller of amies and those that sleep in each others' arms,

I am he attesting sympathy,
(Shall I make my list of things in the house and skip the house that supports
them?)

15

I am not the poet of goodness only, I do not decline to be the poet of
wickedness also.

What blurt is this about virtue and about vice?
Evil propels me and reform of evil propels me, I stand indifferent,

My gait is no fault-finder's or rejecter's gait,
I moisten the roots of all that has grown.

20

Did you fear some scrofula out of the unflagging pregnancy?
Did you guess the celestial laws are yet to be work'd over and rectified?

I find one side a balance and the antipodal side a balance,
Soft doctrine as steady help as stable doctrine,
Thoughts and deeds of the present our rouse and early start.

25

This minute that comes to me over the past decillions,
There is no better than it and now.

What behaved well in the past or behaves well to-day is not such wonder,
The wonder is always and always how there can be a mean man or an infidel.

~ 23 ~

Endless unfolding of words of ages!
And mine a word of the modern, the word En-Masse.

A word of the faith that never balks,
Here or henceforward it is all the same to me, I accept Time absolutely.

It alone is without flaw, it alone rounds and completes all,
That mystic baffling wonder alone completes all.

5

I accept Reality and dare not question it,
Materialism first and last imbuing.

Hurrah for positive science! long live exact demonstration!
Fetch stonecrop mixt with cedar and branches of lilac,
This is the lexicographer, this the chemist, this made a grammar of the old
cartouches,

10

These mariners put the ship through dangerous unknown seas.
This is the geologist, this works with the scalper, and this is a mathematician.

Gentlemen, to you the first honors always!
Your facts are useful, and yet they are not my dwelling, 15
I but enter by them to an area of my dwelling.

Less the reminders of properties told my words,
And more the reminders they of life untold, and of freedom and extrication,
And make short account of neuters and geldings, and favor men and women
fully equipt,
And beat the gong of revolt, and stop with fugitives and them that plot and 20
conspire.

~ 24 ~

Walt Whitman, a kosmos, of Manhattan the son,
Turbulent, fleshy, sensual, eating, drinking and breeding,
No sentimentalist, no stander above men and women or apart from them,
No more modest than immodest.

Unscrew the locks from the doors! 5
Unscrew the doors themselves from their jambs!

Whoever degrades another degrades me,
And whatever is done or said returns at last to me.

Through me the afflatus surging and surging, through me the current and
index.

I speak the pass-word primeval, I give the sign of democracy, 10
By God! I will accept nothing which all cannot have their counterpart of on
the same terms.

Through me many long dumb voices,
Voices of the interminable generations of prisoners and slaves,
Voices of the diseas'd and despairing and of thieves and dwarfs,
Voices of cycles of preparation and accretion,
And of the threads that connect the stars, and of wombs and of the father-
stuff,
And of the rights of them the others are down upon,
Of the deform'd, trivial, flat, foolish, despised,
Fog in the air, beetles rolling balls of dung.

15

Through me forbidden voices,
Voices of sexes and lusts, voices veil'd and I remove the veil,
Voices indecent by me clarified and transfigur'd.

20

I do not press my fingers across my mouth,
I keep as delicate around the bowels as around the head and heart,
Copulation is no more rank to me than death is.

25

I believe in the flesh and the appetites,
Seeing, hearing, feeling, are miracles, and each part and tag of me is a
miracle.

Divine am I inside and out, and I make holy whatever I touch or am touch'd
from,
The scent of these arm-pits aroma finer than prayer,
This head more than churches, bibles, and all the creeds.

30

If I worship one thing more than another it shall be the spread of my own
body, or any part of it,
Translucent mould of me it shall be you!
Shaded ledges and rests it shall be you!
Firm masculine colter it shall be you!
Whatever goes to the tilth of me it shall be you!

35

You my rich blood! your milky stream pale strippings of my life!
Breast that presses against other breasts it shall be you!
My brain it shall be your occult convolutions!
Root of wash'd sweet-flag! timorous pond-snipe! nest of guarded duplicate
eggs! it shall be you!
Mix'd tussled hay of head, beard, brawn, it shall be you! 40
Trickling sap of maple, fibre of manly wheat, it shall be you!
Sun so generous it shall be you!
Vapors lighting and shading my face it shall be you!
You sweaty brooks and dews it shall be you!
Winds whose soft-tickling genitals rub against me it shall be you! 45
Broad muscular fields, branches of live oak, loving lounger in my winding
paths, it shall be you!
Hands I have taken, face I have kiss'd, mortal I have ever touch'd, it shall be
you.

I dote on myself, there is that lot of me and all so luscious,
Each moment and whatever happens thrills me with joy,
I cannot tell how my ankles bend, nor whence the cause of my faintest wish, 50
Nor the cause of the friendship I emit, nor the cause of the friendship I take
again.

That I walk up my stoop, I pause to consider if it really be,
A morning-glory at my window satisfies me more than the metaphysics of
books.

To behold the day-break!
The little light fades the immense and diaphanous shadows, 55
The air tastes good to my palate.

Hefts of the moving world at innocent gambols silently rising freshly
exuding,
Scooting obliquely high and low.

Something I cannot see puts upward libidinous prongs,
Seas of bright juice suffuse heaven.

60

The earth by the sky staid with, the daily close of their junction,
The heav'd challenge from the east that moment over my head,
The mocking taunt, See then whether you shall be master!

~ 25 ~

Dazzling and tremendous how quick the sun-rise would kill me,
If I could not now and always send sun-rise out of me.

We also ascend dazzling and tremendous as the sun,
We found our own O my soul in the calm and cool of the daybreak.

My voice goes after what my eyes cannot reach,
With the twirl of my tongue I encompass worlds and volumes of worlds.

5

Speech is the twin of my vision, it is unequal to measure itself,
It provokes me forever, it says sarcastically,
Walt you contain enough, why don't you let it out then?

Come now I will not be tantalized, you conceive too much of articulation,
Do you not know O speech how the buds beneath you are folded?
Waiting in gloom, protected by frost,
The dirt receding before my prophetic screams,
I underlying causes to balance them at last,
My knowledge my live parts, it keeping tally with the meaning of all things,
Happiness, (which whoever hears me let him or her set out in search of this
day.)

10

15

My final merit I refuse you, I refuse putting from me what I really am,
Encompass worlds, but never try to encompass me,
I crowd your sleekest and best by simply looking toward you.

Writing and talk do not prove me,
I carry the plenum of proof and every thing else in my face,
With the hush of my lips I wholly confound the skeptic.

20

~ 26 ~

Now I will do nothing but listen,
To accrue what I hear into this song, to let sounds contribute toward it.

I hear bravuras of birds, bustle of growing wheat, gossip of flames, clack of
sticks cooking my meals,

I hear the sound I love, the sound of the human voice,

I hear all sounds running together, combined, fused or following,

5

Sounds of the city and sounds out of the city, sounds of the day and night,
Talkative young ones to those that like them, the loud laugh of work-people
at their meals,

The angry base of disjointed friendship, the faint tones of the sick,

The judge with hands tight to the desk, his pallid lips pronouncing a death-
sentence,

The heave'yo of stevedores unlading ships by the wharves, the refrain of the
anchor-lifters,

10

The ring of alarm-bells, the cry of fire, the whirr of swift-streaking engines
and hose-carts with premonitory tinkles and color'd lights,

The steam-whistle, the solid roll of the train of approaching cars,

The slow march play'd at the head of the association marching two and two,
(They go to guard some corpse, the flag-tops are draped with black muslin.)

I hear the violoncello, ('tis the young man's heart's complaint,)

15

I hear the key'd cornet, it glides quickly in through my ears,

It shakes mad-sweet pangs through my belly and breast.

I hear the chorus, it is a grand opera,

Ah this indeed is music—this suits me.

A tenor large and fresh as the creation fills me,
The orbic flex of his mouth is pouring and filling me full.

20

I hear the train'd soprano (what work with hers is this?)
The orchestra whirls me wider than Uranus flies,
It wrenches such ardors from me I did not know I possess'd them,
It sails me, I dab with bare feet, they are lick'd by the indolent waves,
I am cut by bitter and angry hail, I lose my breath,
Steep'd amid honey'd morphine, my windpipe throttled in fakes of death,
At length let up again to feel the puzzle of puzzles,
And that we call Being.

25

~ 27 ~

To be in any form, what is that?
(Round and round we go, all of us, and ever come back thither,)
If nothing lay more develop'd the quahaug in its callous shell were enough.

Mine is no callous shell,
I have instant conductors all over me whether I pass or stop,
They seize every object and lead it harmlessly through me.

5

I merely stir, press, feel with my fingers, and am happy,
To touch my person to some one else's is about as much as I can stand.

~ 28 ~

Is this then a touch? quivering me to a new identity,
Flames and ether making a rush for my veins,
Treacherous tip of me reaching and crowding to help them,
My flesh and blood playing out lightning to strike what is hardly different
from myself,
On all sides prurient provokers stiffening my limbs,
Straining the udder of my heart for its withheld drip,
Behaving licentious toward me, taking no denial,

5

Depriving me of my best as for a purpose,
Unbuttoning my clothes, holding me by the bare waist,
Deluding my confusion with the calm of the sunlight and pasture-fields, 10
Immodestly sliding the fellow-senses away,
They bribed to swap off with touch and go and graze at the edges of me,
No consideration, no regard for my draining strength or my anger,
Fetching the rest of the herd around to enjoy them a while,
Then all uniting to stand on a headland and worry me. 15

The sentries desert every other part of me,
They have left me helpless to a red marauder,
They all come to the headland to witness and assist against me.

I am given up by traitors,
I talk wildly, I have lost my wits, I and nobody else am the greatest traitor, 20
I went myself first to the headland, my own hands carried me there.

You villain touch! what are you doing? my breath is tight in its throat,
Unclench your floodgates, you are too much for me.

~ 29 ~

Blind loving wrestling touch, sheath'd hooded sharp-tooth'd touch!
Did it make you ache so, leaving me?

Parting track'd by arriving, perpetual payment of perpetual loan,
Rich showering rain, and recompense richer afterward.

Sprouts take and accumulate, stand by the curb prolific and vital, 5
Landscapes projected masculine, full-sized and golden.

~ 30 ~

All truths wait in all things,
They neither hasten their own delivery nor resist it,

They do not need the obstetric forceps of the surgeon,
The insignificant is as big to me as any,
(What is less or more than a touch?)

5

Logic and sermons never convince,
The damp of the night drives deeper into my soul.

(Only what proves itself to every man and woman is so,
Only what nobody denies is so.)

A minute and a drop of me settle my brain,
I believe the soggy clods shall become lovers and lamps,
And a compend of compends is the meat of a man or woman,
And a summit and flower there is the feeling they have for each other,
And they are to branch boundlessly out of that lesson until it becomes
 omnific,
And until one and all shall delight us, and we them.

10

15

~ 31 ~

I believe a leaf of grass is no less than the journey work of the stars,
And the pismire is equally perfect, and a grain of sand, and the egg of the
 wren,
And the tree-toad is a chef-d'œuvre for the highest,
And the running blackberry would adorn the parlors of heaven,
And the narrowest hinge in my hand puts to scorn all machinery,
And the cow crunching with depress'd head surpasses any statue,
And a mouse is miracle enough to stagger sextillions of infidels.

5

I find I incorporate gneiss, coal, long-threaded moss, fruits, grains, esculent
 roots,
And am stucco'd with quadrupeds and birds all over,
And have distanced what is behind me for good reasons,
But call any thing back again when I desire it.

10

In vain the speeding or shyness,
In vain the plutonic rocks send their old heat against my approach,
In vain the mastodon retreats beneath its own powder'd bones,
In vain objects stand leagues off and assume manifold shapes, 15
In vain the ocean settling in hollows and the great monsters lying low,
In vain the buzzard houses herself with the sky,
In vain the snake slides through the creepers and logs,
In vain the elk takes to the inner passes of the woods,
In vain the razor-bill'd auk sails far north to Labrador, 20
I follow quickly, I ascend to the nest in the fissure of the cliff.

~ 32 ~

I think I could turn and live with animals, they are so placid and self-contain'd,
I stand and look at them long and long.

They do not sweat and whine about their condition,
They do not lie awake in the dark and weep for their sins,
They do not make me sick discussing their duty to God, 5
Not one is dissatisfied, not one is demented with the mania of owning things,
Not one kneels to another, nor to his kind that lived thousands of years ago,
Not one is respectable or unhappy over the whole earth.

So they show their relations to me and I accept them,
They bring me tokens of myself, they evince them plainly in their possession. 10

I wonder where they get those tokens,
Did I pass that way huge times ago and negligently drop them?

Myself moving forward then and now and forever,
Gathering and showing more always and with velocity,
Infinite and omnigenous, and the like of these among them, 15
Not too exclusive toward the reachers of my remembrancers,
Picking out here one that I love, and now go with him on brotherly terms.

A gigantic beauty of a stallion, fresh and responsive to my caresses,
Head high in the forehead, wide between the ears,
Limbs glossy and supple, tail dusting the ground, 20
Eyes full of sparkling wickedness, ears finely cut, flexibly moving.

His nostrils dilate as my heels embrace him,
His well-built limbs tremble with pleasure as we race around and return.

I but use you a minute, then I resign you, stallion,
Why do I need your paces when I myself out-gallop them? 25
Even as I stand or sit passing faster than you.

~ 33 ~

Space and Time! now I see it is true, what I guess'd at,
What I guess'd when I loaf'd on the grass,
What I guess'd while I lay alone in my bed,
And again as I walk'd the beach under the paling stars of the morning.

My ties and ballasts leave me, my elbows rest in sea-gaps, 5
I skirt sierras, my palms cover continents,
I am afoot with my vision.

By the city's quadrangular houses—in log huts, camping with lumber-men,
Along the ruts of the turnpike, along the dry gulch and rivulet bed,
Weeding my onion-patch or hosing rows of carrots and parsnips, crossing 10
savannas, trailing in forests,
Prospecting, gold-digging, girdling the trees of a new purchase,
Scorch'd ankle-deep by the hot sand, hauling my boat down the shallow river,
Where the panther walks to and fro on a limb overhead, where the buck
turns furiously at the hunter,
Where the rattlesnake suns his flabby length on a rock, where the otter is
feeding on fish,
Where the alligator in his tough pimples sleeps by the bayou, 15

Where the black bear is searching for roots or honey, where the beaver pats
 the mud with his paddle-shaped tail;
 Over the growing sugar, over the yellow-flower'd cotton plant, over the rice in
 its low moist field,
 Over the sharp-peak'd farm house, with its scallop'd scum and slender shoots
 from the gutters,
 Over the western persimmon, over the long-leav'd corn, over the delicate
 blue-flower flax,
 Over the white and brown buckwheat, a hummer and buzzer there with the 20
 rest,
 Over the dusky green of the rye as it ripples and shades in the breeze;
 Scaling mountains, pulling myself cautiously up, holding on by low scragged
 limbs,
 Walking the path worn in the grass and beat through the leaves of the brush,
 Where the quail is whistling betwixt the woods and the wheat-lot,
 Where the bat flies in the Seventh-month eve, where the great goldbug drops 25
 through the dark,
 Where the brook puts out of the roots of the old tree and flows to the meadow,
 Where cattle stand and shake away flies with the tremulous shuddering of
 their hides,
 Where the cheese-cloth hangs in the kitchen, where andirons straddle the
 hearth-slab, where cobwebs fall in festoons from the rafters;
 Where trip-hammers crash, where the press is whirling its cylinders,
 Wherever the human heart beats with terrible throes under its ribs, 30
 Where the pear-shaped balloon is floating aloft, (floating in it myself and
 looking composedly down,)
 Where the life-car is drawn on the slip-noose, where the heat hatches
 pale-green eggs in the dented sand,
 Where the she-whale swims with her calf and never forsakes it,
 Where the steam-ship trails hind-ways its long pennant of smoke,
 Where the fin of the shark cuts like a black chip out of the water, 35
 Where the half-burn'd brig is riding on unknown currents,
 Where shells grow to her slimy deck, where the dead are corrupting below;

Where the dense-starr'd flag is borne at the head of the regiments,
 Approaching Manhattan up by the long-stretching island,
 Under Niagara, the cataract falling like a veil over my countenance, 40
 Upon a door-step, upon the horse-block of hard wood outside,
 Upon the race-course, or enjoying picnics or jigs or a good game of base-ball,
 At he-festivals, with blackguard gibes, ironical license, bull-dances, drinking,
 laughter,
 At the cider-mill tasting the sweets of the brown mash, sucking the juice
 through a straw,
 At apple-peelings wanting kisses for all the red fruit I find, 45
 At musters, beach-parties, friendly bees, huskings, house-raisings;
 Where the mocking-bird sounds his delicious gurgles, cackles, screams,
 weeps,
 Where the hay-rick stands in the barn-yard, where the dry-stalks are
 scatter'd, where the brood-cow waits in the hovel,
 Where the bull advances to do his masculine work, where the stud to the
 mare, where the cock is treading the hen,
 Where the heifers browse, where geese nip their food with short jerks, 50
 Where sun-down shadows lengthen over the limitless and lonesome prairie,
 Where herds of buffalo make a crawling spread of the square miles far and
 near,
 Where the humming-bird shimmers, where the neck of the long-lived swan
 is curving and winding,
 Where the laughing-gull scoots by the shore, where she laughs her near-
 human laugh,
 Where bee-hives range on a gray bench in the garden half hid by the high 55
 weeds,
 Where band-neck'd partridges roost in a ring on the ground with their heads
 out,
 Where burial coaches enter the arch'd gates of a cemetery,
 Where winter wolves bark amid wastes of snow and icicled trees,
 Where the yellow-crown'd heron comes to the edge of the marsh at night and
 feeds upon small crabs,

Where the splash of swimmers and divers cools the warm noon, 60
 Where the katy-did works her chromatic reed on the walnut-tree over the well,
 Through patches of citrons and cucumbers with silver-wired leaves,
 Through the salt-lick or orange glade, or under conical firs,
 Through the gymnasium, through the curtain'd saloon, through the office or
 public hall;
 Pleas'd with the native and pleas'd with the foreign, pleas'd with the new and 65
 old,
 Pleas'd with the homely woman as well as the handsome,
 Pleas'd with the quakeress as she puts off her bonnet and talks melodiously,
 Pleas'd with the tune of the choir of the whitewash'd church,
 Pleas'd with the earnest words of the sweating Methodist preacher, impress'd
 seriously at the camp-meeting;
 Looking in at the shop-windows of Broadway the whole forenoon, flattening 70
 the flesh of my nose on the thick plate glass,
 Wandering the same afternoon with my face turn'd up to the clouds, or down
 a lane or along the beach,
 My right and left arms round the sides of two friends, and I in the middle;
 Coming home with the silent and dark-cheek'd bush-boy, (behind me he
 rides at the drape of the day,)
 Far from the settlements studying the print of animals' feet, or the moccasin
 print,
 By the cot in the hospital reaching lemonade to a feverish patient, 75
 Nigh the coffin'd corpse when all is still, examining with a candle;
 Voyaging to every port to dicker and adventure,
 Hurrying with the modern crowd as eager and fickle as any,
 Hot toward one I hate, ready in my madness to knife him,
 Solitary at midnight in my back yard, my thoughts gone from me a long while, 80
 Walking the old hills of Judæa with the beautiful gentle God by my side,
 Speeding through space, speeding through heaven and the stars,
 Speeding amid the seven satellites and the broad ring, and the diameter of
 eighty thousand miles,
 Speeding with tail'd meteors, throwing fire-balls like the rest,

Carrying the crescent child that carries its own full mother in its belly, 85
Storming, enjoying, planning, loving, cautioning,
Backing and filling, appearing and disappearing,
I tread day and night such roads.

I visit the orchards of spheres and look at the product,
And look at quintillions ripen'd and look at quintillions green. 90

I fly those flights of a fluid and swallowing soul,
My course runs below the soundings of plummets.

I help myself to material and immaterial,
No guard can shut me off, no law prevent me.

I anchor my ship for a little while only, 95
My messengers continually cruise away or bring their returns to me.

I go hunting polar furs and the seal, leaping chasms with a pike-pointed staff,
clinging to topples of brittle and blue.

I ascend to the foretruck,
I take my place late at night in the crow's-nest,
We sail the arctic sea, it is plenty light enough, 100
Through the clear atmosphere I stretch around on the wonderful beauty,
The enormous masses of ice pass me and I pass them, the scenery is plain in
all directions,
The white-topt mountains show in the distance, I fling out my fancies toward
them,
We are approaching some great battle-field in which we are soon to be engaged,
We pass the colossal outposts of the encampment, we pass with still feet and 105
caution,
Or we are entering by the suburbs some vast and ruin'd city,
The blocks and fallen architecture more than all the living cities of the globe.

I am a free companion, I bivouac by invading watchfires,
I turn the bridegroom out of bed and stay with the bride myself,
I tighten her all night to my thighs and lips.

110

My voice is the wife's voice, the screech by the rail of the stairs,
They fetch my man's body up dripping and drown'd.

I understand the large hearts of heroes,
The courage of present times and all times,
How the skipper saw the crowded and rudderless wreck of the steamship, and 115
 Death chasing it up and down the storm,
How he knuckled tight and gave not back an inch, and was faithful of days
 and faithful of nights,
And chalk'd in large letters on a board, *Be of good cheer, we will not desert you;*
How he follow'd with them and tack'd with them three days and would not
 give it up,
How he saved the drifting company at last,
How the lank loose-gown'd women look'd when boated from the side of their 120
 prepared graves,
How the silent old-faced infants and the lifted sick, and the sharp-lipp'd
 unshaved men;
All this I swallow, it tastes good, I like it well, it becomes mine,
I am the man, I suffer'd, I was there.

The disdain and calmness of martyrs,
The mother of old, condemn'd for a witch, burnt with dry wood, her children 125
 gazing on,
The hounded slave that flags in the race, leans by the fence, blowing, cover'd
 with sweat,
The twinges that sting like needles his legs and neck, the murderous buckshot
 and the bullets,
All these I feel or am.

I am the hounded slave, I wince at the bite of the dogs,
Hell and despair are upon me, crack and again crack the marksmen, 130
I clutch the rails of the fence, my gore dribs, thinn'd with the ooze of my skin,
I fall on the weeds and stones,
The riders spur their unwilling horses, haul close,
Taunt my dizzy ears and beat me violently over the head with whip-stocks.

Agonies are one of my changes of garments, 135
I do not ask the wounded person how he feels, I myself become the wounded
person,
My hurts turn livid upon me as I lean on a cane and observe.

I am the mash'd fireman with breast-bone broken,
Tumbling walls buried me in their debris,
Heat and smoke I inspired, I heard the yelling shouts of my comrades, 140
I heard the distant click of their picks and shovels,
They have clear'd the beams away, they tenderly lift me forth.

I lie in the night air in my red shirt, the pervading hush is for my sake,
Painless after all I lie exhausted but not so unhappy,
White and beautiful are the faces around me, the heads are bared of their 145
fire-caps,
The kneeling crowd fades with the light of the torches.

Distant and dead resuscitate,
They show as the dial or move as the hands of me, I am the clock myself.

I am an old artillerist, I tell of my fort's bombardment,
I am there again. 150

Again the long roll of the drummers,
Again the attacking cannon, mortars,
Again to my listening ears the cannon responsive.

I take part, I see and hear the whole,
The cries, curses, roar, the plaudits for well-aim'd shots, 155
The ambulanza slowly passing trailing its red drip,
Workmen searching after damages, making indispensable repairs,
The fall of grenades through the rent roof, the fan-shaped explosion,
The whizz of limbs, heads, stone, wood, iron, high in the air.

Again gurgles the mouth of my dying general, he furiously waves with his 160
hand,
He gasps through the clot *Mind not me—mind—the entrenchments.*

~ 34 ~

Now I tell what I knew in Texas in my early youth,
(I tell not the fall of Alamo,
Not one escaped to tell the fall of Alamo,
The hundred and fifty are dumb yet at Alamo,)
'Tis the tale of the murder in cold blood of four hundred and twelve young 5
men.

Retreating they had form'd in a hollow square with their baggage for
breastworks,
Nine hundred lives out of the surrounding enemies, nine times their number,
was the price they took in advance,
Their colonel was wounded and their ammunition gone,
They treated for an honorable capitulation, receiv'd writing and seal, gave up
their arms and march'd back prisoners of war.

They were the glory of the race of rangers, 10
Matchless with horse, rifle, song, supper, courtship,
Large, turbulent, generous, handsome, proud, and affectionate,
Bearded, sunburnt, drest in the free costume of hunters,
Not a single one over thirty years of age.

The second First-day morning they were brought out in squads and
massacred, it was beautiful early summer, 15
The work commenced about five o'clock and was over by eight.

None obey'd the command to kneel,
Some made a mad and helpless rush, some stood stark and straight,
A few fell at once, shot in the temple or heart, the living and dead lay together,
The maim'd and mangled dug in the dirt, the new-comers saw them there, 20
Some half-kill'd attempted to crawl away,
These were despatch'd with bayonets or batter'd with the blunts of muskets,
A youth not seventeen years old seiz'd his assassin till two more came to
release him,
The three were all torn and cover'd with the boy's blood.

At eleven o'clock began the burning of the bodies; 25
That is the tale of the murder of the four hundred and twelve young men.

~ 35 ~

Would you hear of an old-time sea-fight?
Would you learn who won by the light of the moon and stars?
List to the yarn, as my grandmother's father the sailor told it to me.

Our foe was no sulk in his ship I tell you, (said he,)
His was the surly English pluck, and there is no tougher or truer, and never 5
was, and never will be;
Along the lower'd eve he came horribly raking us.

We closed with him, the yards entangled, the cannon touch'd,
My captain lash'd fast with his own hands.

We had receiv'd some eighteen pound shots under the water,
On our lower-gun-deck two large pieces had burst at the first fire, killing all 10
around and blowing up overhead.

Fighting at sun-down, fighting at dark,
Ten o'clock at night, the full moon well up, our leaks on the gain, and five feet
of water reported,
The master-at-arms loosing the prisoners confined in the after-hold to give
them a chance for themselves.

The transit to and from the magazine is now stopt by the sentinels,
They see so many strange faces they do not know whom to trust.

15

Our frigate takes fire,
The other asks if we demand quarter?
If our colors are struck and the fighting done?

Now I laugh content, for I hear the voice of my little captain,
We have not struck, he composedly cries, *we have just begun our part of the*
fighting.

20

Only three guns are in use,
One is directed by the captain himself against the enemy's main-mast,
Two well serv'd with grape and canister silence his musketry and clear his decks.

The tops alone second the fire of this little battery, especially the main-top,
They hold out bravely during the whole of the action.

25

Not a moment's cease,
The leaks gain fast on the pumps, the fire eats toward the powder-magazine.

One of the pumps has been shot away, it is generally thought we are sinking.

Serene stands the little captain,
He is not hurried, his voice is neither high nor low,
His eyes give more light to us than our battle-lanterns.

30

Toward twelve there in the beams of the moon they surrender to us.

~ 36 ~

Stretch'd and still lies the midnight,
Two great hulls motionless on the breast of the darkness,
Our vessel riddled and slowly sinking, preparations to pass to the one we
 have conquer'd,
The captain on the quarter-deck coldly giving his orders through a
 countenance white as a sheet,
Near by the corpse of the child that serv'd in the cabin, 5
The dead face of an old salt with long white hair and carefully curl'd whiskers,
The flames spite of all that can be done flickering aloft and below,
The husky voices of the two or three officers yet fit for duty,
Formless stacks of bodies and bodies by themselves, dabs of flesh upon the
 masts and spars,
Cut of cordage, dangle of rigging, slight shock of the soothe of waves, 10
Black and impassive guns, litter of powder-parcels, strong scent,
A few large stars overhead, silent and mournful shining,
Delicate sniffs of sea-breeze, smells of sedgy grass and fields by the shore,
 death-messages given in charge to survivors,
The hiss of the surgeon's knife, the gnawing teeth of his saw,
Wheeze, cluck, swash of falling blood, short wild scream, and long, dull, 15
 tapering groan,
These so, these irretrievable.

~ 37 ~

You laggards there on guard! look to your arms!
In at the conquer'd doors they crowd! I am possess'd!
Embody all presences outlaw'd or suffering,
See myself in prison shaped like another man,
And feel the dull unintermitted pain. 5

For me the keepers of convicts shoulder their carbines and keep watch,
It is I let out in the morning and barr'd at night.

Not a mutineer walks handcuff'd to jail but I am handcuff'd to him and walk
by his side,
(I am less the jolly one there, and more the silent one with sweat on my
twitching lips.)

Not a youngster is taken for larceny but I go up too, and am tried and
sentenced.

10

Not a cholera patient lies at the last gasp but I also lie at the last gasp,
My face is ash-color'd, my sinews gnarl, away from me people retreat.

Askers embody themselves in me and I am embodied in them,
I project my hat, sit shame-faced, and beg.

~ 38 ~

Enough! enough! enough!
Somehow I have been stunn'd. Stand back!
Give me a little time beyond my cuff'd head, slumbers, dreams, gaping,
I discover myself on the verge of a usual mistake.

That I could forget the mockers and insults!
That I could forget the trickling tears and the blows of the bludgeons and
hammers!
That I could look with a separate look on my own crucifixion and bloody
crowning.

5

I remember now,
I resume the overstaid fraction,
The grave of rock multiplies what has been confided to it, or to any graves,
Corpses rise, gashes heal, fastenings roll from me.

10

I troop forth replenish'd with supreme power, one of an average unending
procession,
Inland and sea-coast we go, and pass all boundary lines,

Our swift ordinances on their way over the whole earth,
The blossoms we wear in our hats the growth of thousands of years.

15

Eleves, I salute you! come forward!
Continue your annotations, continue your questionings.

~ 39 ~

The friendly and flowing savage, who is he?
Is he waiting for civilization, or past it and mastering it?

Is he some Southwesterner rais'd out-doors? is he Kanadian?
Is he from the Mississippi country? Iowa, Oregon, California?
The mountains? prairie-life, bush-life? or sailor from the sea?

5

Wherever he goes men and women accept and desire him,
They desire he should like them, touch them, speak to them, stay with them.

Behavior lawless as snow-flakes, words simple as grass, uncomb'd head,
 laughter, and naivetè,
Slow-stepping feet, common features, common modes and emanations,
They descend in new forms from the tips of his fingers,
They are wafted with the odor of his body or breath, they fly out of the glance
 of his eyes.

10

~ 40 ~

Flaunt of the sunshine I need not your bask—lie over!
You light surfaces only, I force surfaces and depths also.

Earth! you seem to look for something at my hands,
Say, old top-knot, what do you want?

Man or woman, I might tell how I like you, but cannot,
And might tell what it is in me and what it is in you, but cannot,
And might tell that pining I have, that pulse of my nights and days.

5

Behold, I do not give lectures or a little charity,
When I give I give myself.

You there, impotent, loose in the knees, 10
Open your scarf'd chops till I blow grit within you,
Spread your palms and lift the flaps of your pockets,
I am not to be denied, I compel, I have stores plenty and to spare,
And any thing I have I bestow.

I do not ask who you are, that is not important to me, 15
You can do nothing and be nothing but what I will infold you.

To cotton-field drudge or cleaner of privies I lean,
On his right cheek I put the family kiss,
And in my soul I swear I never will deny him.

On women fit for conception I start bigger and nimbler babes. 20
(This day I am jetting the stuff of far more arrogant republics.)

To any one dying, thither I speed and twist the knob of the door
Turn the bed-clothes toward the foot of the bed,
Let the physician and the priest go home.

I seize the descending man and raise him with resistless will, 25
O despairer, here is my neck,
By God, you shall not go down! hang your whole weight upon me.

I dilate you with tremendous breath, I buoy you up,
Every room of the house do I fill with an arm'd force,
Lovers of me, bafflers of graves. 30

Sleep—I and they keep guard all night,
Not doubt, not decease shall dare to lay finger upon you,

I have embraced you, and henceforth possess you to myself,
And when you rise in the morning you will find what I tell you is so.

~ 41 ~

I am he bringing help for the sick as they pant on their backs,
And for strong upright men I bring yet more needed help.

I heard what was said of the universe,
Heard it and heard it of several thousand years;
It is middling well as far as it goes—but is that all?

5

Magnifying and applying come I,
Outbidding at the start the old cautious hucksters,
Taking myself the exact dimensions of Jehovah,
Lithographing Kronos, Zeus his son, and Hercules his grandson,
Buying drafts of Osiris, Isis, Belus, Brahma, Buddha, 10
In my portfolio placing Manito loose, Allah on a leaf, the crucifix
engraved,
With Odin and the hideous-faced Mexitli and every idol and image,
Taking them all for what they are worth and not a cent more,
Admitting they were alive and did the work of their days,
(They bore mites as for unfledg'd birds who have now to rise and fly and 15
sing for themselves,)
Accepting the rough deific sketches to fill out better in myself, bestowing
them freely on each man and woman I see,
Discovering as much or more in a framer framing a house,
Putting higher claims for him there with his roll'd-up sleeves driving the
mallet and chisel,
Not objecting to special revelations, considering a curl of smoke or a hair on
the back of my hand just as curious as any revelation,
Lads ahold of fire-engines and hook-and-ladder ropes no less to me than the 20
gods of the antique wars,
Minding their voices peal through the crash of destruction,

Their brawny limbs passing safe over charr'd laths, their white foreheads
 whole and unhurt out of the flames;
 By the mechanic's wife with her babe at her nipple interceding for every
 person born,
 Three scythes at harvest whizzing in a row from three lusty angels with shirts
 bagg'd out at their waists,
 The snag-tooth'd hostler with red hair redeeming sins past and to come, 25
 Selling all he possesses, traveling on foot to fee lawyers for his brother and sit
 by him while he is tried for forgery;
 What was strewn in the amplest strewing the square rod about me, and not
 filling the square rod then,
 The bull and the bug never worshipp'd half enough,
 Dung and dirt more admirable than was dream'd,
 The supernatural of no account, myself waiting my time to be one of the 30
 supremes,
 The day getting ready for me when I shall do as much good as the best, and
 be as prodigious;
 By my life-lumps! becoming already a creator,
 Putting myself here and now to the ambush'd womb of the shadows.

~ 42 ~

A call in the midst of the crowd,
 My own voice, orotund sweeping and final.

Come my children,
 Come my boys and girls, my women, household and intimates,
 Now the performer launches his nerve, he has pass'd his prelude on the reeds 5
 within.

Easily written loose-finger'd chords—I feel the thrum of your climax and
 close.

My head slues round on my neck,
Music rolls, but not from the organ,
Folks are around me, but they are no household of mine.

Ever the hard unsunk ground,
Ever the eaters and drinkers, ever the upward and downward sun, ever the air
and the ceaseless tides,
Ever myself and my neighbors, refreshing, wicked, real,
Ever the old inexplicable query, ever that thorn'd thumb, that breath of itches
and thirsts,
Ever the vexer's *hoot! hoot!* till we find where the sly one hides and bring him
forth,
Ever love, ever the sobbing liquid of life,
Ever the bandage under the chin, ever the trestles of death.

Here and there with dimes on the eyes walking,
To feed the greed of the belly the brains liberally spooning,
Tickets buying, taking, selling, but in to the feast never once going,
Many sweating, ploughing, thrashing, and then the chaff for payment
receiving,
A few idly owning, and they the wheat continually claiming.

This is the city and I am one of the citizens,
Whatever interests the rest interests me, politics, wars, markets, newspapers,
schools,
The mayor and councils, banks, tariffs, steamships, factories, stocks, stores,
real estate and personal estate.

The little plentiful manikins skipping around in collars and tail'd coats
I am aware who they are, (they are positively not worms or fleas,)
I acknowledge the duplicates of myself, the weakest and shallowest is
deathless with me,

What I do and say the same waits for them,
Every thought that flounders in me the same flounders in them.

I know perfectly well my own egotism,
Know my omnivorous lines and must not write any less,
And would fetch you whoever you are flush with myself.

30

Not words of routine this song of mine,
But abruptly to question, to leap beyond yet nearer bring;
This printed and bound book—but the printer and the printing-office boy?
The well-taken photographs—but your wife or friend close and solid in your
arms?
The black ship mail'd with iron, her mighty guns in her turrets—but the pluck
of the captain and engineers?
In the houses the dishes and fare and furniture—but the host and hostess,
and the look out of their eyes?
The sky up there—yet here or next door, or across the way?
The saints and sages in history—but you yourself?
Sermons, creeds, theology—but the fathomless human brain,
And what is reason? and what is love? and what is life?

35

40

~ 43 ~

I do not despise you priests, all time, the world over,
My faith is the greatest of faiths and the least of faiths,
Enclosing worship ancient and modern and all between ancient and modern,
Believing I shall come again upon the earth after five thousand years,
Waiting responses from oracles, honoring the gods, saluting the sun,
Making a fetich of the first rock or stump, powowing with sticks in the circle
of obis,
Helping the llama or brahmin as he trims the lamps of the idols,
Dancing yet through the streets in a phallic procession, rapt and austere in
the woods a gymnosophist,

5

Drinking mead from the skull-cap, to Shastas and Vedas admirant, minding
the Koran,
Walking the teokallis, spotted with gore from the stone and knife, beating the 10
serpent-skin drum,
Accepting the Gospels, accepting him that was crucified, knowing assuredly
that he is divine,
To the mass kneeling or the puritan's prayer rising, or sitting patiently in a pew,
Ranting and frothing in my insane crisis, or waiting dead-like till my spirit
arouses me,
Looking forth on pavement and land, or outside of pavement and land,
Belonging to the winders of the circuit of circuits. 15

One of that centripetal and centrifugal gang I turn and talk like a man leaving
charges before a journey.

Down-hearted doubters dull and excluded,
Frivolous, sullen, moping, angry, affected, dishearten'd, atheistical,
I know every one of you, I know the sea of torment, doubt, despair and
unbelief.

How the flukes splash! 20
How they contort rapid as lightning, with spasms and spouts of blood!

Be at peace bloody flukes of doubters and sullen mopers,
I take my place among you as much as among any,
The past is the push of you, me, all, precisely the same,
And what is yet untried and afterward is for you, me, all, precisely the same. 25

I do not know what is untried and afterward,
But I know it will in its turn prove sufficient, and cannot fail.

Each who passes is consider'd, each who stops is consider'd, not a single one
can it fail.

It cannot fail the young man who died and was buried,
Nor the young woman who died and was put by his side,
Nor the little child that peep'd in at the door, and then drew back and was
never seen again,
Nor the old man who has lived without purpose, and feels it with bitterness
worse than gall,
Nor him in the poor house tubercled by rum and the bad disorder,
Nor the numberless slaughter'd and wreck'd, nor the brutish koboo call'd the
ordure of humanity,
Nor the sacs merely floating with open mouths for food to slip in,
Nor any thing in the earth, or down in the oldest graves of the earth,
Nor any thing in the myriads of spheres, nor the myriads of myriads that
inhabit them,
Nor the present, nor the least wisp that is known.

30

35

~ 44 ~

It is time to explain myself—let us stand up.

What is known I strip away,
I launch all men and women forward with me into the Unknown.

The clock indicates the moment—but what does eternity indicate?

We have thus far exhausted trillions of winters and summers,
There are trillions ahead, and trillions ahead of them.

5

Births have brought us richness and variety,
And other births will bring us richness and variety.

I do not call one greater and one smaller,
That which fills its period and place is equal to any.

10

Were mankind murderous or jealous upon you, my brother, my sister?
I am sorry for you, they are not murderous or jealous upon me,
All has been gentle with me, I keep no account with lamentation,
(What have I to do with lamentation?)

I am an acme of things accomplish'd, and I am encloser of things to be. 15

My feet strike an apex of the apices of the stairs,
On every step bunches of ages, and larger bunches between the steps,
All below duly travel'd, and still I mount and mount.

Rise after rise bow the phantoms behind me,
Afar down I see the huge first Nothing, I know I was even there, 20
I waited unseen and always, and slept through the lethargic mist,
And took my time, and took no hurt from the fetid carbon.

Long I was hugg'd close—long and long.

Immense have been the preparations for me,
Faithful and friendly the arms that have help'd me. 25

Cycles ferried my cradle, rowing and rowing like cheerful boatmen,
For room to me stars kept aside in their own rings,
They sent influences to look after what was to hold me.

Before I was born out of my mother generations guided me,
My embryo has never been torpid, nothing could overlay it. 30

For it the nebula cohered to an orb,
The long slow strata piled to rest it on,
Vast vegetables gave it sustenance,
Monstrous sauroids transported it in their mouths and deposited it with care.

All forces have been steadily employ'd to complete and delight me,
Now on this spot I stand with my robust soul.

35

~ 45 ~

O span of youth! ever-push'd elasticity!
O manhood, balanced, florid and full.

My lovers suffocate me,
Crowding my lips, thick in the pores of my skin,
Jostling me through streets and public halls, coming naked to me at night,
Crying by day *Ahoy!* from the rocks of the river, swinging and chirping over
my head,
Calling my name from flower-beds, vines, tangled underbrush,
Lighting on every moment of my life,
Bussing my body with soft balsamic busses,
Noiselessly passing handfuls out of their hearts and giving them to be mine.

5

10

Old age superbly rising! O welcome, ineffable grace of dying days!

Every condition promulges not only itself, it promulges what grows after and
out of itself,
And the dark hush promulges as much as any.

I open my scuttle at night and see the far-sprinkled systems,
And all I see multiplied as high as I can cipher edge but the rim of the farther
systems.

15

Wider and wider they spread, expanding, always expanding,
Outward and outward and forever outward.

My sun has his sun and round him obediently wheels,
He joins with his partners a group of superior circuit,
And greater sets follow, making specks of the greatest inside them.

20

There is no stoppage and never can be stoppage,
If I, you, and the worlds, and all beneath or upon their surfaces, were this
moment reduced back to a pallid float, it would not avail the long run,
We should surely bring up again where we now stand,
And surely go as much farther, and then farther and farther.

A few quadrillions of eras, a few octillions of cubic leagues, do not hazard the 25
span or make it impatient,
They are but parts, any thing is but a part.

See ever so far, there is limitless space outside of that,
Count ever so much, there is limitless time around that.

My rendezvous is appointed, it is certain,
The Lord will be there and wait till I come on perfect terms, 30
The great Camerado, the lover true for whom I pine will be there.

~ 46 ~

I know I have the best of time and space, and was never measured and never
will be measured.

I tramp a perpetual journey, (come listen all!)
My signs are a rain-proof coat, good shoes, and a staff cut from the woods,
No friend of mine takes his ease in my chair,
I have no chair, no church, no philosophy, 5
I lead no man to a dinner-table, library, exchange,
But each man and each woman of you I lead upon a knoll,
My left hand hooking you round the waist,
My right hand pointing to landscapes of continents and the public road.

Not I, not any one else can travel that road for you, 10
You must travel it for yourself.

It is not far, it is within reach,
Perhaps you have been on it since you were born and did not know,
Perhaps it is everywhere on water and on land.

Shoulder your duds dear son, and I will mine, and let us hasten forth, 15
Wonderful cities and free nations we shall fetch as we go.

If you tire, give me both burdens, and rest the chuff of your hand on my
hip,
And in due time you shall repay the same service to me,
For after we start we never lie by again.

This day before dawn I ascended a hill and look'd at the crowded heaven, 20
And I said to my spirit *When we become the enfolders of those orbs, and the
pleasure and knowledge of every thing in them, shall we be fill'd and
satisfied then?*
And my spirit said *No, we but level that lift to pass and continue beyond.*

You are also asking me questions and I hear you,
I answer that I cannot answer, you must find out for yourself.

Sit a while dear son, 25
Here are biscuits to eat and here is milk to drink,
But as soon as you sleep and renew yourself in sweet clothes, I kiss you with a
good-by kiss and open the gate for your egress hence.

Long enough have you dream'd contemptible dreams,
Now I wash the gum from your eyes,
You must habit yourself to the dazzle of the light and of every moment of 30
your life.

Long have you timidly waded holding a plank by the shore,
Now I will you to be a bold swimmer,

To jump off in the midst of the sea, rise again, nod to me, shout, and
laughingly dash with your hair.

~ 47 ~

I am the teacher of athletes,
He that by me spreads a wider breast than my own proves the width of my
own,
He most honors my style who learns under it to destroy the teacher.

The boy I love, the same becomes a man not through derived power, but in
his own right,

Wicked rather than virtuous out of conformity or fear,
Fond of his sweetheart, relishing well his steak,
Unrequited love or a slight cutting him worse than sharp steel cuts,
First-rate to ride, to fight, to hit the bull's eye, to sail a skiff, to sing a song or
play on the banjo,
Preferring scars and the beard and faces pitted with small-pox over all
latherers,
And those well-tann'd to those that keep out of the sun.

5

10

I teach straying from me, yet who can stray from me?
I follow you whoever you are from the present hour,
My words itch at your ears till you understand them.

I do not say these things for a dollar or to fill up the time while I wait for a
boat,
(It is you talking just as much as myself, I act as the tongue of you,
Tied in your mouth, in mine it begins to be loosen'd.)

15

I swear I will never again mention love or death inside a house,
And I swear I will never translate myself at all, only to him or her who
privately stays with me in the open air.

If you would understand me go to the heights or water-shore,
The nearest gnat is an explanation, and a drop or motion of waves key,
The maul, the oar, the hand-saw, second my words. 20

No shutter'd room or school can commune with me,
But roughs and little children better than they.

The young mechanic is closest to me, he knows me well,
The woodman that takes his axe and jug with him shall take me with him all 25
day,
The farm-boy ploughing in the field feels good at the sound of my voice,
In vessels that sail my words sail, I go with fishermen and seamen and love
them.

The soldier camp'd or upon the march is mine,
On the night ere the pending battle many seek me, and I do not fail them,
On that solemn night (it may be their last) those that know me seek me. 30

My face rubs to the hunter's face when he lies down alone in his blanket,
The driver thinking of me does not mind the jolt of his wagon,
The young mother and old mother comprehend me,
The girl and the wife rest the needle a moment and forget where they are,
They and all would resume what I have told them. 35

~ 48 ~

I have said that the soul is not more than the body,
And I have said that the body is not more than the soul,
And nothing, not God, is greater to one than one's self is,
And whoever walks a furlong without sympathy walks to his own funeral
drest in his shroud,
And I or you pocketless of a dime may purchase the pick of the earth, 5
And to glance with an eye or show a bean in its pod confounds the learning
of all times,

And there is no trade or employment but the young man following it may
become a hero,
And there is no object so soft but it makes a hub for the wheel'd universe,
And I say to any man or woman, Let your soul stand cool and composed
before a million universes.

And I say to mankind, Be not curious about God,
For I who am curious about each am not curious about God,
(No array of terms can say how much I am at peace about God and about
death.)

10

I hear and behold God in every object, yet understand God not in the least,
Nor do I understand who there can be more wonderful than myself.

Why should I wish to see God better than this day?
I see something of God each hour of the twenty-four, and each moment then,
In the faces of men and women I see God, and in my own face in the glass,
I find letters from God dropt in the street, and every one is sign'd by God's
name,
And I leave them where they are, for I know that wheresoe'er I go,
Others will punctually come for ever and ever.

15

20

~ 49 ~

And as to you Death, and you bitter hug of mortality, it is idle to try to alarm
me.

To his work without flinching the accoucheur comes,
I see the elder-hand pressing receiving supporting,
I recline by the sills of the exquisite flexible doors,
And mark the outlet, and mark the relief and escape.

5

And as to you Corpse I think you are good manure, but that does not offend
me,

I smell the white roses sweet-scented and growing,
I reach to the leafy lips, I reach to the polish'd breasts of melons.

And as to you Life I reckon you are the leavings of many deaths,
(No doubt I have died myself ten thousand times before.)

10

I hear you whispering there O stars of heaven,
O suns—O grass of graves—O perpetual transfers and promotions,
If you do not say any thing how can I say any thing?

Of the turbid pool that lies in the autumn forest,
Of the moon that descends the steep of the soughing twilight,
Toss, sparkles of day and dusk—toss on the black stems that decay in the muck,
Toss to the moaning gibberish of the dry limbs.

15

I ascend from the moon, I ascend from the night,
I perceive that the ghastly glimmer is noonday sunbeams reflected,
And debouch to the steady and central from the offsprung great or small.

20

~ 50 ~

There is that in me—I do not know what it is—but I know it is in me.

Wrench'd and sweaty—calm and cool then my body becomes, I sleep—I sleep
long.

I do not know it—it is without name—it is a word unsaid,
It is not in any dictionary, utterance, symbol.

Something it swings on more than the earth I swing on,
To it the creation is the friend whose embracing awakes me.

5

Perhaps I might tell more. Outlines! I plead for my brothers and sisters.

Do you see O my brothers and sisters?
It is not chaos or death—it is form, union, plan—it is eternal life—it is
Happiness.

~ 51 ~

The past and present wilt—I have fill'd them, emptied them.
And proceed to fill my next fold of the future.

Listener up there! what have you to confide to me?
Look in my face while I snuff the sidle of evening,
(Talk honestly, no one else hears you, and I stay only a minute longer.) 5

Do I contradict myself?
Very well then I contradict myself,
(I am large, I contain multitudes.)

I concentrate toward them that are nigh, I wait on the door-slab.

Who has done his day's work? who will soonest be through with his supper? 10
Who wishes to walk with me?

Will you speak before I am gone? will you prove already too late?

~ 52 ~

The spotted hawk swoops by and accuses me, he complains of my gab and my
loitering.

I too am not a bit tamed, I too am untranslatable,
I sound my barbaric yawp over the roofs of the world.

The last scud of day holds back for me,
It flings my likeness after the rest and true as any on the shadow'd wilds, 5
It coaxes me to the vapor and the dusk.

I depart as air, I shake my white locks at the runaway sun,
I effuse my flesh in eddies, and drift it in lacy jags.

I bequeath myself to the dirt to grow from the grass I love,
If you want me again look for me under your boot-soles.

10

You will hardly know who I am or what I mean,
But I shall be good health to you nevertheless,
And filter and fibre your blood.

Failing to fetch me at first keep encouraged,
Missing me one place search another,
I stop somewhere waiting for you.

15

s · o · n · g *of* m · y · s · e · l · f

A Lexicon

A large part of the brilliance of “Song of Myself” is the raffishness and playfulness of its diction. The poem belongs in that way to the mid-nineteenth century’s love of linguistic play that also characterizes Dickens and Melville and Twain. The English language exploded in the nineteenth century. This must have been a function of English wealth and technical innovation, mixed with the expansion of the language through the British Empire to much of the world, and the emergence and continued development of parallel branches of the language in the United States and India and Canada and Australia. It was also the century of the development of mass literacy. When Wordsworth published *Lyrical Ballads*, something like 40 percent of English males could produce a signature, and less than 25 percent of English females. In the nineteenth century, especially in the United States, people were learning to read, a fact that shows up, poignantly, early in “Song of Myself”:

Have you practiced so long to learn to read?

Have you felt so proud to get at the meaning of poems?

This hard-bought acquisition of language and the development of technologies that delivered inexpensive books and magazines and newspapers must account for a certain word-drunkenness in the English language writers of mid-century that is unlike anything else in English except perhaps the verse of Chaucer and the plays of Shakespeare, two other moments when new technologies were delivering a wild mix of learned and vernacular language to a new class of people. Paul Zweig, in his study of Whitman, reports on a librarian in the New York Public Library, who remembered Walt Whitman arriving at regular intervals to look up words in the dictionary. In these annotations, we’ve

walked, informally and at random, in his footsteps, as we tried to look over his shoulder and track down for ourselves what the feel of many of his word choices must have been in 1855. Our principle of selection was perhaps arbitrary, a mix of curiosity at usages we didn't recognize and others that it simply never would have occurred to us to use. Whitman remarked, of Longfellow's poems, that they failed to take advantage of "the native raciness" of American English.

These notes, then, are undertaken in wonder, as homage to a poet, a poem, and a language. The line numbers refer first to the 1855 and then to the 1891–92 versions of the poem. We need to thank David Bonanno and Stephen Berg for encouraging this lexicon into existence and first printing it as a special supplement of *The American Poetry Review*. The authors of the lexicon are grateful to Geoffrey Nunberg for his advice and to Ed Folsom for his invaluable scholarship, especially his work on Walt Whitman and dictionaries.

1 : 1.1 *I celebrate myself,*

celebrate This is the first unexpected word in the poem. "Celebrate," of course, means now as it did then, to treat a person or occasion festively. It also meant to extol or praise and, according to the *American Heritage Dictionary*, "to make widely known, to display." Hence its association with celebrity. (Mark Twain's "The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County" was published in 1858.) But the word also had the elder meaning, primary in the *Oxford English Dictionary*, in which "to celebrate" was "to perform a religious ceremony" or to observe a day or person or event "with ceremonies of respect."

3 : 1.3 *For every atom belonging to me as good belongs to you.*

atom Epicurus or, for that matter, Lucretius could have given Whitman "atom," but he was an enthusiastic reader of popular science. One of the books Whitman reviewed in the *Brooklyn Eagle* in 1847 was the translation of a German science text, Justus Leibig's *Chemistry in Its Application to Physiology and Agriculture*. David Reynolds: "Leibig presented a scientific rationale for what would become one of Whitman's main answers to cynics: even if matter were all, nature constantly regenerates itself and turns death into life through chemical

transformation. . . . When an organism decomposed, its atoms were chemically recombined, immediately giving rise, in his words, 'to another arrangement of the atoms of the body, that is, to the production of a compound that did not exist before.' Every thirty years, he estimated, a billion people and several billion animals died and were absorbed into the earth. Their atoms became transferred to the earth, rocks, and the varieties of plant life, whose atoms in turn became the sources of new life. Whatever diseases they had were lost in the transforming process." (DR, p. 240)

8 : 2.3 *The distillation would intoxicate me also, but I shall not let it.*

distillation This is the first of many instances of his love of the terms of art from the nineteenth-century American trades and crafts. The word usually refers to the process of vaporizing a liquid in order to extract or purify some element in a complex substance through condensation, especially in making liquors and perfumes. Whitman uses it here in the secondary usage, meaning, "the product of distillation." He likes the word so well, he repeats it in the next line: *The atmosphere is not a perfume, it has no taste of the distillation, it is odorless.* At least one effect of using the word this way is that it puts the process back into the product; it's an aspect of his fascination with the way things are made and the work that goes into making them.

14 : 2.9 *Echos, ripples, and buzzed whispers . . . loveroot, silkthread, crotch and vine,*

loveroot "Lovage: a plant of the genus *Ligusticum*. Also called love-root, angelica, licorice root, wild celery, sea parsley." *Dictionary of American Regional English*, III, 48. A member of the parsley family, so it is a relative of wild carrot, or Queen Anne's lace.

silkthread Noah Webster gives his readers for "silk" "the fine soft thread produced by the insect called silk-worm or bombyx," but also "the filiform style of the female flower of maiz, which resembles real silk in fineness and softness" and "Virginia silk, a plant of the genus *Periploca*, which climbs and winds about other plants, trees, &c." The deliciousness of the line, of course, is the way Whitman

veers from his list of sounds and motions into vegetal and sexual imagery, as if the phrase “buzz’d whispers” introduced a new train of thought.

crotch “1. The angle or region of the angle formed by the junction of two parts or members, such as two branches, limbs, or legs.” (AHD)

17 : 2.12 *The sound of the belched words of my voice . . . words loosed to the eddies of the wind,*

belched There seems to be no shade of meaning of this word that doesn’t give you a burp or a violent eructation. Noah Webster gives as a secondary definition “to eject violently from a deep hollow place,” and the OED notices that it is used metaphorically for the action of cannons and volcanoes and notices that Thomas Carlyle, whose prose Whitman passionately admired, writes of “rusty firelocks” belching and in 1865 the batteries in Frances Parkman’s history of the French-Indian wars belch, so perhaps Whitman had a triumphantly military burst of sound in mind.

37 : 3.8 *Always the procreant urge of the world.*

procreant We’ve always thought this word, in this crucial line, was one of Whitman’s quasi-scientific coinages. It turns out that it has a quite distinguished literary ancestry. Shakespeare, *Macbeth*: “*this bird hath made his pendant bed and procreant cradle;*” Wordsworth, 1817: “*Her procreant vigils Nature keeps/ Amid the unfathomable deeps;*” Arthur Hugh Clough, 1849: “*The procreant heat and furor of our youth.*”

41 : 3.12 *Sure as the most certain sure . . . plumb in the uprights, well entretied, braced in the beams,*

well entretied Another word, in fact a whole line, from the trades. Whitman worked off and on as a carpenter and house-builder. “Entretied” is not in Webster. For “entrete” the OED gives “a plaster,” from the French, and remarks that it’s obsolete; a 1913 dictionary, *Century Dictionary and Encyclopedia*, gives “a bandage, a plaster.” One scholarly edition of the poem (EG) says the word means “cross-braced,” but cites no authority for this usage. So either plastered or cross-braced, and deliciously exact and of its time in either case.

42 : 3.13 *Stout as a horse, affectionate, haughty, electrical,*

electrical Whitman wrote this line some years after Michael Faraday's critical experiments on induction in 1839 and before James Maxwell's *Dynamical Theory of the Electromagnetic Field* in 1865. The world was coming to understand electromagnetic energy, and Whitman would live to see New York City ablaze with electric lights. There is a small literature on Whitman and magnetism and electricity that includes Joseph Beaver's *Walt Whitman—Poet of Science* and the work of David Reynolds. They've noted that he paraphrases the geologist Richard Owens when he writes, "*The sun there at the center though conceal'd, / Electric life forever at the center.*" He had also read Humboldt on animal magnetism and seemed in his nineteenth-century New Age milieu to have supposed an association between magnetism, electricity, and sexual energy that the phrenologists called "adhesiveness" and "amateness." The point here is that he is using a fashionable and up-to-date word to mean, roughly, "tingling with personal energy."

54 : 3.25 *Shall I postpone my acceptation and realization and scream at my eyes,*

acceptation The expected word would be "acceptance." But OED gives a contemporary instance of its use as "favorable reception," by H. Reed, *Lectures on English Literature*, 1855: "What else can explain the large acceptation, which a poem like Gray's 'Elegy' found at once?" which clues us to what must have been the flavor of the word for Whitman.

realization The OED is rich in useful possibilities. "1. The action of making real or investing with reality," which cites an 1881 usage: "... no realization of the fears which he expressed"; "2. the action of forming a clear and distinct concept," 1874: "a vivid realization of the person of Christ"; "3. the conversion of paper money or property into a more available form," 1881: "the realization of the insolvent's estate."

83 : 5.11 *And I know that the hand of God is the elderhand of my own,*

elderhand The word seems to be Whitman's invention. Quite amazingly, he dropped it from the 1881 edition of the poem, substituting the word "promise." See note to line 1283.

86 : 5.14 *And that a kelson of the creation is love;*

kelson On Long Island, when Whitman was growing up, and in the Brooklyn shipyards he had plenty of opportunity to observe the boatbuilding trade. AHD lists “kelson” as a variant of “keelson,” which it defines as “a timber or girder placed parallel with and bolted to the keel for additional strength.”

89 : 5.17 *And mossy scabs of the wormfence, and heaped stones, and elder and mullen and pokeweed.*

wormfence J. R. Bartlett’s 1848 *Dictionary of Americanisms* gives us this: “A rail fence laid up in a zig-zag manner.” And offers this citation, undated: “Mr. Haskell, one of the delegates from Tennessee, told a story about a man in his “diggins,” who was once struck by “Joe Larkins,” by which he was knocked at least forty rods. He fell against a *worm-fence*, and carried away about forty panels, rail-riders and all. —*N. Y. Mirror*.” Early English travelers described worm fences as particularly characteristic of the New York country landscape. And the Rev. Hugh Jones in 1724 in *The Present State of Virginia* notices them as a characteristic American form, though he’s not very exact: “Wormfences are made of rails supporting one another very firmly in a particular manner.” Dickens remarked of it in *American Notes*: “the primitive wormfence is universal, and an ugly thing it is.”

elder *Sambucus* is a genus of shrubs and small trees, having small white flowers and red or blackish berry-like fruit. All three of the plants in this line do well in the disturbed soil of roadsides, where one might find fences of wood or heaped stones.

mullen Common mullein, *verbascum thapsus*, is a member of the snapdragon family. It has, says the Peterson-Mckenny *Field Guide to the Wildflowers*, “large flannel-textured leaves” and yellow flowers in club-like flowerheads. It flowers through the summer and grows on roadsides and in vacant lots all over the northeast U.S.

pokeweed *Phytolacca Americana* is a plant of the eastern U.S., the only member of the family to grow there. It’s a weedy, large-leaved plant with coarse,

reddish stems. The field guide notices that the greenish-white sepals look like petals. The small flowers are white, the berries purple-black. Damp thickets, roadsides, clearings.

94 : 6.5 *A scented gift and remembrancer designedly dropped,*

remembrancer The passage is the argument from design recast as Victorian flirtation. The definition that captures this is from the OED: “A thing serving to remind one; a reminder; a memento, souvenir.” And gives us Hawthorne from *The House of Seven Gables* (1851), “The freckles . . . friendly remembrancers of the April sun and breeze” and W. D. Howells’ *Italian Journey* (1862): “A bit of sacred wood for a remembrancer.”

97 : 6.8 *Or I guess it is a uniform hieroglyphic,*

hieroglyphic Root *hieros*, “holy.” Paul Zweig gives a wonderful account (pp. 157–60) of Walt Whitman’s fascination with the “Egyptian Museum,” an exhibition in second story rooms at 659 Broadway in Manhattan of the personal collection of Egyptian artifacts of an English doctor, Henry Abbot, who had practiced medicine for thirty years in Cairo. Whitman wrote an article about the place in 1855. He read George Sand on the hermetic mysteries of Egypt and conducted “long talks” with Abbot about “the visual enigma of signs and stylized pictures known as hieroglyphics” and also about Osiris and Egyptian vegetative myths.

100 : 6.11 *Kanuck, Tuckahoe, Congressman, Cuff, I give them the same,
I receive them the same.*

Kanuck Slang for French Canadian. Bartlett spells it “cannuck” and gives “a name applied to Canadians by people in the Northern states.”

Tuckahoe Bartlett cites *The Farmer’s Encyclopedia*: “(*Lucoperdon solidu*. Clayton, *Flora Virginica*.) The Virginia truffle. A curious vegetable, sometimes called by the name of Indian Bread, or Indian Loaf, found in the Southern States, bordering on the Atlantic. It is a natural production, the origin of which has greatly perplexed naturalists, as it is commonly found several feet under the

surface, and, like the truffle of Europe, has apparently no stem or leafy appendage connecting it with the external atmosphere. . . . The Southern botanists regard the *tuckahoe* as a fungus." And he adds, "The term *tuckahoe* is often applied to an inhabitant of Lower Virginia, and to the poor land in that section of the State."

Cuff Slang for African American. We haven't been able to track the origin of this phrase. It appears in a lot of nineteenth-century American writing as an African American name, including the apocryphal story of the vaudevillian James Rice and the origin of "Jim Crow."

103 : 6.14 *It may be you transpire from the breasts of young men,*

transpire Webster, 1828: "to emit through the pores of the skin; to send off in vapor." AHD: "to give off (vapor containing waste products) through the pores of the skin or the stomata of plant tissue." Interesting to its use here, if it is primarily a technical, botanical term.

127 : 7.6 *I am not an earth nor an adjunct of an earth,*

adjunct This is another example of Whitman's pure love of the odd and unexpected word, which, it turns out, has a number of technical meanings. The 1828 Webster:

[L. *adjunctus*, joined, from *adjungo*. See *Join*.]

1. Something added to another, but not essentially a part of it; as, water absorbed by a cloth or sponge is its adjunct. Also a person joined to another.
2. In metaphysics, a quality of the body or the mind, whether natural or acquired; as color, in the body; thinking, in the mind.
3. In grammar, words added to illustrate or amplify the force of other words; as, the *History of the American Revolution*. The words in *Italics* are the adjuncts of *History*.
4. In music, the word is employed to denominate the relation between the principal mode and the modes of its two fifths.
5. The adjunct deities, among the Romans, were inferior deities which were added as assistants to the principal gods; as Bellona to Mars; to Vulcan, the Cabiri; to the Good Genius, the Lares; to the Evil, the Lemures.

6. In the royal academy of sciences at Paris, the adjuncts are certain members attached to the study of particular sciences. They are twelve in number, created in 1716.

7. Adjunct has been used for a colleague, but rarely.

And then Webster cites the term as an adjective—applied to professors. “a. Added to or united with, as an adjunct professor.” So they were trying to figure out how not to pay teachers a living wage even in 1828.

138 : 7.16 *I see through the broadcloth and gingham whether or no,*

broadcloth “1. a densely textured woolen cloth with a plain or twill weave and a lustrous finish. 2. A closely woven silk, cotton, or synthetic fabric with a narrow crosswise rib.” (AHD)

gingham “A yarn-dyed cotton fabric woven in stripes, checks, plaids, or solid colors.” (AHD). It’s characteristic that he specifies the fabrics. Here is Kris Driesen, an historian of American quilting, commenting on women’s clothing in the nineteenth century in “The Influence of American Women’s Lives on Textiles,” at the *Quilt History* website: “For most of the 19th century, women spent their days in severely restrictive clothing. Even servant class women wore a minimum of four layers of clothing, year round. A woman’s clothing could weigh up to 40 pounds. It started with the chemise (a slip-type garment that served as a bra) and pantaloons (long underpants with a slit in the middle so a chamberpot could be used without undressing). These were worn under a corset with a corset cover. The hourglass shape was highly desired and no woman ever considered leaving her bedroom in the morning without being tightly laced. Hoops and petticoats were then overlaid, the number depending on current fashion. THEN the woman dressed in long sleeved, floor length dresses depending on her chores for the day.”

146 : 8.7 *The blab of the pave . . . the tires of carts and sluff of bootsoles and talk of the promenaders,*

blab Webster gives us the verb “to blab” (“to utter or tell in a thoughtless manner”) and the noun “blab” (“a babbler; a telltale”), but neither quite captures Whitman’s wonderful invention of the city street as a babbler; and **pave** for

“pavement” seems to be his own stylish shorthand. Neither Webster nor Bartlett lists the word as a noun; the OED finds an instance in a poem in *Harpers* in 1881—“I see them on every pave in Rome”—but it could well be a borrowing from Whitman.

sluff Not Webster or Bartlett or the OED gives us the sound of feet on pavement, either in this spelling or the more common “slough,” as in sloughing off a skin, so this is probably pure onomatopoeitic invention.

147 : 8.8 *The heavy omnibus, the driver with his interrogating thumb, the
clank of the shod horses on the granite floor,*

omnibus OED: “A four-wheeled public vehicle for carrying passengers with the inside seats extending along the sides and entrance at the rear, with or without seats on the roof.” The term came into use in 1828, which may date the beginning of modern urban life. “Brower established New York City’s first public transportation route in 1827, a 12-seat stagecoach called ‘Accommodation’ that ran along Broadway from the Battery to Bleecker Street. By 1831, Brower had added the ‘Sociable’ and ‘Omnibus.’ The next year, John Mason organized the New York and Harlem Railroad, a street railway that used horse-drawn cars with metal wheels and ran on metal track. By 1855, 593 omnibuses traveled on 27 Manhattan routes and horse-drawn cars ran on street railways on Third, Fourth, Sixth, and Eighth Avenues” (www.mta.info/nyct/facts/ffhist.htm). See also Beaver, Ch. 1, page 1: “Whitman surveyed nature from the top of a Broadway omnibus.”

159 : 8.19 *I mind them or the resonance of them . . . I come again and again.*

resonance “*Path.* The sound heard in auscultation of the chest while the person is speaking, or that elicited by percussion of various parts of the body. P. M. LATHAM *Lect. Clin. Med.* I., i. 15: ‘There are other sounds . . . entirely produced by our percussion of the præcordial region. These should rather be called resonances than sounds.’” (OED). Another instance of Whitman’s wide reading and exquisite exactness. The modern meaning (AHD: “Richness or significance, especially in evoking an association or strong emotion”) was also available. Carlyle, *History of the French Revolution*: “He had a resonance in his bosom for every note of human feeling.”

163 : 9.4 *The armfuls are packed to the sagging mow:*

mow AHD was still in 1978 defining the noun as “1. a place for storing hay or grain. 2. Feed so stored.” Whitman spent his early childhood on a Long Island farm.

166 : 9.7 *I jump from the crossbeams, and seize the clover and timothy,*

timothy AHD: “A grass, *Phleum pretense*, native to Eurasia, having narrow, cylindrical flower-spikes, and widely cultivated for hay. [Said to have been taken from New York to the Carolinas in 1720 by *Timothy* Hanson, American farmer.]”

173 : 10.6 *The Yankee clipper is under her three skysails . . . she cuts the
sparkle and scud,*

Yankee clipper A clipper was (AHD) “a sharp-bowed sailing vessel of the mid-nineteenth century, having tall masts and sharp lines and built for great speed.”

sky-sails AHD: “a small square sail above the royal in a square-rigged vessel.” A royal was “a sail set on the royal mast.” The royal mast was “a small mast immediately above the topgallant mast.” The topgallant mast was “the mast above the topmast.” The topmast was “the mast that is below the topgallant mast in a square-rigged ship.” The point is that Whitman registers precisely the technology that gave the ship its speed and splendid look.

sparkle and scud Webster 1828 defines “scud” as “a low, thin cloud, or cloud driven by rain.” The first meanings in the OED relate to clouds but also give us “open foam and spray driven by the wind” and cite 1850 as the earliest nautical usage. AHD: “*Nautical*: To run before a gale with little or no sail set,” and for the noun “Wind-driven clouds, mist, or rain” and “A sudden light shower.” For “sparkle” Webster gives “a spark; a luminous particle” and OED, among other definitions, “a lively brightness.” Its application to the play of light on the sea seems to be Whitman’s invention.

185 : 10.17 *Through the swung half-door of the kitchen I saw him limpsey and weak,*

limpsey Though the exactness of “the swung half-door” deserves comment, it probably doesn’t need annotation, except to inquire how doors cut in half horizontally so that either the upper or lower part could be opened separately acquired the name, in English, of “Dutch door.” Limpsey: variation of “limp.” “E. BURRITT *Walk Land’s End* viii., 284: ‘That child . . . makes two steps forward before its limpsy body loses its balance.’ WHITMAN, *Sel. Poems 1868* 119 ‘The death-howl, the limpsey tumbling body, the rush of friend and foe thither.’” (OED)

190 : 10.22 *And remember putting plasters on the galls of his neck and ankles;*
galls AHD: “a skin sore caused by friction or abrasion: a saddle gall.” The term was applied to humans by 1440.

192 : 10.24 *I had him sit next me at table . . . my firelock leaned in the corner.*

firelock In the mid-nineteenth century firelocks—long-barreled guns with an ignition created by friction or percussion and smooth-bored—were being replaced in the British and U.S. armies by rifles—long-barreled guns with spiral bores, which made them more accurate and more deadly, a technical innovation that contributed to the carnage of the Civil War. Whitman may be using the name of the older gun to portray his rustic speaker in this passage. The gun was presumably there to protect the fugitive from slavecatchers. (The infamous Fugitive Slave Act was passed in 1850.) See Alexander Rose, *American Rifle: A Biography*, New York, 2008.

193 : 11.1 *Twenty-eight young men bathe by the shore,*

Twenty-eight young men Though it’s been our intention to gloss and not interpret the poem, it seems worth pointing out here that scholars have guessed that Whitman’s interest in Egyptian mythology led him to construct this scene, even as it feels like something from a (particularly daring) Victorian novel, as a fable of the lunar cycle, in which the moon goddess, Isis, has twenty-eight young male consorts, one for each day of the lunar month.

212 : 12.2 *I loiter enjoying his repartee and his shuffle and breakdown.*

shuffle and breakdown Here is Justin Kaplan quoting Whitman on butcher boys: “And when they have nothing else to do, they amuse themselves with a jig, or a breakdown. The capacities of the ‘market-roarers’ in all the mysteries of a double shuffle, it needs not our word to endorse.” For “breakdown,” OED gives “a riotous dance, with which balls are often terminated in the country; a dance in the peculiar style of the negroes. U.S.” and cites Bartlett as a source, and this sentence from *New England Tales* (1864): “Don’t clear out when the quadrilles are over, for we are going to have a breakdown to wind up with.” “Shuffle” survives into AHD: “A dance in which the feet scrape along the floor at each step.”

Here is Wikipedia on minstrel dancing: “Dances like the Turkey Trot, the Buzzard Lope, and the Juba dance all had their origins in the plantations of the South, and some were popularized by black performers such as William Henry Lane, Signor Cornmeali (‘Old Corn Meal’), and John ‘Picayune’ Butler. One performance by Lane in 1842 was described as consisting of ‘sliding steps, like a shuffle, and not the high steps of an Irish jig.’ Lane and the white men who mimicked him moved about the stage with no obvious foot movement. The walkaround, a common feature of the minstrel show’s first act, was ultimately of West African origin and featured a competition between individuals hemmed in by the other minstrels. Elements of white tradition remained, of course, such as the fast-paced *breakdown* that formed part of the repertoire beginning with Rice.”

213 : 12.4 *Blacksmiths with grimed and hairy chests environ the anvil,*

environ Webster 1828: “1. To surround; to encompass; to encircle; as a plain environed with mountains. 2. To involve; to envelop; as, to environ with darkness, or with difficulties. 3. To besiege; as a city environed with troops.” An image of several smiths in a shop working around the same anvil; the vowel sounds must have taken him to this phrasing.

214 : 12.4 *Each has his main-sledge . . . they are all out . . . there is a great heat in the fire.*

main-sledge For “sledge” OED gives “a large, heavy hammer, usually wielded with both hands, especially the large hammer used by a blacksmith.” None of the dictionaries give us “main-sledge”; it was presumably a term of art for the smith’s main or heaviest hammer.

216 : 12.6 *The lithe sheer of their waists plays even with their massive arms,*

sheer Possibly a metaphor from (AHD) “the upward curve, or the amount of upward curve, of the longitudinal lines of a ship’s hull, as seen from the side.”

219 : 13.1 *The negro holds firmly the reins of his four horses . . . the block swags underneath on its tied-over chain,*

We are not sure what’s going on here, though it is evident that Whitman does. The **block** could be “a heavy piece of timber or wood, usually with one plain surface; or it is rectangular, and rather thick than long” (Webster 1828) that the dray is carrying, or else a very large “piece of wood in which a pulley runs; used also for the pulley, or the block itself and the sheaves, or wheels” (also Webster). **swag** Webster 1828: “To sink down by its weight; to lean.” The OED cites a relevant usage from 1876: “A timber-dray . . . with a great trunk swinging and swagging on the road.”

220 : 13.2 *The negro that drives the huge dray of the stoneyard . . . steady and tall he stands poised on one leg on the stringpiece,*

dray AHD: “A low, heavy cart without sides, used for haulage.”

stringpiece “(a) a long piece of timber serving to connect and support a framework (e.g. a floor, bridge); a longitudinal railway-sleeper (U.S.); a heavy squared timber carried along the edge of a wharf-front.” (OED)

222 : 13.4 *His glance is calm and commanding . . . he tosses the slouch of his hat away from his forehead,*

slouch As a noun, referring to “the fact or condition of slouching,” OED gives

an 1851 instance from Mayne Reid: “under the slouch of broad sombreros.” Later the look became the thing: “a soft hat with a broad flexible brim” (AHD).

226 : 13.8 *In me the caresser of life wherever moving . . . backward as well as forward slueing,*

slueing Webster 1828: “In seaman’s language, to turn anything conical or cylindrical &c about its axis without removing it; to turn.” AHD: To slue is “to turn or twist (something) sideways” or “to twist (a mast or boom) around on its axis.” Another example of Whitman’s metaphorical use of a nineteenth-century technical term.

236 : 13.19 *And the mocking bird in the swamp never studied the gamut,*

gamut OED: “2. The ‘Great Scale’ (of which the invention is ascribed to Guido d’Arezzo), comprising the seven hexachords or partial scales, and consisting of all the recognized notes used in mediæval music. It extended from *ut* (= G on the lowest line of the bass stave) to *E-la* (= E in the highest space of the treble). *Obs. exc. Hist.*” “3. Hence in later use: The whole series of notes that are recognized by musicians. Sometimes also used for: The major diatonic scale, or the ‘scale’ recognized by any particular people, or at any period.” (OED). See Zweig on Whitman’s love of opera, 46–48.

258 : 15.2 *The carpenter dresses his plank . . . the tongue of his foreplane whistles its wild ascending lisp,*

foreplane OED: “1842 GWILT, *Encycl. Archit.* Gloss.,: *Fore Plane*: in carpentry and joinery the first plane used after the saw or axe. 1847 EMERSON, *Repr. Men, Uses Gt. Men* Wks. (Bohn) I., 278: Every carpenter who shaves with a fore-plane borrows the genius of a forgotten inventor.”

260 : 15.4 *The pilot seizes the king-pin, he heaves down with a strong arm,*

king-pin AHD gives for “king-bolt”: “A vertical bolt that joins the body of a wagon or other vehicle to its front axle and usually acts as a pivot; also called *kingpin*.” The context seems nautical, but none of the nautical dictionaries we consulted give us this word.

268 : 15.12 *The jour printer with gray head and gaunt jaws works at his case,*

jour OED: “U.S. colloq. abbrev. of JOURNEYMAN. 1854 B. P. Shillaber, *Life & Sayings Mrs. Partington*, 146: ‘I wouldn’t be so bothered about *my* meals,’ said a jour printer to a brother typo.”

case OED: “*Printing*. The receptacle or frame in which the compositor has his types, divided into compartments for the various letters, figures, and spaces.”

269 : 15.13 *He turns his quid of tobacco,*

quid “1. A small lump of something (esp. tobacco) for chewing. Also *fig.*” (OED). A variant of “cud” and in common use in the nineteenth century. 1884: “His mind was revolving the problem of existence like a quid of gum.”

272 : 15.16 *The quadroon girl is sold at the stand . . . the drunkard nods by
the barroom stove,*

quadroon “1. A person who is by descent three-quarters white and one-quarter black; a person with one black grandparent. Formerly also: a person with one black great-grandparent (*obs. rare*).” (OED)

279 : 15.23 *The woollypates hoe in the sugarfield, the overseer views them
from his saddle;*

woollypates Bartlett on “woolyheads,” 1859: “A term applied in the first instance to negroes, and then to anti-slavery politicians.”

282 : 15.26 *The Wolverine sets traps on the creek that helps fill the Huron,*

Wolverine OED: “3. A nickname for an inhabitant of Michigan. 1835 C. F. HOFFMAN, *Winter in Far West*: The genuine wolverine, or naturalized Michigania.”

Huron There are three Huron Rivers in Michigan. A trapper, so we are probably in the Upper Peninsula.

288 : 15.30 *The young sister holds out the skein, the elder sister winds it off in
a ball and stops now and then for the knots,*

skein OED: “1. a. A quantity of thread or yarn, wound to a certain length upon a reel, and usually put up in a kind of loose knot.”

291 *The nine months’ gone is in the parturition chamber, her faintness and
pains are advancing;*

parturition chamber OED: “1. a. Chiefly *techn.* and *literary.* The action of giving birth to young; childbirth. Also: a confinement.” Not clear whether he has a physical room in mind or the act of giving birth. See Richard and Dorothy Wertz, *Lying In: A History of Childbirth in America*, 1977.

292 : 15.33 *The pavingman leans on his twohanded rammer—*

rammer “An instrument for ramming or beating down earth, or forcing stones into the ground; a piledriver.” (OED). Records a use of the term in 1497. Also, “5. *coarse slang.* the penis.”

293 : 15.34 *The canal-boy trots on the towpath—*

towpath “A path by the side of a canal or navigable river for use in towing. 1882 R. MACKENZIE, *America*, 305: ‘He had begun life on the towpath as a driver of mules.’” (OED)

299 *The camera and plate are prepared, the lady must sit for her
daguerreotype,*

camera and plate A very basic description of the parts involved in the creation of a **daguerreotype**. The daguerreotype, invented by Louis Daguerre in France in 1839, was a pioneering photographic process. Walt Whitman haunted Matthew Brady’s daguerreotype studio on Broadway in Manhattan, and remarked about *Leaves of Grass* in his journals, “In these Leaves everything is literally photographed. Nothing is poeticized.” See Reynolds on Whitman and photography, 280–86.

307 : 15.47 *The crew of the fish-smack pack repeated layers of halibut in the hold,*

fish-smack “1. A single-masted sailing-vessel, fore-and-aft rigged like a sloop or cutter, and usually of light burden, chiefly employed as a coaster or for fishing, and formerly as a tender to a ship of war.” (OED)

311 : 15.51 *In single file each shouldering his hod pass onward the laborers;*

hod OED: “An open receptacle for carrying mortar, and sometimes bricks or stones, to supply builders at work; also the quantity carried in it, a hodful.”

315 : 15.55 *The stumps stand thick round the clearing, the squatter strikes deep with his axe,*

squatter “1809 KENDALL, *Travels*: ‘Upon visiting his lands, he finds possession taken by a race of men, (the settlers and lumberers,) who in this view are called squatters.’” (OED)

316 : 15.56 *The flatboatmen make fast toward dusk near the cottonwood or pekantrees,*

flatboatmen Flat-boat: “U.S. A large roughly-made boat formerly much used for floating goods, etc. down the Mississippi and other western rivers. 1837 MARTINEAU, *Society in America*: Notwithstanding the increase of steam-boats in the Mississippi, flat boats are still much in use. 1883 C. F. WOOLSON, *For the Major*: African slaves poling their flat-boats along the Southern rivers.” (OED). The pecan trees give us a Southern river.

318 : 15.58 *The torches shine in the dark that hangs on the Chattahoochee or Altamahaw;*

Chattahoochee The Chattahoochee originates in the Appalachians in north-east Georgia and flows southwestward to Atlanta, where it turns straight south and joins the Apalachicola in the Florida panhandle. The name comes from the Creek language.

Altamahaw Originates at the confluence of the Oconee and the Ocmulgee and

flows east through central Georgia to the Atlantic. The names of many other rivers figure in the poem: the Red, the Tennessee, the Arkansas, the Elkhorn, the Niagara, and the Mississippi. Rivers and canals were still the transportation infrastructure of the United States in 1855. The great push for a transcontinental railroad began in the 1860s.

334 : 16.9 *A boatman over the lakes or bays or along coasts . . . a Hoosier,
a Badger, a Buckeye,*

Hoosier “a. A nickname for a native or inhabitant of the state of Indiana.” (OED). Often pejoratively used, but not in the case of Whitman’s poem.

Badger “a. Esp. in Wisconsin: a lead miner, *spec.* one who lives in a dugout close to the diggings. Now *hist.* and *rare.* b. A native or inhabitant of Wisconsin.” (OED)

Buckeye “2. a. A native of Ohio, the ‘Buckeye State’, in which the *Æsculus glabra* abounds. *colloq.*” (OED)

335 *A Louisianian or Georgian, a poke-easy from sandhills and pines,*

poke-easy “A slow or lazy person or animal; slow, easy-going.” (DARE). Mainly a Southern expression. 1851 *Southern Literary Messenger*: “She couldn’t bear, she said, your psalm-singing, poke-easy, good-for-nothing, dumbfounded, sighing sort of beaux.”

337 : 16.11 *At home in the fleet of iceboats, sailing with the rest and tacking,*

iceboats The term was used both for ice-breaking ships and for “a boat mounted on runner for propulsion on the ice” (OED), which these probably are. 1819: “They go with incredible swiftness, sometimes so quick as to affect the breath.” 1868: “The river had good sport for skaters and the navigators of ice-boats.”

342 : 16.16 *A novice beginning experient of myriads of seasons,*

experient This is pure styling, or “flash” as they might have said in New York in 1854. OED includes the word—meaning “having experience, or being acquainted with”—and describes it as obsolete. It was used in 1420, “the awardeyne with his rodde experient” and in a Chapman play in 1630.

345 : 16.18 *A farmer, mechanic, or artist . . . a gentlemen, sailor, lover or quaker,*
quaker Since the word is not capitalized, it isn't clear whether he means a Quaker or, in contrast to "lover," a faint-hearted person.

346 : 16.19 *A prisoner, fancy-man, rowdy, lawyer, physician or priest.*

fancy-man In the nineteenth century "the Fancy" was the art of boxing and all the stylish hangers-on associated with the sport. And OED: "c. *slang*. A man who lives upon the earnings of a prostitute." 1821: "One of the Fancy, he was not a fancy-man." 1890: "They will bear from the 'fancy-man' any usage, however brutal."

rowdy "Of American, but otherwise quite obscure, origin," says the OED. "Originally, a backwoodsman of a rough and lawless type; hence, a rough, disorderly person; one addicted to quarrelling, fighting, or disturbing the peace." 1824: "The riotous roisters, or as they are here [Kentucky] called, rowdies, will fight from mere love of fighting."

349 : 16.22 *And am not stuck up, and am in my place.*

stuck up The expression seems to have been a nineteenth-century invention. Dickens, *Nicholas Nickleby*, 1839: "He's a nasty stuck-up monkey, that's what I consider him,' said Mrs. Squeers."

363 *It is for the admirable communes of literary men and composers and singers and lecturers and engineers and savans,*

commune A French administrative term until a revolutionary group calling themselves the Commune of Paris seized political control of the city in 1789, so it can mean at once "a village" and "a self-declared revolutionary community."

savans In James P. Warren's *Walt Whitman's Language Experiment*, he comments on Whitman's taste for borrowing foreign words to coin new ones in English: "The words are based on foreign borrowings, but often Whitman either alters the foreign base to create an original word or employs foreign endings to create an original combination with lexically established English word." The examples he gives include "savans," "venerealee," "compend," "promulge," and "debouch." So 'savants,' learned persons, become 'savans.'"

365 *This is the trill of a thousand clear cornets and scream of the octave flute
and strike of triangles.*

octave flute “*n.* (a) a small flute sounding an octave higher than the ordinary flute, a piccolo; (b) a flute stop in an organ sounding an octave higher than the ordinary pitch.” (OED)

369 : 18.6 *I sound triumphal drums for the dead . . . I fling through my
embouchures the loudest and gayest music to them,*

embouchures “*Music.* ‘The part of a musical instrument applied to the mouth’ (Grove).” (OED) And here, probably, the mouth formed for that purpose.

375 : 19.4 *The keptwoman and sponger and thief are hereby invited . . .
the heavy-lipped slave is invited . . . the venerealee is invited,*

keptwoman Whitman’s spelling in the 1855 edition. He later revised to “kept woman.”

sponger Though it is not in NW, this term for “one who lives meanly at other’s expense” goes back at least to the late seventeenth century in England.

venerealee A coinage that presumably means a leech, or possibly someone afflicted with a venereal disease.

377 : 19.6 *This is the press of a bashful hand . . . this is the float and odor of hair,*

float This is a sweet invention. Presumably he just means “flowing.” Among the twenty or so meanings for this word in the OED, there seems no meaning with an American or technical provenience.

380 : 19.10 *This is the thoughtful merge of myself and the outlet again.*

merge “An act or instance of merging; a merger” says the OED, which remarks that the word is very rare as a noun. Here it is for all practical purposes a coinage. And “outlet” gives it a watery connotation and its suggestion of “margin.”

outlet Hence “a channel of egress or discharge, a vent, a way out.” In extended use: “a way out of a difficulty; a means of escape or relief; (also) a way of expressing or releasing emotion, energy, talent, etc. *c. fig.* Issue, outcome. *Obs. rare.*” (OED)

384 : 19.14 *Does the daylight astonish? or the early redstart twittering through
the woods?*

redstart A warbler, *Setophaga ruticilla*, of the eastern U.S. winters in Mexico and the West Indies, so its return to the woods signals the beginning of spring.

391 : 20.4 *All I mark as my own you shall offset it with your own,*

offset We wondered if “offset” was a particularly modern verb. OED says it is, in the meaning “to set off as an equivalent against something else, to counter balance,” chiefly an American usage. The earliest example it gives is from 1792. And then there is this, since Whitman worked in printer’s offices: “*Printing = to set off* at SET v. Phrasal verbs. Also occas. *trans.* 1888 C. T. JACOBI, *Printers’ Vocab.*, 122: When the ink off-sets from one sheet to another.”

395 *That life is a suck and a sell, and nothing remains at the end but thread-
bare crape and tears.*

suck Bartlett glosses this, so it was apparently common slang in 1856: “A monstrous humbug—a grand suck in.” The OED in its turn cites Bartlett: “7. *slang.* A deception; a disappointing event or result. Also *suck-in.* 1856 Dow *Serm.* II. 316 (Bartlett): A monstrous humbug, a grand suck in.”

sell In the sense of “swindle,” the OED dates this word from 1853. It was apparently racetrack slang. 1857: “The thing is what in the language of the turf is called ‘a sell.’”

crape OED: “1. a. A thin transparent gauze-like fabric, plain woven, without any twill, of highly twisted raw silk or other staple, and mechanically embossed, so as to have a crisped or minutely wrinkled surface. The name originally comprised fine worsted fabrics (see b.); but it is now chiefly limited to a black silk (or imitation silk) fabric much used for ladies’ mourning dresses, and for funereal trimming and draping.”

396 : 20.8 *Whimpering and truckling fold with powders for invalids . . .
conformity goes to the fourth-removed,*

truckling Webster 1828 on “truckle”: “To yield or bend obsequiously to the will of another; to submit; to creep. Small states must truckle to large ones.” The OED cites Thackeray in *The Book of Snobs*, 1848: “The habit of truckling and cringing.”

fold It seems that the metaphor here is that the obsequious body folds like the folds of paper in which medicines were purchased.

fourth-removed OED on “removed”: “Distant in relationship by a certain degree of descent or consanguinity.” A continuation of the sardonic metaphors of social submission—it’s the poor relations who have to cringe.

408 : 20.20 *I know I shall not pass like a child’s carlacue cut with a burnt stick
at night.*

carlacue A variant spelling of curlicue, which the OED *Supplement* (1930) finds in 1840: “I soon saw by the way in which the white man’s track doubled and doubled again . . . that the fellow could not be cutting such carlicues for nothing.” For “curlicue”: “a fantastic curl or twist.” Here is Bartlett: “Carlicues, or Curlycues. Boyish tricks, capers. *To cut* or *cut up carlicues* is to cut capers.” “‘Sally,’ says I, ‘will you take me for better or worse?’ This put her considering, and I gave a flourishing about the room, and cut a curlycue with my right foot, as much as to say, ‘Take your own time.’” —*McClintock’s Tales*

412 : 20.24 *I reckon I behave no prouder than the level I plant my house by
after all.*

level Another term from the carpenter’s craft. Webster 1828: “An instrument in mechanics by which to find or draw a horizontal line, as in setting buildings, or in making canals and drains. The instruments for these purposes are various; as the air level, the carpenter’s level, the mason’s level, and the gunner’s level.”

419 : 20.31 *My foothold is tenoned and mortised in granite,*

tenoned OED: “furnished or made with a tenon.” A tenon is “a projection fashioned on the end or the side of a piece of wood, to fit into a corresponding cavity, or MORTISE, as a corresponding piece.”

mortised “1. a. *trans.* To fasten or join securely; to fix in or join together closely and firmly; (*Joinery*) to join with a mortise; to fasten *into* or *to* by means of mortise and tenon; to secure (a tenon) with a mortise. Also *fig.*” In the 1850s in the United States mortise and tenon construction began to give way to balloon frame construction, made possible—and fast—by machine-produced penny-nails. Gideon: “in America materials were plentiful and skilled labor scarce; in Europe skilled labor was plentiful and materials scarce. It is this difference which accounts for differences in the structure of American and European industry from the fifties on.”

425 : 21.3 *The first I graft and increase upon myself . . .*

graft A horticulturist’s term, but *increase upon myself*, though clear enough, is such an odd and unexpected phrasing.

429 : 21.7 *I chant a new chant of dilation or pride,*

dilation The noun form is not in Webster 1828, who defines “dilate” : “1. To expand; to distend; to enlarge or extend in all directions; opposed to contract. The air dilates the lungs; air is dilated by rarefaction. 2. To enlarge; to relate at large; to tell copiously or diffusely; as, to dilate upon the policy of a measure. In this sense, it is generally used intransitively. Spenser and Shakespeare have used it in a transitive sense; as, to dilate a theme.” OED finds in Charles Lamb in 1823 “Those natural dilations of the youthful spirit.”

436 : 21.14 *Press close magnetic nourishing night!*

magnetic See the note on **electrical**, line 42. And there was among Whitman’s phrenological friends another sense of the word. Kaplan: “‘I openly avow my belief in Animal Magnetism,’ Orson (Fowler, Whitman’s publisher) announced, ‘because I have seen so many facts and experiments that I know it to be true.’”

The universe was represented as a vast battery of ‘irradiating power’ or ‘nervous force’ that worked on principles conveniently confused with those of the magnetic telegraph.” (p. 150)

442 : 21.20 *Earth of the vitreous pour of the full moon just tinged with blue!*

vitreous OED: “1. a. Of or belonging to, consisting or composed of, glass; of the nature of glass; glassy. 3. *vitreous electricity*, positive electricity obtained from glass by friction.” In use in the seventeenth century. In the nineteenth: “He had left the vitreous and mercurial climate of France . . . for the voluptuous and indolent air of Italy.”

445 : 21.23 *Far-swooping elbowed earth!*

elbowed The first use of this adjective the OED finds in 1825: “c. Formed into the shape of an elbow, bent, curved.” The instance is “An elbowed seat had been introduced.”

462 : 22.12 *Partaker of influx and efflux . . . extoler of hate and conciliation,*

influx and efflux OED: “influx: The act or fact of flowing in; an inflow, as of a physical fluid, water, air, light, heat, spiritual or immaterial influence into the soul, etc.” “efflux: 1. A flowing outwards of water or other liquid; a stream, river. Also, of air, gases, volatile particles, magnetic or electric currents, etc.; opposed to *afflux* or *influx*. Also *attrib*. Hence, a channel of outflow.” Bacon uses them both as scientific terms in 1626. 1823: “A strong influx of light.” 1860: “. . . the influx of His grace.”

463 : 22.13 *Extoler of amies and those that sleep in each others’ arms.*

amies According to the OED “amy” for “friend or lover” was in use in England in the 1300s and not after.

468 *Washes and razors for foofoos . . . for me freckles and a bristling beard.*

foofoos Bartlett: “In New York a slang word meaning ‘an outsider.’ Or one not in on the secrets of a society, party, or band.” He provides this instance: “Don’t know what a foo-foo is? Well, as you’re a greenhorn, I’ll enlighten you. A foo-foo,

or outsider, is a chap who can't come the big figure." The "big figure" was "three cents for a glass of grog and a night's lodgings" according to a play set in the Bowery. Mark Twain entitled Chapter 17 of *The Prince and the Pauper* "Foo-foo the First."

473 : 22.21 *Did you fear some scrofula out of the unflagging pregnancy?*

scrofula An old medical term for chronic enlargement of the lymph gland. In 1828 Webster defined it this way: "A disease, called vulgarly the king's evil, characterized by hard, scirrous, and often indolent tumors in the glands of the neck, under the chin, in the arm-pits, &c." In the mid-nineteenth century (Miller, p. 88) it was thought to be caused by too-frequent pregnancies.

484 : 23.2 *And mine a word of the modern . . . a word en masse.*

modern As an adjective, to distinguish ancient from modern times or languages, the word dates to the sixteenth century. As a noun with the sense of "of the present, the new, up-to-date," OED cites 1897, 1905.

en masse Seems to have come into English to mean "in a mass or body" around 1815. "The public, *enmasse*,/ Hath affirmed that these Lays other efforts surpass." One of the milder effects, perhaps, of the French revolution.

487 : 23.8 *A word of reality . . . materialism first and last imbueing.*

materialism In the sense of a philosophy based on the idea that nothing exists except matter and its movements, OED dates this word to 1748. It came into its own in the nineteenth century, where it was often associated with irreligious thought. OED quotes a sermon of 1850: "The miserable materialism of the mass."

488 : 23.9 *Hurrah for positive science! Long live exact demonstration!*

positive science OED on "positive" in this sense that connects to the positivism of Auguste Comte: "Dealing only with matters of fact and experience; practical, realistic." Comte's *Philosophie positive* was published in 1830.

489 : 23.10 *Fetch stonecrop and mix it with cedar and branches of lilac;*

stonecrop “The common name of *Sedum acre* (N.O. *Crassulaceæ*), an herb with bright yellow flowers and small cylindrical fleshy sessile leaves, growing in masses on rocks, old walls, etc.; also applied (with or without defining word) to other species of *Sedum*, esp. those of similar growth, and of allied genera, as the N. American *Penthorum*.” (OED)

490 : 23.11 *This is the lexicographer or chemist . . . this made a grammar of
the old cartouches,*

cartouches “A cartouche is an oval ring used in hieroglyphic writing to set off the characters of a royal or divine name. The earliest examiners of the Rosetta stone had noticed that a group of characters enclosed in an oval appeared at a point in the hieroglyphic inscription corresponding to the place where the name of the pharaoh Ptolemy Epiphanes occurred in the Greek inscription.” It was this study of the royal cartouches, beginning in 1785, that led to the deciphering of the hieroglyphics by Jean Francois Champollion in 1832. It was one of the intellectual achievements of the age.

496 *And go on the square for my own sake and for other's sakes,*

go on the square We have not been able to find this exact usage. Here is Wikipedia on a similar, but contemporary phrase: “To **kid on the square** is to be joking, but at the same time really mean it. In this context, the *square* means ‘genuine’ or ‘true’ in the same sense as *fair and square*, *square deal* and *three square meals*, with an origin in carpentry, where a *square* is a tool used to ensure that objects are perpendicular to one another.”

499 : 24.1 *Walt Whitman, an American, one of the roughs, a kosmos,*

roughs Not a noun in either Webster or Bartlett. OED gives: “A man or lad belonging to the lower classes and inclined to commit acts of violence or disorder; a rowdy” and dates it from 1837.

kosmos In the later editions of *Leaves of Grass*, the line reads “Walt Whitman, a kosmos, of Manhattan the son.” OED: “The world or universe as an ordered

and harmonious system.” Reynolds: “The word, which had been popularized by the Prussian naturalist Alexander von Humboldt, epitomized the progressive scientist’s vision of the universe. . . . The first volume of his six-volume work, *Kosmos*, appeared in 1845, the second two years later.” (pp. 244–45)

506 : 24.9 *Through me the afflatus surging and surging . . . through me the current and index.*

afflatus OED: “The miraculous communication of supernatural knowledge; hence also, the imparting of an over-mastering impulse, poetic or otherwise; inspiration.” Joseph Priestly, *Natural and Revealed Religion*, 1782: “Orpheus said antient poets wrote by a divine afflatus.”

current Used for the flow of rivers since the fourteenth century. OED cites this from 1842: “From the manner in which the peculiar force called electricity is seemingly transmitted through certain bodies, the term *current* is commonly used to denote its apparent progress.”

index Rich in its range of meanings. Webster 1828: “1. That which points out; that which shows or manifests. 2. The hand that points to any thing, as the hour of the day, the road to a place. 3. A table of the contents of a book; a table of references in an alphabetical order. 4. In anatomy, the forefinger, or pointing finger. 5. In arithmetic and algebra, that which shows to what power any quantity is involved; the exponent. 6. The index of a globe, or the gnomon, is a little style fitted on the North Pole, which by turning with the globe, serves to point to certain divisions of the hour circle. 7. In music, a direct *obs*.”

514 : 24.16 *And of the threads that connect the stars—and of wombs, and of the fatherstuff,*

fatherstuff Apparently Whitman’s coinage.

525 : 24.27 *Seeing hearing and feeling are miracles, and each part and tag of me is a miracle.*

tag OED: “1. Originally, one of the narrow, often pointed, *laciniæ* or pendent pieces made by slashing the skirt of a garment; hence, any hanging ragged or torn piece; also, any end or rag of ribbon or the like. 2. A small pendent piece

or part hanging from, or attached more or less loosely to the main body of anything. With numerous specific applications, e.g. a. A matted lock of wool on a sheep; a tag-lock; a twisted or matted lock of hair. b. A shred of animal tissue. c. A shred of metal in a casting. d. A final curl, twirl, or flourish added to a letter, sometimes used as a mark of contraction. e. *fig.* An appendage; the tail-end (of any proceedings)."

531 : 24.34 *Shaded ledges and rests, firm masculine coulter, it shall be you,*

coulter OED: "The iron blade fixed in front of the share in a plough; it makes a vertical cut in the soil, which is then sliced horizontally by the share."

532 : 24.35 *Whatever goes to the tilth of me it shall be you,*

tilth Webster 1828: "The state of being tilled or prepared for a crop. We say, land is in good tilth, when it is manured, plowed, broken and mellowed for receiving the seed. We say also, ground is in bad tilth. When we say, land is in tilth, we mean in good condition for the seed; not in tilth, in a bad condition." Here is Wordsworth in the 1851 *Prelude*, which Whitman read: "I paused and cast / Upon his rich domains, vineyard and tilth, / Green meadow-ground and many-colored woods / A farewell look."

535 : 24.38 *My brain it shall be your occult convolutions,*

occult OED: "1. a. Not disclosed or divulged, secret; kept secret; communicated only to the initiated. Now *rare*." And "c. *Science* (now *hist.*). Of a property or matter: not manifest to direct observation; discoverable only by experiment; unexplained; latent."

536 : 24.39 *Root of washed sweet-flag, timorous pond-snipe, nest of guarded duplicate eggs, it shall be you,*

sweet-flag This is Whitman's beloved calamus, *Acorus calamus*, a tall perennial wetland plant with a strikingly phallic spadix. Here is Wikipedia on the cultural symbolism of the plant: "The calamus has long been a symbol of male love. The name is associated with a Greek myth: Kalamos, a son of the river-god Maeander, who loved Karpos, the son of Zephyrus and Chloris. When Karpos

drowned, Kalamos was transformed into a reed, whose rustling in the wind was interpreted as a sigh of lamentation. The plant was a favorite of Henry David Thoreau (who called it sweet flag), and also of Walt Whitman, who added a section called the ‘Calamus’ poems, possibly celebrating his love of men, to the third edition of *Leaves of Grass*. The name *Sweet Flag* refers to its sweet scent (it has been used as a strewing herb) and the wavy edges of the leaves which are supposed to resemble a fluttering flag.”

pond-snipe There are two species of North American snipe, *Gallinago gallinago*, the common snipe, and *Gallinago delicata*, Wilson’s snipe. They overlap in New York, where the common snipe is much more common. Both species, typically, lay a clutch of four eggs. However, the male leaves the nest with the first two fledglings to hatch, the female with the last two—so searchers often came across nests with two eggs, which suits Whitman’s metaphorical purpose.

549 : 24.52 *To walk up my stoop is unaccountable . . .*

stoop OED: “U.S. and Canada: “An uncovered platform before the entrance to a house” and cites an instance in Hawthorne in 1837. Also *Backwoods of Canada*, 1833: “The Canadians call these verandahs ‘stoups.’”

576 : 25.15 *My knowledge my live parts . . . it keeping tally with the meaning of things,*

tally See Harold Bloom, *Agon: Towards a Theory of Revisionism*, Oxford 1982 for an exhaustive discussion of Whitman’s use of this word, which has resonance in several domains, including counting in two columns, voting, and baseball.

582 : 25.21 *I carry the plenum of proof and every thing else in my face,*

plenum Webster 1828: “Fullness of matter in space.” OED: “1. a. Physics. A space completely filled with matter; spec. the whole of space regarded as being so filled. Contrasted with *VACUUM*. And: “Chiefly literary. In extended use: a condition of fullness or great quantity; a place filled with something.” George Eliot, *Scenes of Clerical Life*, 1858: “He must have some approximate conception of the mode in which the doctrines that have so much vitality in the plenum of his own brain will comport themselves in vacuo.”

589 *Talkative young ones to those that like them . . . the recitative of
fish-pedlars and fruit-pedlars . . . the loud laugh of workpeople
at their meals,*

recitative Came into English with the art it names in the mid-seventeenth century. OED: “A style of musical declamation, intermediate between singing and ordinary speech, commonly employed in the dialogue and narrative parts of operas and oratorios.” Its usage was metaphorical by the eighteenth. Smollett, *Humphrey Clinker*, 1771: “Because every language had its peculiar recitative.”

601 : 26.21 *The orbic flex of his mouth is pouring and filling me full.*

orbic OED: “rare. Having the form of an orb; circular, rounded, orbal.” And finds an instance in 1619, and this from 1892, *Saturday Review*: “He gazes up with rapturous, orbical eyes.”

flex Not in Webster. In the OED, it is a verb: “To bend. Now only in scientific use, esp. with reference to the bending of a joint or limb by the action of the flexor muscles.” So another instance of Whitman’s making nouns from verbs and verbs from nouns.

603 : 26.23 *The orchestra whirls me wider than Uranus flies,*

Uranus The discovery of the seventh planet was made by Sir William Herschel in 1781. For Whitman’s enthusiasm about astronomy, see Beaver.

608 : 26.27 *Steeped amid honeyed morphine . . . my windpipe squeezed in
the fakes of death,*

fakes For “fake” Webster 1828 gives only this: “One of the circles or windings of a cable or hawser, as it lies in a coil; a single turn.” OED also describes it as a nautical noun of obscure origin. But also gives this definition: “An act of faking; contrivance, ‘dodge’” with the earliest citation in 1828. The verb in OED means “To lay a rope in fakes or coils.”

612 : 27.3 *If nothing lay more developed the quahaug and its callous shell were enough.*

quahaug An American word, of course, from the Narraganset for the Atlantic round clam, *Venus mercenaria*.

614 : 27.5 *I have instant conductors all over me whether I pass or stop,*

conductors For the meaning of “something that conducts or permits the passage of heat or electricity,” OED gives a first instance in 1734. For Whitman on the nerve endings and electricity, see Beaver (pp. 87–88): “The sun itself, the force of life, was held by scientists to be an electric force; Richard Owen, the geologist, posited as his first axiom that the sun is the source of all stimulus, ‘and stimulation the cause of motion.’ His second axiom reads as follows: ‘The phenomena of heat, light, and electricity, (the latter in all its forms,) may result from modifications of motion, (vibratory or undulatory, disturbed equilibrium, etc.) and many facts point to a similarity or connection between volcanic, electrical, and nervous energy.’ The suspicion, voiced by Owen and others,” says Beaver, “that even nervous agency was connected somehow with electric force is expressed by Whitman as early as ‘Song of Myself.’”

658 : 30.12 *And a compend of compends is the meat of a man or woman,*

compend OED: “compend = COMPENDIUM. (transf. and fig). 1882 J. PAYNE, *1001 Nights* I. 182: He’s such a compend of beauties.”

660 : 30.14 *And they are to branch boundlessly out of that lesson until it becomes omnific,*

omnific Though this is the sort of word one associates with the Latin-loving English prose writers of the seventeenth century, the word does appear in 1828 Webster: “[L. *omnis*, all, and *facio*, to make.] All-creating.” With this instance, “*Thou deep, peace! said then th’ omnific word, your discord end,*” which suggests that its flavor was theological.

663 : 31.2 *And the pismire is equally perfect, and a grain of sand, and the egg
of the wren,*

pismire Webster 1828: “The insect called the ant or emmet.” “Obsolete except as dialect,” says the OED, which guesses that the word derives “from the urinous smell of anthills.” It finds an instance in an 1821 English poem: “Where the pismire hills abound.”

664 : 31.3 *And the tree-toad is a chef-d'œuvre for the highest,*

tree-toad Probably *Hyla arborea*. Bright leaf-green above and white underneath with adhesive toe pads.

chef-d'œuvre OED: “A masterpiece.” Earliest instance, 1772. Walter Scott uses it in his journal to describe paintings in 1831.

670 : 31.8 *I find I incorporate gneiss and coal and long-threaded moss and
fruits and grains and esculent roots,*

gneiss Webster 1828: “In mineralogy, a species of aggregated rock, composed of quartz, feldspar and mica, of a structure more or less distinctly slaty. The layers, whether straight or curved, are frequently thick, but often vary considerably in the same specimen. It passes on one side into granite, from which it differs in its slaty structure, and on the other into mica slate. It is rich in metallic ores.”

esculent OED: “Suitable for food, eatable.” Bacon uses it in 1626. By the nineteenth century it is an agriculturist’s and a botanist’s word: “The 4th of August was the period when the juicy esculent could be first enjoyed.”

671 : 31.9 *And am stucco'd with quadrupeds and birds all over,*

stucco'd It is a verb in Webster 1828: “To plaster; to overlay with fine plaster.” Comes into English from Italian early, 1598. Another instance of the language of the building trades.

675 : 31.13 *In vain the plutonic rocks send their old heat against my approach,*

plutonic OED: “*Geol.* Of, relating to, or designating rocks formed by the action of heat at great depths in the earth’s crust, esp. as distinguished from volcanic

rocks formed at or near the earth's surface; abyssal, intrusive. Also (now *hist.*): designating, relating to, or advocating the theory of Plutonism (contrasted with Neptunian)." This was, of course, the period of a revolution in geology. Plutonism was a theory, proposed around the turn of the nineteenth century, that volcanic activity was the source of rocks on the surface of the earth. Neptunism claimed that rocks had originated from a great flood and were basically sedimentary in origin. Charles Lyell's *Principles of Geology*, which Whitman knew, superseded these theories. Lyell, 1833: "The unstratified crystalline rocks have been very commonly called Plutonic, from the opinion that they were formed by igneous action at great depths."

676 : 31.14 *In vain the mastadon retreats beneath its own powdered bones,*

mastodon Webster 1828: "n. [Gr. mamilla, and tooth.] A genus of mammiferous animals resembling the elephant, now extinct, and known only by their fossil remains. It includes the N. American mammoth." The word was apparently first used in French in 1806. Tennyson: "Nature brings not back the mastodon."

682 : 31.20 *In vain the razorbilled auk sails far north to Labrador,*

razorbilled auk *Alca torda*. They breed in the north Atlantic from the Arctic Circle to Maine, and winter south to the Jersey coast, so Whitman may have seen them on Long Island.

698 : 32.15 *Infinite and omnigenous and the like of these among them;*

omnigenous OED: "Of all kinds." Clearly a savant's word. Coleridge, 1814, in a letter: "A miraculous combination of erudition, broad, deep, and omnigenous."

714 : 33.7 *I am afoot with my vision.*

afoot Webster 1828: "1. On foot; borne by the feet; opposed to riding. 2. In action; in a state of being planned for execution; as, a design is afoot, or on foot."

716 : 33.9 *Along the ruts of the turnpike . . . along the dry gulch and rivulet bed,*

turnpike From the mid-eighteenth century in England, meaning a toll road. It appears in the 1828 Webster.

gulch Does not appear in the 1828 Webster or in Bartlett. OED: “U.S. A narrow and deep ravine.” Earliest instance from Bayard Taylor in 1850: “The word *gulch* denotes a mountain ravine, steep, abrupt, and inaccessible.” So this is Whitman’s knowing use of a fairly new American landscape term.

717 : 33.10 *Hoing my onion-patch, and rows of carrots and parsnips . . .
crossing savannas . . . trailing in forests,*

savannas OED: “1. a. A treeless plain; *properly*, one of those found in various parts of tropical America.” Comes from Spanish into English early, but became a particularly North American term. George Washington, 1753: “. . . the nearest and levellest way was now impassible, by Reason of many large and mirey Savannahs.” Francis Parkman, 1865: “Next came the broad sunlight and the wide savanna.”

718 : 33.11 *Prospecting . . . gold-digging . . . girdling the trees of a new purchase,*

girdling OED: “To cut through the bark of a tree in a circle extending round the trunk, or to remove a certain breadth of bark in a similar circle, either for the purpose of killing the tree or for that of rendering it more fruitful; sometimes in *pass.* of injuries caused accidentally, e.g., by a tight wire or by the gnawing of rabbits. Also with *round*.” This was how new settlers in the American forests began to transform them into farmland.

725 : 33.18 *Over the sharp-peaked farmhouse with its scalloped scum and slender shoots from the gutters;*

scalloped scum Neither Webster 1828 nor OED gives any definition of “scum” that doesn’t amount to the froth that rises to the surface in boiling or fermentation, or some metaphorical derivation. “Scalloped,” of course, is “Having the border, edge, or outline cut into a series of segments of circles resembling a scallop-shell” (OED), but, unless there is some other meaning of “scum,” this must be a description of rainwater both foaming and drizzling from the farmhouse gutters and rainspout. Or “scum” is a variant of “scrim.”

726 : 33.19 *Over the western persimmon . . . over the longleaved corn and the delicate blue-flowered flax;*

western persimmon *Diospyros virginiana*, the American persimmon or possumwood tree, grows mostly in the southeastern U.S., and west to Texas and Oklahoma.

729 : 33.22 *Scaling mountains . . . pulling myself cautiously up . . . holding on by low scragged limbs,*

scrag Webster 1828: "Something thin or lean with roughness. A raw-boned person is called a scrag, but the word is vulgar."

731 : 33.24 *Where the quail is whistling betwixt the woods and the wheatlot,*

wheatlot Webster 1828, on "lot": "In the United States, a piece or division of land; perhaps originally assigned by drawing lots, but now any portion, piece or division. So we say, a man has a lot of land in Broadway, or in the meadow; he has a lot in the plain, or on the mountain; he has a home-lot, a house-lot, a wood-lot."

732 : 33.25 *Where the bat flies in the July eve . . . where the great goldbug drops through the dark;*

goldbug Probably a golden tortoise beetle, of the *Chrysomelidae* family in North America, unless it is a common term for firefly, or some other insect of the nineteenth-century New York summer dark. None of the dictionaries help. Here is an entomology website and a different geography: "Few who see the 'gold bug' forget it. It is one of the most striking insects in the Puget Sound area. The golden tortoise beetle is a stunning, vibrant metallic gold color. It has a magical quality, not only because of the brilliance of its color, but also because the brilliance isn't permanent. *Metritona* can alter color within a short time period, turning from brilliant gold to a dull, spotty reddish color."

733 *Where the flails keep time on the barn floor,*

flails OED: “1. An instrument for threshing corn by hand, consisting of a wooden staff or handle, at the end of which a stouter and shorter pole or club, called a swingle or swipple, is so hung as to swing freely. 1868 ROGERS, *Pol. Econ.* x. (1876) 24: Thirty years ago all corn, or nearly all corn, was threshed by the flail.” (“Corn” here means “grain.”)

736 : 33.28 *Where the cheese-cloth hangs in the kitchen, and andirons straddle
the hearth-slab, and cobwebs fall in festoons from the rafters;*

cheese-cloth The cloth through which the curds are pressed in cheese-making.

andirons Webster 1828: “An iron utensil used, in Great Britain, where coal is the common fuel, to support the ends of a spit; but in America, used to support the wood in fire places.”

hearth-slab for “hearthstone”: “A stone or stones forming a hearth; also fig. in 1847 EMERSON *Poems*, p. 58. I go to seek my own hearth-stone.” (DARE)

737 : 33.29 *Where triphammers crash . . . where the press is whirling its
cylinders;*

triphammers OED: “A massive machine-hammer operated by a tripping device, as a wheel with projecting teeth, a cam, or the like, by which it is raised and then allowed to drop; a tilt-hammer. Also fig. 1854 EMERSON, *Lett. & Soc. Aims, Eloquence* Wks. III. 190: What character, what infinite variety, belong to the voice! sometimes it is a flute, sometimes a trip-hammer.” Whitman spent a lot of time in print shops.

740 : 33.32 *Where the life-car is drawn on the slipnoose . . . where the heat
hatches pale-green eggs in the dented sand,*

life-car Greenspan: “A watertight boat or chamber used in rescues to haul people through surf too unsettled for open boats.” No source given, but clearly related to what is now called a lifeboat.

slipnoose OED: “a noose which tightens and slackens by means of a slip-knot.”

743 *Where the ground-shark's fin cuts like a black chip out of the water,*

ground-shark The Greenland shark, *Somniosus microcephalus*, also known as the sleeper, grey, or ground shark, native to the waters of the North Atlantic around Greenland and Iceland.

744 : 33.36 *Where the half-burned brig is riding on unknown currents,*

brig OED: "A vessel with two masts square-rigged like a ship's fore- and main-masts, but carrying also on her main-mast a lower fore-and-aft sail with a gaff and boom."

749 : 33.41 *Upon a door-step . . . upon the horse-block of hard wood outside,*

horse-block OED: "A small platform, usually of stone, ascended by 3 or 4 steps, for convenience in mounting a horse; also a portable structure of wood, or the like, for the same purpose."

750 : 33.42 *Upon the race-course, or enjoying pic-nics or jigs or a good game
 of base-ball,*

pic-nics Came into existence in the middle of the eighteenth century to denominate elegant parties at which each guest brought a dish, an aristocratic pot-luck. Came by the mid-nineteenth to mean an outdoor party, but it was still a piquant phrase.

jigs OED: "A lively, rapid, springy kind of dance."

base-ball Traubel's *Conversations with Whitman*: "—it's our game: that's the chief fact in connection with it: America's game: has the snap, go fling, of the American atmosphere—belongs as much to our institutions, fits into them as significantly, as our constitutions, laws: is just as important in the sum total of our historic life."

751 : 33.43 *At he-festivals with blackguard jibes and ironical license and bull-
 dances and drinking and laughter,*

he-festivals Whitman's invention?

bull-dances OED: "1867 SMYTH, *Sailor's Word-bk.*: *Bull-dance*, at sea it is performed by men only, when without women. It is sometimes called a stag-dance."

752 *At the cider-mill, tasting the sweet of the brown squish . . .*

squish Neither “squish” nor “squish” in Webster. OED: “1. *intr.* To collapse into a soft, pulpy mass. 1884 MARK TWAIN, *Huck. Finn*: ‘He’d a squished down like a bluff bank that the river has cut under.’” In later editions he revised “squish” to “mash.”

754 : 33.46 *At musters and beach-parties and friendly bees and huskings and house-raisings;*

muster OED: “The number of people or things assembled on a particular occasion; an assembly, a collection. 1863 W. C. BALDWIN, *Afr. Hunting* viii. 325: We set off, a strong muster, two days ago, to hunt part of the forest in which the elephants stand.” In Webster 1828 the term is only military.

bees OED: “In allusion to the social character of the insect (originally in U.S.): A meeting of neighbours to unite their labours for the benefit of one of their number; e.g. as is done still in some parts, when the farmers unite to get in each other’s harvests in succession; usually preceded by a word defining the purpose of the meeting, as *apple-bee*, *husking-bee*, *quilting-bee*, *raising-bee* etc.”

huskings OED: “The action of removing a husk. *spec.* in U.S., the removal of the husk from Indian corn; hence, a party or gathering of the neighbours and friends of a farmer to assist him in husking his corn, usually enlivened with festivities; called also *husking-bee*.”

house-raisings OED: “(U.S.), ‘a gathering of the inhabitants in a thinly settled district to assist a neighbor in raising the frame of his house’ (*Cent. Dict.*).”

756 : 33.48 *Where the hay-rick stands in the barnyard, and the dry-stalks are scattered, and the brood cow waits in the hovel,*

hay-ricks OED: “A haystack. 1837 DICKENS, *Pickw.* vii: ‘The rich, sweet smell of the hayricks.’”

brood cow “Brood” is “offspring,” so OED: “With the sense of *breeding*, hence *brood hen*, *brood mare*, and the like.”

hovel “A shed” in 1828 Webster. OED: “1. An open shed; an outhouse used as a shelter for cattle, a receptacle for grain or tools.” 1655: “Cottages for themselves and Hovels for the Cattel.”

762 : 33.54 *Where the laughing-gull scoots by the slappy shore and laughs her
near-human laugh;*

laughing-gull The common name for the Atlantic gull, *Larus atricilla*.
slappy Not in the dictionaries.

764 : 33.56 *Where the band-necked partridges roost in a ring on the ground
with their heads out;*

band-necked partridges *Perdix perdix*, the gray partridge, is the only North American species, and it doesn't have a notably banded neck. Perhaps he was thinking of pheasants. The behavior he describes is quite specific. Like pheasants, partridges are an introduced species and this seems to describe their behavior. Pheasants tend to roost in trees.

767 : 33.59 *Where the yellow-crowned heron comes to the edge of the marsh at
night and feeds upon small crabs;*

yellow-crowned night heron *Nycticorax violaceus*, the smaller of the two North American night herons. A resident of Long Island marshes, though it is more common further south.

769 : 33.61 *Where the katydid works her chromatic reed on the walnut-tree
over the well;*

katydid OED: "A large longhorn grasshopper of the family Tettigoniidae, of arboreal habits, which produces by stridulation a noise to which its name is due; the common or broad-winged species (*Cyrtophyllum concavum*) abounds in the central and eastern states of America."

chromatic Applied to color as well as sound. OED: "Full of color, brightly or highly colored." And this: "In *Rhetoric*, florid, elaborate, artificial." In music, "containing notes which do not belong to the diatonic scale."

770 : 33.62 *Through patches of citrons and cucumbers with silver-wired leaves,*

citrons Webster 1828: "A large species of lemon."

silver-wired His own look at the cucumber leaf.

771 : 33.63 *Through the salt-lick or orange glade . . . or under conical firs;*

salt-lick OED: “lick: 2. *N. Amer.* a. A spot to which animals resort to lick the salt or salt earth found there. Also *buffalo-lick*, *salt-lick*.”

778 : 33.70 *Looking in at the shop-windows in Broadway the whole forenoon . . . pressing the flesh of my nose to the thick plate-glass,*

plate-glass The word and the product appeared in the 1720s and was widely manufactured in the U.S. by the 1850s, though still a fashionable innovation in store windows.

781 : 33.73 *Coming home with the bearded and dark-cheeked bush-boy . . . riding behind him at the drape of the day;*

bush-boy No idea. OED gives “a native Australian or bushman,” but that seems unlikely. “Bush” was associated with several nineteenth-century processes. It referred to “the metal lining of the axle hole of a wheel” and in printing to “an alloy of copper and tin.”

785 : 33.77 *Voyaging to every port to dicker and adventure;*

dicker OED: “U.S., To trade by barter or exchange; to truck; to bargain in a petty way, to haggle.” James Fenimore Cooper, 1848: “The white men who penetrated to the semi-wilds were always ready to dicker and to swap.” Of equal interest is **adventure** as a verb: “I. To commit to chance. 1. *trans.* To take the chance of; to commit to fortune; to undertake a thing of doubtful issue; to try, to chance, to venture upon.”

791 : 33.83 *Speeding amid the seven satellites and the broad ring and the diameter of eighty thousand miles,*

seven satellites, etc. Saturn, which has by current measure a diameter of 74,900 miles.

795 *Backing and filling, appearing and disappearing,*

backing and filling Originally a nautical term. OED: “to back a sail, a yard: to lay it aback; ‘to brace the yard so that the wind may blow directly on the front of the sail, and thus retard the ship’s course.’”

799 : 33.87 *I fly the flight of the fluid and swallowing soul,*

swallowing !!!

805 : 33.97 *I go hunting polar furs and the seal . . . leaping chasms with a
pike-pointed staff . . . clinging to topples of brittle and blue.*

topples There is in the OED a 1907 instance of “topple” as a noun, and it is colloquial: “This ain’t the topple over of the Coll building yet.”

brittle and blue Two adjectives for nouns to describe sea ice.

806 : 33.98 *I ascend to the foretruck . . . I take my place late at night in the
crow’s nest . . .*

foretruck OED: “d. *Naut.* Chiefly in words denoting some ‘part of a ship’s frame and machinery which lies near the stem, or in that direction, in opposition to *aft* or *after*’ (Adm. Smyth); also of parts connected with the fore-mast.”

813 : 33.108 *I am a free companion . . . I bivouac by invading watchfires.*

bivouac Originally a military usage come into English from the Thirty Years’ War. OED: “to remain, esp. during the night, in the open air without tents”; it also came to mean simply “*transf.* To rest or pass the night in the open air. 1814 SCOTT, *Wav.* II. i., 8: These distinguished personages bivouacked among the flowery heath, wrapped up in their plaids.”

watchfires OED: “a fire maintained during the night as a signal, or for the use of a sentinel, party or person on watch.”

836 : 33.131 *I clutch the rails of the fence . . . my gore dribs thinned with the
ooze of my skin,*

gore An honorable old word, etymologically connected to animal dung; it came by the seventeenth century to mean “Blood in the thickened state that

follows effusion. In poetical language often: Blood shed in carnage.” (OED)

drib OED says it is obsolete. “1. *intr.* To fall in drops; *fig.*, to go on little by little.” Also “to dribble” and “to fall in driblets.” In use in the sixteenth century. Whitman may have reinvented it, or it survived to North America in spoken English.

854 *Again the reveille of drummers . . . again the attacking cannon and mortars and howitzers,*

howitzers OED: “A short piece of ordnance, usually of light weight, specially designed for the horizontal firing of shells with small charges, and adapted for use in a mountainous country. 1695 *Lond. Gaz.* No. 3106/3: 40 Mortars and Hauwitzers. 1812 *Examiner* 14 Sept. 581/1: We drove the enemy from . . . the town by howitzers.” In the taxonomies of artillery pieces used by European (and European-style) armies in the eighteenth, nineteenth centuries, according to Wikipedia, the howitzer stood between the gun or cannon (which was characterized by a longer barrel, larger propelling charges, smaller shells, higher velocities and flatter trajectories) and the mortar (which has the ability to fire projectiles at even higher angles of ascent and descent). So Whitman, the journalist, got the array of armaments right.

858 : 33.156 *The ambulanza slowly passing and trailing its red drip,*

ambulanza Italian for “ambulance,” of course. According to the OED, the word came into use during the Crimean War. Hence, the continental turn Whitman gives it.

872 : 34.10 *They were the glory of the race of rangers,*

rangers OED identifies it as an American term: “A body of mounted troops, or other armed men, ranging over a tract of land.” Goes back at least to 1742 in Georgia: “For the safety of the colony it is necessary to have rangers who can ride the woods.”

892 : 35.4 *Our foe was no skulk in his ship, I tell you,*

skulk OED: “One who skulks or hides himself; a shirker.” Melville, *Omoo*, 1847: “‘Where’s that skulk, Chips?’ shouted Jermin down the forecastle scuttle.”

894 : 35.6 *Along the lowered eve he came, horribly raking us.*

lowered eve In the evening dark? “lowered” in the sense of “descended”?

raking OED: “To sweep with shot” since 1630. Nothing new, but the appropriate nautical term.

895 : 35.7 *We closed with him . . . the yards entangled . . . the cannon touched,*

yards OED: “Naut. A wooden spar, comparatively long and slender, slung . . . from and in front of the mast and serving to support a squaresail.”

898 : 35.10 *On our lower-gun-deck two large pieces had burst at the first fire, killing all around and blowing up overhead.*

pieces OED: “Mil & Naut. Cannon.”

900 : 35.13 *The master-at-arms loosing the prisoners confined in the after-hold to give them a chance for themselves.*

master-at-arms OED: “Naut. A warrant officer . . . appointed to instruct the officers and the crew of a ship of war in the use of small arms.”

after-hold OED “hold”: “The interior cavity of a ship where cargo is stored.” Whitman puts prisoners in a specific compartment of the ship.

901 : 35.14 *The transit to and from the magazine was now stopped by the sentinels,*

magazine OED: “A place in which gunpowder and other explosives are kept.”

903 : 35.17 *Our frigate was afire . . . the other asked if we demanded quarters? if our colors were struck and the fighting done?*

quarter OED: “Exemption from being immediately put to death, granted to a vanquished opponent by a victor in battle.”

colors OED: “A flag, ensign, or standard of a regiment or ship.” To *strike* a sail is to lower it, in this case, in surrender.

908 : 35.23 *Two well-served with grape and canister silenced his musketry
and cleared his decks.*

grape Short for “grapeshot,” the small cast iron balls discharged from cannons.

canister Short for “canister-shot.” OED: “consisting of a number of small iron balls . . . packed in a cylindrical tin case fitting the bore of the gun from which it is to be fired. 1809 *Naval Chron.* XXI. 25: Repeated broadsides of grape and cannister shot.”

931 : 36.15 *The wheeze, the cluck, the swash of falling blood . . .*

swash OED, 1849: “He heard the swash of the water against the sides of the ship.” 1863, Nathaniel Hawthorne, *Our Old House*: “The swash and swell of the passing steamers.”

937 *What sobers the Brooklyn boy as he looks down the shores of the
Wallabout and remembers the prison ships,*

Wallabout Whitman lived as a boy at 12 Ryerson Street near Wallabout Bay and the Brooklyn Naval Yard. Wikipedia: “The area was the site where the infamous British prison ships moored during Revolutionary War from about 1776–1783. Over 10,000 soldiers and sailors died due to deliberate neglect on these rotting hulks, more American deaths than from every battle of the war combined. Though their corpses were buried on the eroding shore in shallow graves, or often simply thrown overboard, local women collected remains when they became exposed or washed onshore and many more were discovered with the development of the area and expansion of the pier.”

938 *What burnt the gums of the redcoat at Saratoga when he surrendered his
brigades,*

burnt the gums ???

944 : 37.6 *For me the keepers of convicts shoulder their carbines and keep watch,*

carbines OED: “A kind of fire-arm, shorter than the musket, used by the cavalry and other troops; ‘a kind of medium between the pistol and the musket’ (J.). 1858 Greener, *Gunnery* 399: Double rifled carbines can be constructed of so light a weight that their exclusive use for cavalry is not far distant.” So many weapons named in this poem!

951 : 37.13 *Askers embody themselves in me, and I am embodied in them,*

askers OED, R. Burton, *Gold Coast*, 1881: “They beg with a good grace, and not with an insult and a curse, as the European ‘asker,’ when refused.”

961 : 38.9 *I remember . . . I resume the overstaid fraction,*

overstaid fraction One of the most mysterious phrases in the poem. It has provoked a lot of commentary and interpretation, coming as it does at a climactic moment in the poem that is filled with Christian death and resurrection imagery.

Here is Webster 1828 on “fraction”: “1. The act of breaking or state of being broken, especially by violence.” This is followed by a rather laborious definition of fractions in arithmetic: “2. In arithmetic and algebra, a broken part of an integral or integer; any division of a whole number or unit, as $\frac{2}{5}$, two fifths, $\frac{1}{4}$, one fourth, which are called vulgar fractions. In these, the figure above the line is called the numerator, and the figure below the line the denominator. In decimal fractions, the denominator is a unit, or 1, with as many cyphers annexed, as the numerator has places. They are commonly expressed by writing the numerator only, with a point before it by which it is separated from the whole number; thus .5, which denotes five tenths, $\frac{5}{10}$, or half the whole number; .25, that is $\frac{25}{100}$, or a fourth part of the whole number.”

OED adds the senses of “a broken place, breach, fissure, rupture. 1798: ‘Wounds, fractions, and dislocations,’” and “an interruption of good feeling or harmony; dissension, discord,” but the examples are from the seventeenth century, and, finally, “in the Eucharist: the act of breaking or dividing the bread.

1877, CHAMBERS, *Divine Worship*: The Fraction is the most solemn, ancient, and significant action of the whole formulary of consecration.” For “stayed,” Webster 1828 has: “Staid; fixed; settled; sober. It is now written staid. For “stay,” “1. To remain; to continue in a place; to abide for any indefinite time” and “3. To wait; to attend; to forbear to act.” The simplest paraphrase in this connotative wealth would be “the part of the whole that stayed over,” i.e., the living.

962 : 38.10 *The grave of rock multiplies what has been confided to it . . .*

confide OED: “To entrust (an object of care, a task) to a person with reliance on his fidelity and competence.” Also “to impart as a secret.”

966 : 38.13 *Inland and by the seacoast and boundary lines . . . and we pass the boundary lines.*

boundary lines Not clear what he had in mind. The late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries saw a number of boundary line treaties, from the establishment of the Mason-Dixon lines through the establishment of the Canadian and Mexican boundaries, and the boundary lines created by treaties with the Indian tribes.

967 : 38.14 *Our swift ordinances are on their way over the whole earth,*

ordinances OED: “The act of ordering or regulating, regulation, direction management. *Archaic*. 1885, JOHN RUSKIN: Unless music exalt and purify, it is not under St. Cecilia’s ordinance.” And: “An authoritative instruction as to how to proceed or act; an established set of principles; a system of government; authority; discipline. *Obs*. 1847, TENNYSON: Then the voice of Ida sounded, issuing ordinance.” Also “Warlike provision, equipment and stores.” Also “That which is ordained or decreed by a Deity or fate.”

968 : 38.15 *The blossoms we wear in our hats are the growth of two thousand years.*

the blossoms we wear in our hats Possibly the blossoms are cockades or worn jauntily in the place of cockades, “Knots of ribbon or rosettes, worn in the hat as a badge of rank,” if “ordinance” in the previous line carries a military sense.

969 : 38.16 *Eleves I salute you,*

Eleves French for “students.”

981 : 39.9 *Slowstepping feet and the common features, and the common
modes and emanations,*

slowstepping OED gives slow-going, slow-moving, and slowpacing, but not “slowstepping.”

emanations There are three relevant fields of meaning. OED: “The process of flowing forth, issuing, or proceeding from anything as a source; often applied to the origination of created beings from God”; also “Something emitted or radiated from a material object; especially applied to impalpable things, as light, an electric or magnetic effluvium, an odor, etc.”; and “Applied to immaterial things, moral and spiritual powers, virtues, qualities.”

984 : 40.1 *Flaunt of the sunshine I need not your bask . . . lie over,*

flaunt Now *rare*, says the OED, as a noun meaning “The action or habit of flaunting, or making display,” but finds an example in 1830 in a poem by Holmes: “Who needs the silken tassel’s flaunt / Beside the golden corn?”

bask Also *rare*, meaning “A ‘bath’ or suffusion of genial warmth,” also with a nineteenth-century example. 1876: “A perfect bask of sunshine lying over it.”

lie over OED: “To be held or deferred to a future occasion. 1856: I have a strange story to tell, but that must lie over, or I shall miss my omnibus.”

985 : 40.2 *You light surfaces only . . . I force the surfaces and the depths also.*

force The nearest meaning for “force” as a transitive verb is horticultural, “To hasten by artificial means the maturity of” (OED). Neither “force a passage” or “compel an outcome” quite fits this idiom.

987 : 40.4 *Say old topknot! what do you want?*

topknot OED: “A tuft of hair on the top or crown of the head of a person or animal; a knob of hair worn on the crown of the head in some styles of hair-dressing; also, a plume or crest of feathers or filaments on the head of a bird”

and “The head. *slang*. 1869 E. WAUGH, *Hermit Cobbler*: I doubt it’s unsattle’t his top-knot a bit.” Doesn’t show up in the dictionaries of nineteenth-century slang we were able to consult.

993 : 40.10 *You there, impotent, loose in the knees, open your scarfed chops
till I blow grit within you,*

loose in the knees OED on “loose”: “Of the joints: slack, relaxed from weakness. R. L. STEVENSON, 1893: My eyes besides were still troubled and my knees loose under me.”

scarfed There seems to be no sense that doesn’t mean “wrapped in a scarf,” except in either a carpenter’s or shipbuilder’s sense (OED: “1823: In each piece of timber to be joined, the parts of the joints that come in contact are called scarves”) or a medical one (“to scarf” is “to bind up wounds with, or as with, a scarf”). This could be either one, or punningly both.

chops OED: “Jaw, sides of the face. 1877: I’ll slap thy chops fo’ tha.”

1002 : 40.21 *This day I am jetting the stuff of far more arrogant republics.*

jetting OED: Walter Scott, 1814: “Conflicting tides that foam and fret / And high their mingled billows jet.”

1009 : 40.28 *I dilate you with tremendous breath . . . I buoy you up;*

dilate OED: “1. To expand, amplify, enlarge.” 1851: “Heat dilates matter with an irresistible force.” 1871: “As we have seen, it [Christianity] dilates our whole being.”

1019 *It is middling well as far as it goes . . . but is that all?*

middling Webster 1828: “Of middle rank, state, size or quality; about equally distant from the extremes; moderate. Thus we speak of people of the middling class or sort, neither high nor low; of a man of middling capacity or understanding; a man of middling size; fruit of a middling quality.” In the sense of “moderately good, mediocre, second-rate,” the OED says it is “*colloq.* Or *vulgar.*” Matthew Arnold, 1882: “The abundant consumption of middling literature.”

1020 : 41.6 *Magnifying and applying come I,*

magnify OED: “1. To speak or act for the glory and honor of a person or thing; to glorify, extol.” Macaulay, *History of England*, 1849: “Everywhere men magnified his valour, genius, and patriotism.” “2. To make greater in size, status, importance.” “4. To increase the apparent size of an object (by artificial means).” 1853: “The effects of fog on estimations of dimension are well-known: men are magnified to giants.”

apply Multiple meanings could be relevant. OED: “To put a thing into contact with another; to put close *to*; to place (a flame, heat, a measuring instrument, etc.) in immediate proximity *to*; to minister to, to bring to bear on, 1817: “They applied coercion . . .”; to set oneself closely to a task; to devote one’s energy *to*.”

1021 : 41.7 *Outbidding at the start the old cautious hucksters,*

hucksters Webster 1828: “1. A retailer of small articles, of provisions, nuts, &c. 2. A mean trickish fellow.” OED: from the sixteenth century, “a broker, a middleman; 2. a. *trans.* and *fig.* A person ready to make his profit of anything in a mean or petty way; one who basely barter his services, etc., for gain; a mercenary; an overreacher of others. 1868: I am no huckster to sell my daughter to the highest bidder.”

1022 *The most they offer for mankind and eternity less than a spirt of my own seminal wet,*

spirt Also “spurt.” OED: “A jet or slender spout of water, or other liquid. 1840 BROWNING, *Sordello*: One bright spirt of water bubbles in.”

1024 : 41.9 *Lithographing Kronos and Zeus his son, and Hercules his grandson,*

lithographing Lithography as a method of printing using a plate or stone with a smooth surface was invented in Germany in 1796 and was widely used in the U.S. in the nineteenth century. According to the OED, “lithograph” was first used as a verb in 1825.

1025 : 41.10 *Buying drafts of Osiris and Isis and Belus and Brahma and
Adonai,*

buying drafts Not sure which meaning Whitman has in mind. Webster 1828: “An order from one man to another directing the payment of money; a bill of exchange, e.g., ‘I thought it most prudent to defer the drafts, till advice was received of the progress of the loan.’” And also “A drawing of lines for a plan; a figure described on paper; delineation; sketch; plan delineated. [See Draught.],” which would be in keeping with the metaphors in the lines before and after.

1026 : 41.11 *In my portfolio placing Manito loose, and Allah on a leaf, and the
crucifix engraved,*

loose . . . on a leaf . . . engraved All terms of art, it would seem, for the representations an artist might bring to a printer.

1030 : 41.15 *Admitting they bore mites as for unfledged birds who have now to
rise and fly and sing for themselves,*

mite OED: “In early use, applied to any minute insect or arachnid,” i.e., the small insects fed to a baby bird. But also a coin of very small value, the small amount (Mark, 12:42) one is able to give.

1031 : 41.16 *Accepting the rough deific sketches to fill out better in myself. . . .*

deific OED: “making divine; or divine, godlike.” Earliest use in 1490. A theologian’s term in the nineteenth century. 1858: “What the hard style of mystical theology called deific transformation.” Though Whitman’s use of it seems jaunty.

1033 : 41.18 *Putting higher claims for him there with his rolled-up sleeves,*

putting . . . claims Couldn’t find help with this usage (as opposed to making claims or laying claims), though it feels idiomatic.

1034 : 41.19 *Not objecting to special revelations*

special revelations In Christianity, God’s initial revelation of Himself and His intent to men occurred in the Old and New Testaments. All other revelations,

especially individual and private ones, were “special revelations,” and usually viewed with suspicion by orthodox theologians. Joseph Smith’s visit from the Angel Moroni in 1827 would be a nineteenth-century instance.

1035 : 41.20 *Those ahold of fire-engines and hook-and-ladder ropes*

ahold Interestingly, both Webster 1828 and OED describe “ahold” as an obsolete nautical term. AHD describes it as a noun meaning “hold or grip” and gives a current instance: “I got ahold of a bottle.” Much evidence for Whitman’s newspaperman’s enthusiasm for firemen.

1037 : 41.22 *Their brawny limbs passing safe over charred laths . . .*

lath An old word. OED: “A thin strip of wood used as a groundwork on which to fasten the slates or tiles of a roof or the plaster of a wall.” From 1490 and still a term of the building trades in Whitman’s time.

1040 : 41.25 *The snag-toothed hostler with red hair redeeming sins past and
to come,*

snag-toothed Originally a “snag” was a short stump standing out from the trunk of a tree. OED on “snaggled”: “U.S. Of teeth, uneven, irregular projecting.” Joel Chandler Harris, *Uncle Remus*, 1884: “I’m snaggle-toofed an’ double-j’inted.”

hostler The person who keeps horses at an inn; the joke about hostlers and red hair and sins is lost to us now.

1041 : 41.26 *Selling all he possesses and traveling on foot to fee lawyers for his
brother*

to fee Seems to occur with some regularity in the nineteenth century as a transitive verb for paying a fee to. OED: “1884: ‘You must fee the waiter when you give the order.’” This incident has the feel of a story that Whitman had heard or knew about.

1045 : 41.30 *The supernatural of no account . . . myself waiting my time to be
one of the supremes,*

supremes As a noun, in the OED it refers to the Christian God. 1818, Shelley: “Heaven’s dread Supreme.” No instances of a plural usage (and no Diana Ross jokes).

1047 *Guessing when I am it will not tickle me much to receive puffs out of
pulpit or print;*

puffs For this kind of “puff,” Webster 1828 gives, “A tumid or exaggerated statement or commendation.” The earliest OED reference to journalistic puffs comes from 1794 (fairly early in the history of the medium): “The amount is consumed in paying for newspaper puffs.” “Tickle,” meaning to amuse or please, was in use in Chaucer’s time.

1048 : 41.32 *By my life-lumps! becoming already a creator!*

life-lumps Another instance of Whitman’s enthusiasm for phrenology, the science of reading a person’s character from the bumps on the head. See DR, 247–49.

1049 : 41.33 *Putting myself here and now to the ambushed womb of the
shadows!*

ambushed womb of the shadows !!!

1054 *Now the performer launches his nerve . . . he has passed his prelude on
the reeds within.*

nerve In the sense of “strength or vigor,” the usage goes back to the seventeenth century, according to the OED. For the meaning of “courage, boldness, assurance,” the earliest use is nineteenth century and American. Washington Irving, 1809: “He spoke forth like a man of nerve and vigor.” Webster in 1828 gives three shadings: “3. Strength; firmness of body; as a man of nerve. 4. Fortitude; firmness of mind; courage. 5. Strength; force; authority; as the nerves of discipline.”

the reeds within A “reed” can be a shepherd’s pipe, a part of a musical instrument, the pipe of an organ, or a reed instrument. In the plural, usually with reference to an organ or to the reed section of an orchestra. “Reeds within” seems to be Whitman’s invention.

1055 : 42.6 *Easily written loosefingered chords! I feel the thrum of their climax and close.*

loose-fingered chords The OED gives “to finger” as a verb: “To play upon (an instrument) with the fingers,” though the archaic sense of “to finger out” can be heard punning on the title of Whitman’s book: “To read carefully or with effort, passing the finger along the lines.”

thrum The word pertains to both music and textile. Webster 1828: “To play coarsely on an instrument with the fingers,” as well as: “To weave; to know; to twist; to fringe.”

1056 *My head evolves on my neck,*

evolves Though the Latin *volvo* means “to roll,” Webster 1828 gives “To unfold; to open and expand” and so does the OED: “To unfold, unroll (something that is wrapped up).” Whitman had second thoughts and revised the phrase by the 1882 edition: “My head slues round on my neck.” Perhaps Darwin had interceded.

1061 : 42.13 *Ever the old inexplicable query . . . ever that thorned thumb—
that breath of itches and thirsts,*

thorned thumb This expression may have an interesting forebear in “to *flash* one’s thumb,” which meant “to take trouble”—*flash* meaning “to afflict, annoy, trouble, vex” (OED). Hence “Thorny: Sharp; pricking; vexatious; as thorny points” (Webster’s 1828). Probably a figure then for a nagging minor irritation.

that breath of itches and thirsts !!!? A metaphor presumably for the “old inexplicable query.”

1064 : 42.16 *Ever the bandage under the chin . . . ever the tressels of death.*

tressels, or trestles Coffins were placed on trestles at funerals and wakes, and Whitman had the exact word for them. “A support for something, consisting

of a short horizontal beam or bar with diverging legs, usually two at each end” (OED). “Trestles of death” calls up as well an obsolete use of the word, also from OED: “A stand or frame for candles or tapers burning in religious worship.”

1065 : 42.17 *Here and there with dimes on the eyes walking,*

dimes on the eyes There are references to the custom of placing coins on the eyes of the dead as early as the story of Charon in Greek mythology.

1074 *They who piddle and patter here in collars and tailed coats . . .*

piddle Webster 1828: “To deal in trifles; to spend time in trifling objects; to attend to trivial concerns or the small parts rather than to the main.” In the OED, it is more or less synonymous with *loiter*: “To work or act in an ineffectual or wasteful way; to mess about or around.” Whitman revised the line by 1882: *The little plentiful manikins skipping around in collars and tail’d coats*. **Manakin** first appears in the sixteenth century as a term of contempt: ‘little man.’ In 1831, it is a model of the body for use in anatomy demonstration. **Mannequin** came into English from French, according to Merriam-Webster, to mean “a seamstress’s dummy” and became a dummy for the display of clothes in the nineteenth century with the invention of the department store. The oldest department store in New York, The Marble Palace on East Broadway, opened in 1846.

1075 *I acknowledge the duplicates of myself under all the scrape-lipped and pipe-legged concealments.*

scrape-lipped and pipe-legged There is a considerable literature on the semiotics of mustaches and men’s fashion in the nineteenth century. Neither of these compounds shows up in Webster or OED. Whitman revised this line: *the weakest and shallowest is deathless with me*.

1079 : 42.30 *I know perfectly well my own egotism,*

egotism OED finds the earliest instance of this word in the essays of Joseph Addison in 1714. By the nineteenth century Coleridge could speak of “the alcohol of egotism” and Emerson remark of Napoleon in 1847 that “his absorbing egotism was deadly to all other men.”

1085 *The panorama of the sea . . . but the sea itself?*

panorama The term was invented in 1789 by an R. Barker to refer to “A picture of a landscape arranged on a cylindrical surface with the spectator at the center.” One historian has described the panorama as “the art form *par excellence* of the early nineteenth century. “See Stephan Oettermann, *The Panorama: History of a Mass Medium*. New York: Zone Books, 1997. Trans. by Deborah Lucas Schneider. Whitman cut this line, perhaps because panoramas had come to seem quaint by 1882.

1086 : 42.36 *The well-taken photographs . . . but your wife or friend close
and solid in your arms?*

photograph First use in the OED dates from 1831.

1097 : 43.6 *Making a fetish of the first rock or stump . . . powowing with
sticks in the circle of obis,*

fetish Probably intended in the early-anthropological sense of “An inanimate object worshipped by primitive peoples on account of its supposed inherent magical powers, or as being animated by a spirit” (OED). The signal text that introduced this usage was Charles de Brosses’ *Le Culte des Dieux Fétiches* (1760).

powow or **pow-wow** Came into English in the seventeenth century, according to OED. An Algonquian (North American Indian) word, traced to pre-Pennsylvania: “To practice a religious or magical ritual; to gather for a council or conference.” Here is Bartlett’s *Americanisms* in 1852: “POW-WOW. (Indian.) This is the name given by the early chroniclers to the feasts, dances, and other public doings of the red men, preliminary to a grand hunt, a council, a war expedition, or the like. It has been adopted, in political talk, to signify any uproarious meeting for a political purpose, at which there is more noise than deliberation, more clamor than counsel. [*J. Inman.*] ‘A murder was recently committed upon a Sioux by two Chippewa. The body of the murdered Indian was taken to the fort, where a most terrific *pow-wow* was held over it by the friends of the deceased, 300 in number.’ —*Western Newspaper.*”

obi A Nigerian word whose two primary meanings are well-served by Whitman's usage: it is both "a hut or house, especially one for formal or ceremonial use" and "a king, a chief" (OED).

1098 : 43.7 *Helping the lama or brahmin as he trims the lamps of the idols,*

lama Webster 1828: "The sovereign pontiff, or rather the god of the Asiatic Tartars." "A Buddhist monk or priest, applicable in both Tibetan and Mongolian Buddhism." OED, which records the term in English in 1652.

brahmin Webster 1828: "A priest among the Hindoos and other nations of India. There are several orders of Bramins, many of whom are very corrupt in their morals; others live sequestered from the world devoted to superstition and indolence. They are the only persons who understand the Sanscrit, or ancient language of the country, in which their sacred books are written; and to them are European nations indebted for their knowledge of the language."

1099 : 43.8 *Dancing yet through the streets in a phallic procession . . . rapt
and austere in the woods, a gymnosophist,*

phallic Interestingly, Webster's 1828 has no entry for "phallic." The OED indicates its usage in 1721, "as a noun in plural denoting the festival of Dionysus." Whitman's usage echoes very closely George Grote's *A History of Greece*, published (serially) 1846–1856: "The exuberant revelry of the phallic festival and procession."

gymnosophist Greek *gymnos*, naked: "One of a sect of ancient Hindu philosophers of ascetic habits (known to the Greeks through the reports of the companions of Alexander), who wore little or no clothing, denied themselves flesh meat, and gave themselves up to mystical contemplation." (OED)

1100 : 43.9 *Drinking mead from the skull-cup . . . to shasta and vedas
admirant . . . minding the koran,*

shasta Actually "Shastra." OED: "Any one of the sacred writings of the Hindus." The word was known in English in 1698, but there was a considerable literature on Hinduism in English in Whitman's time.

vedas Together, all of the "four ancient sacred books of the Hindus" (OED). In English from the mid-eighteenth century.

admirant Another bit of dandyism. Nothing in Webster. OED gives one use of “admirance,” by Spenser in 1596.

1101 : 43.10 *Walking the teokallis, spotted with gore from the stone and
knife—beating the serpent-skin drum;*

teokallis Or “teocallis,” singular “teocalli”: an Aztec house of worship, “usually consisting of a four-sided truncated pyramid built terrace-wise, and surmounted by a temple” (OED). Prescott’s immensely popular (and still thrilling and appalling) *History of the Conquest of Mexico* was published in 1843. Prescott: “The floors and walls of the *teocalli* were then cleansed, by the order of Cortes, of their foul impurities.”

1106 : 43.15 *Belonging to the winders of the circuit of circuits.*

winders of the circuit of circuits Itinerant preachers in nineteenth-century America traveled from church to church, tent meeting to tent meeting, in a circuit and were called, not altogether respectfully, “circuit winders.” And there is this coup-let in an 1809 English poem: *So when day breaks, I’ll tempt my fate no more,/ But wind the circuit which I wound before,*” which would make one’s circuit one’s fate. And there are Whitman’s own uses of the word. In *Democratic Vistas*: “At best, we can only offer suggestions, comparisons, circuits.” And elsewhere in “Song of Myself”: “*My sun has his sun, and round him obediently wheels,/ He joins with his partners, a group of superior circuit* (line 1186).”

1113 : 43.20 *How the flukes splash!*

flukes For Webster a fluke is “a flounder,” as it was in English in the sixteenth century, when the barbed ends of an anchor became (by analogy of shape) flukes. OED: “The two parts which constitute the large triangular tail of the whale,” a sense probably also developed from the analogy to the anchor. First citation in the OED is 1725.

1117 : 43.24 *The past is the push of you and me and all precisely the same,*

push Webster 1828 supplies this sense of *push* (n.): “Exigence; trial; extremity.”

1119 : 43.26 *And what is yet untried and afterward is for you and me and all.*

afterward No instance of “afterward” as an adjective in OED.

1127 : 43.33 *Nor him in the poorhouse tubercled by rum and the bad disorder,*

tubercled OED: “Furnished or affected with tubercles; tuberculate.” Tubercle was a term, transferred from botany, for swellings—masses of granulation cells—of an organ. Tuberculosis wasn’t isolated as a disease until 1839. Not clear whether “the bad disorder” is pulmonary TB or venereal disease. The association with rum is apparently a common one at the time.

1128 : 43.34 *Nor the numberless slaughtered and wrecked . . . nor the brutish koboo, called the ordure of humanity,*

koboo The kobo, or kubu, are semi-nomadic forest dwellers who lived, in the nineteenth century, “primarily in swampy areas near watercourses in south-eastern Sumatra, Indonesia.” The term has come to be “a generic label used by outsiders for a number of scattered former hunter-gatherers in Sumatra,” who currently number, according to one estimate, about ten thousand people. What and how Whitman knew of them goes to the question of his general knowledge of geography in his time. He was an omnivorous reader and, of course, an editor and journalist. His general knowledge of the world can be glimpsed in “Salut au Monde,” where the same term shows up: “You poor kobo whom the meanest of the rest look down upon for all your glimmering language and spirituality.” The *Pequod* visits Sumatra, though not the Kubu, in chapter 87 of *Moby Dick*, and Whitman may have known of it also from William Marsden’s 1781 *History of Sumatra* or from Cook’s *Voyages*.

1129 : 43.35 *Nor the sacs merely floating with open mouths for food to slip in,*

sacs “Sac,” without a *k*, as a technical biological term came into English at the end of the eighteenth century and was in wide use in nineteenth-century science. OED: 1851: “In the sea-star, the stomach is a capacious sac.” There is a sense in this line of the nineteenth-century awareness of the immense variety of life forms into which Darwin would, in a few years, introduce a dynamic sense of order.

1146 : 44.13 *All has been gentle with me I keep no account with
lamentation;*

keep no account with Would be lovely to know exactly the provenance of this usage. “With,” not “of,” suggests it is (OED) “*in account with*: in business relations that require keeping of an account *with*. 1832 SCOTT, *Quentin Durward*: Oh! Do not reckon that old debt to my account!”

1148 : 44.15 *I am an acme of things accomplished, and I an encloser of things
to be.*

acme OED notes that the word was often used as a Greek word and written in Greek letters from Roger Ascham in 1380 to Oliver Goldsmith in 1750. It is a fancy enough word in the late eighteenth century that Burke italicizes it in his *Reflections on the Revolution in France* in 1790: “France was by no means at its *acme* in that year.”

encloser Whitman may have had in mind the English sense of “enclose.” “To fence in (waste or common land) with the intention of taking it into cultivation, or of appropriating it to individual owners.” (OED). The notorious Enclosure Acts, giving over communal lands to landlords to raise sheep for the booming wool trade, became law between 1801 and 1845.

1149 : 44.16 *My feet strike an apex of the apices of the stairs,*

apex The Latin word came into English in the Renaissance to mean the tip or highest point of a pyramid or mountain and was figurative as well as technical in the nineteenth century. Here is Charlotte Brontë’s *Villette* (1853) on a bouquet: “It formed an apex to a blooming pyramid.” **Apices** is the Latin plural.

1156 : 44.22 *And took my time . . . and took no hurt from the fœtid carbon.*

carbon Antoine Lavoisier in a 1789 chemical textbook and Joseph Priestly in an essay the same year introduced this term to French and English. Whitman’s use of it is up-to-date science, at a time when theologians were uneasy about nineteenth-century advances in chemistry. The OED cites a text from 1858: Dove, *The Logic of the Christian Faith*: “Is man’s body mere carbon?”

1164 : 44.30 *My embryo has never been torpid . . . nothing could overlay it;*

overlay As a general meaning, OED: “To cover the surface (of a thing) with something else spread over it; to deck out.” As in Ruskin, 1857: “You may make king’s thrones of it, and overlay temple gates with it.” Also, “To lie over or upon (a child); so as to suffocate or smother.” And it is also a technical printer’s term. An overlay was a sheet of paper pasted over the surface of a press to darken the impression.

1165 : 44.31 *For it the nebula cohered to an orb . . .*

nebula cohered to an orb Immanuel Kant in 1755 and Pierre-Simon Laplace in 1796 had elaborated the theory that the universe was formed from gaseous clouds, nebula, flatted by gravity to form the stars and the planets. For Whitman’s astronomical knowledge and enthusiasms, see Beaver, 70–73.

1166 : 44.34 *Monstrous sauroids transported it in their mouths and deposited it with care.*

sauroids “Sauria” as a zoological term for reptiles, from the Latin *sauria* for “lizard,” belongs to the nineteenth century. OED gives a first use in 1836: “M. Agassiz has already ascertained seventeen genera of sauroid fishes.” The word “dinosaur”—terrible lizard—was coined in 1842. The early nineteenth century was a period of discovery; the first fossil remains of the giant reptiles to be recognized for what they were occurred in England in 1819. Greenspan remarks: “The reference here is to the belief that [sauroids] carried their unhatched eggs in their mouths,” but he provides no source.

1169 : 45.1 *Span of youth! Ever-pushed elasticity! Manhood balanced and florid and full!*

ever-pushed elasticity Hard to imagine who else would invent this phrase. “Elastic,” meaning having the property of spontaneously resuming its natural shape after being stretched or dilated by an external force, is a seventeenth-century word. “Elasticity” in the sense of “Energy, vigor, buoyancy of mind” (OED) has a long usage also, and was available in the nineteenth century. 1815,

Scott, *Guy Mannering*: “Nature had given him that elasticity of mind which rises higher from the rebound.” And “ever-pushed” has in it Whitman’s sense of dynamism.

1177 : 45.9 *Bussing my body with soft and balsamic busses,*

buss To kiss. EG cites Robert Herrick: “We buss our wantons but our wives we kiss.” OED says it is an archaic or dialect word, and cites Tennyson, 1847: “Nor burnt the grange, nor buss’d the milking maid.”

balsamic A balsam was, originally, any aromatic resin, like pine resin, and came to mean “any healthful and preservative oil . . . of a softly penetrative nature” (OED). “Balsamic” in nineteenth-century usage, was “delicious, fragrant,” and/or “having the healing properties of balsam.” Longfellow, 1873: “The sweet balsamic fragrance of the pines,” and Macaulay’s *History*, metaphorically, in 1855: “The balsamic virtue of the royal hand.”

1180 : 45.12 *Every condition promulges not only itself . . . it promulges what grows after and out of itself,*

promulge Webster 1828: “To promulgate; to publish. [Less common than *promulgate*.]” OED describes it as *archaic* and gives a couple of nineteenth-century examples. 1882, an encyclopedia of religion: “Fanatics announced visions and promulged prophecies.” None of them quite carry Whitman’s meaning, which seems to lie between “announce” and “beget.”

1181 : 45.13 *And the dark hush promulges as much as any.*

dark hush “Hush” is, of course, the audible quiet after a lot of noise is suddenly stilled. Dark hush? Perhaps, death.

1182 : 45.14 *I open my scuttle at night and see the far-sprinkled systems,*

scuttle Webster 1828: “A square hole in the roof of a house, with a lid.” OED: “Now only U.S.” and cites Webster.

1193 : 45.25 *A few quadrillions of eras, a few octillions of cubic leagues, do not hazard the span, or make it impatient,*

hazard the span OED: “To put (anything) to risk of being lost in a game of chance, or other doubtful manner.” Webster cites a general sense of risk, first, “To hazard salvation for temporal pleasure,” and risk at a game of chance second, “To hazard an estate on the throw of the dice.” Multiple meanings for “span.” Originally the distance from the tip of the thumb to the tip of the little finger. Then, the length of a life. And the distance between the abutments of an arch, or walls carrying a roof. Oliver Wendell Holmes, 1858: “Great minds are those with a wide span.”

1212 : 46.15 *Shoulder your duds, and I will mine, and let us hasten forth;*

duds Webster 1828: “Old clothes; tattered garments. [Vulgar].” “Shoulder” as a verb meaning to carry is cited from 1611.

1214 : 46.17 *If you tire, give me both burdens, and rest the chuff of your hand on my hip,*

chuff Not in Webster or Bartlett with this sense, nor AHD. Nearest is “*obs*, a cheek swollen or puffed with fat.” Seems to mean the meat of the hand.

1216 : 46.19 *For after we start we never lie by again.*

lie by Webster 1828: “To rest; to intermit labor. We lay by during the heat of the day.”

1219 : 46.22 *And my spirit said No, we level that lift to pass and continue beyond.*

level that lift “Level”: To make level, presumably. And “lift” as a noun with the technical meaning of “the distance or extent to which anything rises” (OED). Of canals, 1840: “The difference between levels is called the *lift* of the *lock*.” Feels like it has some such meaning as a term of some art or craft.

1227 : 46.30 *You must habit yourself to the dazzle of the light and of every moment of your life*

habit yourself Webster 1828: “To dress; to clothe; to array. ‘They habited themselves like rural deities.’” OED gives an 1866 use, “To habit herself as she deemed suitable for the journey,” and also describes another sense, “to accustom, familiarize,” as obsolete.

1238 : 47.8 *First rate to ride, to fight, to hit the bull’s eye,*

first rate Bartlett, 1848: “Of the first class or order; superior; superexcellent. An expression now in very common use, applied, as most superlatives are in the United States, with very little discrimination. It was formerly said of large and important things, as ‘a *first rate* ship.’ Now we hear of ‘*first rate* pigs,’ ‘*first rate* liquors,’ ‘*first rate* lawyers.’ It is also used adverbially; thus if we ask a person how he is, he replies, ‘I am *first rate*,’ i.e. in excellent health, very well. ‘The *first rate* importance of the subject, and the real merits of the work, are deserving of a portion of our space.’ — *Westminster Rev.* July, 1847. ‘A young woman wants a situation as a chambermaid. She is a *first rate* washer and ironer, and plain sewer.’ — *Adv. in N. Y. Tribune.*”

bull’s eye The first use of “bull’s eye” to mean “the center of a target” the OED gives is 1833 in a cavalry manual. Dickens in 1840: “This is wide of the bull’s eye.”

1239 : 47.9 *Preferring scars and faces pitted with smallpox over all latherers and those that keep out of the sun.*

latherers Nothing in Webster or Bartlett. OED cites from *Westminster Gazette*, 1899: “Boys employed as latherers in barber’s shops.” But this must be men foppishly clean-shaven.

1250 : 47.21 *The maul the oar and the handsaw second my words.*

maul A heavy hammer, typically a shipwright’s tool.

1265 : 48.4 *And whoever walks a furlong without sympathy walks to his own funeral, dressed in his shroud,*

furlong Webster 1828: “A measure of length; the eighth part of a mile; forty rods, poles or perches.”

1266 : 48.5 *And I or you pocketless of a dime may purchase the pick of the earth,*

the pick Webster, 1828: “Choice; right of selection. ‘You may have your pick.’” OED gives a usage as early as 1755, but quotes George Eliot in *Middlemarch*, 1872: “Mama, I wish you would not say ‘the pick of them,’ it is a rather vulgar expression.”

1282 : 49.2 *To his work without flinching the accoucheur comes,*

accoucheur Webster 1828: “A man who assists women in childbirth.” So Whitman wasn’t using a fancy foreign word. According to one history (*Birth: The Amazing Story of How We Are Born*, by Tina Cassidy, 2006), Louis XIV began the fashion of male midwives by choosing a man rather than a woman to deliver the babies of his mistresses. By the early nineteenth century it was a male medical practice. The *Accoucheur’s Vademecum: or Modern Guide to the Practice of Midwifery* was published in London in 1840 by Thomas Travers Burke. The term “obstetrics” came into use in 1821.

1283 : 49.3 *I see the elderhand pressing receiving supporting,*

elderhand See the note to line 83. Whitman used this phrase, apparently of his own invention, twice in the poem. In subsequent revisions he cut the first use and here changed the spelling to “elder-hand.” So the hand here belongs not to the accoucheur but to nature or divinity.

1293 : 49.15 *Of the moon that descends the steeps of the soothing twilight,*

soothing This venerable bit of onomatopoeia is not in Webster. OED, more evocatively than usual: “A rushing, or murmuring, sound as of wind, water, or the like, esp. one of a gentle or soothing nature.” Geoffrey Chaucer, 1382: “Of

sykys hoote as fuyr I herde a swow that gan aboute renne.” Emily Brontë, 1847; “The evening calm betrayed alike the tinkle of the nearest stream and the sough of the most remote.”

1295 : 49.17 *Toss to the moaning gibberish of the dry limbs.*

gibberish Webster 1828: “Rapid and inarticulate talk; unintelligible language; unmeaning words.” The word goes back to the 1550s in England and is related to “jabber.”

1298 : 49.20 *And debouch to the steady and central from the offspring great or small.*

debouch Webster 1828: “To issue or march out of a narrow place, or from defiles, as troops.” For the OED it is also first a military term, but gives a geographical instance—Bayard Taylor, *El Dorado*, 1850: “The ravine finally debouched upon the river at the Middle Bar”—and a figurative one from the London *Times*, 1839: “M. Labouchere debouches upon the cabinet.”

1306 : 50.7 *Perhaps I might tell more Outlines! I plead for my brothers and sisters.*

Outlines Mysterious word here. Webster 1828: “Contour; the line by which a figure is defined; the exterior line.” The meaning you would expect, but what does Whitman mean? It may connect to his work as an editor and printer. OED: “A sketch or drawing in which an object is represented by lines of contour without shading. 1868, *Freehand Drawing*: “The outlines and finished views of these casts are given separately.” And “A rough draft or general sketch in words; a description, giving a general idea of the whole, but leaving the details to be filled in. 1865: ‘I have given a bare outline of the contents of this passage.’”

1310 : 51.2 *And proceed to fill my next fold of the future.*

fold Webster 1828: “1. A pen or inclosure for sheep; a place where a flock of sheep is kept, whether in the field or under shelter.” And “1. The doubling of any flexible substance, as cloth; complication; a plait; one part turned or bent and laid on another; as a fold of linen. 2. In composition, the same quantity added;

as two fold, four fold, ten fold, that is, twice as much, four times as much, ten times as much.” EHM: “Fold’ is a notable word in Whitman with its maternal connotations obvious in the line ‘*unfolded out of the folds, man comes unfolded, and is always to come unfolded*’ where the syllable is repeated almost like an *idée fixe*.” (p. 135)

1312 : 51.4 *Look in my face while I snuff the sidle of evening,*

snuff the sidle “Snuff” is clear enough; though Webster 1828 gives it only as a noun, meaning “1. The burning part of a candle wick, or that which has been charred by the flame, whether burning or not” and “2. A candle almost burnt out,” OED gives the transitive verb, “To free (a candle, wick, etc.) from the snuff by cutting this off.” There were tools called snuffers for the purpose. For the general sense of “extinguish, put out,” OED instances Dickens, *Barnaby Rudge*, 1841: “Slight yellow specks that seemed to be rapidly snuffed out one by one.” For Webster “sidle” is only a verb: “1. To go or move side foremost; as, to sidle through a crowd. 2. To lie on the side.” OED defines the noun—“An act of sidling; a side-long or oblique movement”—and gives two instances, both from the nineteenth century and both nautical. 1853: “Turning the sidle into a stately sail.” 1883: “The final sidle up to the dock was a very inglorious effort of poling.” By 1900 the noun had moved to land: “Susan coming forward with a coquettish sidle.” The image seems to be of a lordly extinguishing of the day, a sunset.

1321 : 52.1 *The spotted hawk swoops by and accuses me . . . he complains of my gab and my loitering.*

spotted hawk Most immature hawks have spotted breasts. Our candidate for this bird’s sound and appearance is the red-tailed hawk, *buteo jamaicensis*, which might very well have been seen over the rooftops of Brooklyn in the mid-nineteenth century, though this bird’s cry more closely resembles a red-shouldered hawk’s or an osprey’s. Red-tails, perhaps descendants of Whitman’s bird, nest in Prospect Park to this day.

gab Webster 1828: “The mouth, as in the phrase ‘the gift of gab,’ that is, loquaciousness. But the word is so vulgar as rarely to be used.” OED dates “conversation, talk, twaddle, prattle” from 1790.

1323 : 52.3 *I sound my barbaric yawp over the roofs of the world.*

yawp The cries of the red-tailed hawk, the red-shouldered hawk, and the osprey are about equally shrill, piercing and exultant. William Dean Howells, who met Whitman when the poet was an older man, had this to say about him: “The apostle of the rough, the uncouth, is the gentlest person; his barbaric yawp, translated into the terms of social encounter, was an address of singular quiet, delivered in a voice of winning and endearing friendliness.”

1324 : 52.4 *The last scud of day holds back for me,*

scud Webster 1828: “1. A low, thin cloud, or thin cloud driven by the wind; 2. A driving along, a rushing with precipitation.” This latter meaning comes from the verb form and the weather eye of seamen: “In seamen’s language, to be driven with precipitation before a tempest.” OED gives “hurried movement. 1853: ‘The scud of the clouds before the wind.’” And “Light clouds driven before the wind. Scott, 1814: ‘The darkening scud comes on.’” Pretty clearly a cloud here, which the speaker in the poem is becoming.

1328 : 52.8 *I effuse my flesh in eddies and drift it in lacy jags.*

effuse Webster 1828: “To pour out as a fluid, to spill, to shed.” Old associations with the flow of blood. More recent ones with weather. Hawthorne: “The same gentle shower had been effusing itself all morning.” And with emotion: Shenstone, 1750: “T’was his fond hart effus’d the melting theme.”

jags Webster 1828 gives the verb “jagg”: “To notch, or to cut into notches or teeth like those of a saw” and for “jagged”: “Notched, uneven; having notches of teeth; cleft; lacinate; as jagged leaves.” *Lacinate* is interesting, from the Latin for “hem,” because it picks up on “lacy.” OED also gives “A shred of cloth, *in plural* rags or tatters. 1800, Maria Edgeworth: ‘Black jags of paper littering the place.’”

1333 : 52.13 *And filter and fibre your blood.*

fibre (v) According to OED a botanical term but *rare*. “To form or throw out fibres. 1869: ‘The plant is sufficiently strong to fibre as prodigally as it likes.’” (Not a bad sentence with which to end this slightly mad catalogue.)

SOURCES

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I N T R O D U C T I O N

A sampling of *Leaves of Grass*

There has been a consensus among Walt Whitman's twentieth-century readers that his great achievement, after "Song Of Myself," lay in a handful of long poems, which, like "Song," are also in a form that seems taken from the Romantic ode: "Crossing Brooklyn Ferry," "Out of the Cradle Endlessly Rocking," "As I Ebb'd with the Ocean of Life," and his elegy for Lincoln, "When Lilacs Last in the Dooryard Bloom'd." Readers have also been drawn to *Drum Taps*, his poems of the Civil War, especially because of his experience in Washington, D.C., in the hospital wards of the war.

And there is also the fascination, paging through the five hundred pages of the 1891–92 edition of the book, of seeing Whitman experimenting through the years with this new instrument he had invented: a supple, long-lined free verse. Our ears have become so accustomed to it that it is easy to forget how novel his poems were, technically. To take a simple example, it was not apparent, once he had abandoned rhyme, what a stanza was for, since what had determined stanza patterns in the entire history of English poetry had been rhyme schemes.

In addition to the long poems (with their catalogues that Emerson and others grew so weary of), he experimented in a number of ways with short forms—with the couplet, the three-line poem, brief images, anecdotes, thoughts, notations on the margins of his thoughts. Some of the most interesting of them—"The Dalliance of Eagles," "A Farm Picture," "The Runner"—anticipate the imagist procedures of the young modernists who came a half century later. Some of them—the remarkable "A Glimpse," "I Saw in Louisiana a Live-Oak Growing," "Sparkles from the Wheel"—have almost no antecedents in the lyric poetry that came before him.

Reading through all of these poems, we are also reading our way into the formation of a great style—that Whitman did not always achieve, but in his best poems, he made an instrument of great suppleness and range and power, delicacy and strength. It is moving in the notebooks to get glimpses of the way in which he thought about this labor. Here is one undated passage:

In future Leaves of Grass. Be more severe with the final revision of the poem, nothing will do, not one word or sentence, that is not perfectly clear—with positive purpose—harmony with the name, nature, drift of the poem. Also no ornaments, especially no ornamental adjectives, unless they have come molten hot, and imperiously prove themselves. No ornamental similes at all—not one: perfect transparent clearness sanity and health are wanted—that is the divine style—O if it can be attained—

What follows is a sampling of those great long poems and of his brilliant and surprising experiments in the short form—and in “the divine style,” which has become in so many poets the idiom of our literature.

To You

Whoever you are, I fear you are walking the walks of dreams,
I fear these supposed realities are to melt from under your feet and hands,
Even now your features, joys, speech, house, trade, manners,
 troubles, follies, costume, crimes, dissipate away from you,
Your true soul and body appear before me,
They stand forth out of affairs, out of commerce, shops, work,
 farms, clothes, the house, buying, selling, eating, drinking,
 suffering, dying.

Whoever you are, now I place my hand upon you, that you be my poem,
I whisper with my lips close to your ear,
I have loved many women and men, but I love none better than you.

O I have been dilatory and dumb,
I should have made my way straight to you long ago,
I should have blabb'd nothing but you, I should have chanted nothing
 but you.

I will leave all and come and make the hymns of you,
None has understood you, but I understand you,
None has done justice to you, you have not done justice to yourself,
None but has found you imperfect, I only find no imperfection in you,
None but would subordinate you, I only am he who will never consent
 to subordinate you,
I only am he who places over you no master, owner, better, God,
 beyond what waits intrinsically in yourself.

Painters have painted their swarming groups and the centre-figure of all,
From the head of the centre-figure spreading a nimbus of gold-color'd light,

But I paint myriads of heads, but paint no head without its nimbus
of gold-color'd light,
From my hand from the brain of every man and woman it streams,
effulgently flowing forever.

O I could sing such grandeurs and glories about you!
You have not known what you are, you have slumber'd upon yourself
all your life,
Your eyelids have been the same as closed most of the time,
What you have done returns already in mockeries,
(Your thrift, knowledge, prayers, if they do not return in
mockeries, what is their return?)

The mockeries are not you,
Underneath them and within them I see you lurk,
I pursue you where none else has pursued you,
Silence, the desk, the flippant expression, the night, the
accustom'd routine, if these conceal you from others or from
yourself, they do not conceal you from me,
The shaved face, the unsteady eye, the impure complexion, if these
balk others they do not balk me,
The pert apparel, the deform'd attitude, drunkenness, greed,
premature death, all these I part aside.

There is no endowment in man or woman that is not tallied in you,
There is no virtue, no beauty in man or woman, but as good is in you,
No pluck, no endurance in others, but as good is in you,
No pleasure waiting for others, but an equal pleasure waits for you.

As for me, I give nothing to any one except I give the like carefully
to you,
I sing the songs of the glory of none, not God, sooner than I sing
the songs of the glory of you.

Whoever you are! claim your own at any hazard!
These shows of the East and West are tame compared to you,
These immense meadows, these interminable rivers, you are immense
and interminable as they,
These furies, elements, storms, motions of Nature, throes of apparent
dissolution, you are he or she who is master or mistress over them,
Master or mistress in your own right over Nature, elements, pain,
passion, dissolution.

The hobbles fall from your ankles, you find an unfailing sufficiency,
Old or young, male or female, rude, low, rejected by the rest,
whatever you are promulges itself,
Through birth, life, death, burial, the means are provided, nothing
is scanted,
Through angers, losses, ambition, ignorance, ennui, what you are
picks its way.

[1856]

Crossing Brooklyn Ferry

~ 1 ~

Flood-tide below me! I see you face to face!
Clouds of the west—sun there half an hour high—I see you also face
to face.

Crowds of men and women attired in the usual costumes, how curious
you are to me!
On the ferry-boats the hundreds and hundreds that cross, returning
home, are more curious to me than you suppose,
And you that shall cross from shore to shore years hence are more
to me, and more in my meditations, than you might suppose.

~ 2 ~

The impalpable sustenance of me from all things at all hours of the day,
The simple, compact, well-join'd scheme, myself disintegrated, every
one disintegrated yet part of the scheme,
The similitudes of the past and those of the future,
The glories strung like beads on my smallest sights and hearings, on
the walk in the street and the passage over the river,
The current rushing so swiftly and swimming with me far away,
The others that are to follow me, the ties between me and them,
The certainty of others, the life, love, sight, hearing of others.

Others will enter the gates of the ferry and cross from shore to shore,
Others will watch the run of the flood-tide,
Others will see the shipping of Manhattan north and west, and the
heights of Brooklyn to the south and east,
Others will see the islands large and small;
Fifty years hence, others will see them as they cross, the sun half
an hour high,

A hundred years hence, or ever so many hundred years hence, others
will see them,
Will enjoy the sunset, the pouring-in of the flood-tide, the
falling-back to the sea of the ebb-tide.

~ 3 ~

It avails not, time nor place—distance avails not,
I am with you, you men and women of a generation, or ever so many
generations hence,
Just as you feel when you look on the river and sky, so I felt,
Just as any of you is one of a living crowd, I was one of a crowd,
Just as you are refresh'd by the gladness of the river and the
bright flow, I was refresh'd,
Just as you stand and lean on the rail, yet hurry with the swift
current, I stood yet was hurried,
Just as you look on the numberless masts of ships and the
thick-stemm'd pipes of steamboats, I look'd.

I too many and many a time cross'd the river of old,
Watched the Twelfth-month sea-gulls, saw them high in the air
floating with motionless wings, oscillating their bodies,
Saw how the glistening yellow lit up parts of their bodies and left
the rest in strong shadow,
Saw the slow-wheeling circles and the gradual edging toward the south,
Saw the reflection of the summer sky in the water,
Had my eyes dazzled by the shimmering track of beams,
Look'd at the fine centrifugal spokes of light round the shape of my
head in the sunlit water,
Look'd on the haze on the hills southward and south-westward,
Look'd on the vapor as it flew in fleeces tinged with violet,
Look'd toward the lower bay to notice the vessels arriving,
Saw their approach, saw aboard those that were near me,

Saw the white sails of schooners and sloops, saw the ships at anchor,
The sailors at work in the rigging or out astride the spars,
The round masts, the swinging motion of the hulls, the slender
 serpentine pennants,
The large and small steamers in motion, the pilots in their pilothouses,
The white wake left by the passage, the quick tremulous whirl of the wheels,
The flags of all nations, the falling of them at sunset,
The scallop-edged waves in the twilight, the ladled cups, the
 frolicsome crests and glistening,
The stretch afar growing dimmer and dimmer, the gray walls of the
 granite storehouses by the docks,
On the river the shadowy group, the big steam-tug closely flank'd on
 each side by the barges, the hay-boat, the belated lighter,
On the neighboring shore the fires from the foundry chimneys burning
 high and glaringly into the night,
Casting their flicker of black contrasted with wild red and yellow
 light over the tops of houses, and down into the clefts of streets.

~ 4 ~

These and all else were to me the same as they are to you,
I loved well those cities, loved well the stately and rapid river,
The men and women I saw were all near to me,
Others the same—others who look back on me because I look'd forward
 to them,
(The time will come, though I stop here to-day and to-night.)

~ 5 ~

What is it then between us?
What is the count of the scores or hundreds of years between us?

Whatever it is, it avails not—distance avails not, and place avails not,
I too lived, Brooklyn of ample hills was mine,

I too walk'd the streets of Manhattan island, and bathed in the
waters around it,
I too felt the curious abrupt questionings stir within me,
In the day among crowds of people sometimes they came upon me,
In my walks home late at night or as I lay in my bed they came upon me,
I too had been struck from the float forever held in solution,
I too had receiv'd identity by my body,
That I was I knew was of my body, and what I should be I knew I
should be of my body.

~ 6 ~

It is not upon you alone the dark patches fall,
The dark threw its patches down upon me also,
The best I had done seem'd to me blank and suspicious,
My great thoughts as I supposed them, were they not in reality meagre?
Nor is it you alone who know what it is to be evil,
I am he who knew what it was to be evil,
I too knitted the old knot of contrariety,
Blabb'd, blush'd, resented, lied, stole, grudg'd,
Had guile, anger, lust, hot wishes I dared not speak,
Was wayward, vain, greedy, shallow, sly, cowardly, malignant,
The wolf, the snake, the hog, not wanting in me.
The cheating look, the frivolous word, the adulterous wish, not wanting,
Refusals, hates, postponements, meanness, laziness, none of these wanting,
Was one with the rest, the days and haps of the rest,
Was call'd by my highest name by clear loud voices of young men as
they saw me approaching or passing,
Felt their arms on my neck as I stood, or the negligent leaning of
their flesh against me as I sat,
Saw many I loved in the street or ferry-boat or public assembly, yet
never told them a word,
Lived the same life with the rest, the same old laughing, gnawing, sleeping,

Play'd the part that still looks back on the actor or actress,
The same old role, the role that is what we make it, as great as we like,
Or as small as we like, or both great and small.

~ 7 ~

Closer yet I approach you,
What thought you have of me now, I had as much of you—I laid in my
stores in advance,
I consider'd long and seriously of you before you were born.

Who was to know what should come home to me?
Who knows but I am enjoying this?
Who knows, for all the distance, but I am as good as looking at you
now, for all you cannot see me?

~ 8 ~

Ah, what can ever be more stately and admirable to me than
mast-hemm'd Manhattan?
River and sunset and scallop-edg'd waves of flood-tide?
The sea-gulls oscillating their bodies, the hay-boat in the
twilight, and the belated lighter?
What gods can exceed these that clasp me by the hand, and with voices I
love call me promptly and loudly by my highest name as approach?
What is more subtle than this which ties me to the woman or man that
looks in my face?
Which fuses me into you now, and pours my meaning into you?

We understand then do we not?
What I promis'd without mentioning it, have you not accepted?
What the study could not teach—what the preaching could not
accomplish is accomplish'd, is it not?

Flow on, river! flow with the flood-tide, and ebb with the ebb-tide!
 Frolic on, crested and scallop-edg'd waves!
 Gorgeous clouds of the sunset! drench with your splendor me, or the
 men and women generations after me!
 Cross from shore to shore, countless crowds of passengers!
 Stand up, tall masts of Mannahatta! stand up, beautiful hills of Brooklyn!
 Throb, baffled and curious brain! throw out questions and answers!
 Suspend here and everywhere, eternal float of solution!
 Gaze, loving and thirsting eyes, in the house or street or public assembly!
 Sound out, voices of young men! loudly and musically call me by my
 nighest name!
 Live, old life! play the part that looks back on the actor or actress!
 Play the old role, the role that is great or small according as one
 makes it!
 Consider, you who peruse me, whether I may not in unknown ways be
 looking upon you;
 Be firm, rail over the river, to support those who lean idly, yet
 haste with the hasting current;
 Fly on, sea-birds! fly sideways, or wheel in large circles high in the air;
 Receive the summer sky, you water, and faithfully hold it till all
 downcast eyes have time to take it from you!
 Diverge, fine spokes of light, from the shape of my head, or any
 one's head, in the sunlit water!
 Come on, ships from the lower bay! pass up or down, white-sail'd
 schooners, sloops, lighters!
 Flaunt away, flags of all nations! be duly lower'd at sunset!
 Burn high your fires, foundry chimneys! cast black shadows at
 nightfall! cast red and yellow light over the tops of the houses!
 Appearances, now or henceforth, indicate what you are,
 You necessary film, continue to envelop the soul,
 About my body for me, and your body for you, be hung our divinest aromas,

Thrive, cities—bring your freight, bring your shows, ample and
sufficient rivers,
Expand, being than which none else is perhaps more spiritual,
Keep your places, objects than which none else is more lasting.

You have waited, you always wait, you dumb, beautiful ministers,
We receive you with free sense at last, and are insatiate henceforward,
Not you any more shall be able to foil us, or withhold yourselves from us,
We use you, and do not cast you aside—we plant you permanently within us,
We fathom you not—we love you—there is perfection in you also,
You furnish your parts toward eternity,
Great or small, you furnish your parts toward the soul.

[1856]

This Compost

~ 1 ~

Something startles me where I thought I was safest;
I withdraw from the still woods I loved;
I will not go now on the pastures to walk;
I will not strip the clothes from my body to meet my lover the sea;
I will not touch my flesh to the earth, as to other flesh, to renew me.

O how can it be that the ground does not sicken?
How can you be alive, you growths of spring?
How can you furnish health, you blood of herbs, roots, orchards, grain?
Are they not continually putting distemper'd corpses within you?
Is not every continent work'd over and over with sour dead?

Where have you disposed of their carcasses?
Those drunkards and gluttons of so many generations;
Where have you drawn off all the foul liquid and meat?
I do not see any of it upon you to-day—or perhaps I am deceiv'd;
I will run a furrow with my plough—I will press my spade through the sod,
 and turn it up underneath;
I am sure I shall expose some of the foul meat.

~ 2 ~

Behold this compost! behold it well!
Perhaps every mite has once form'd part of a sick person—Yet behold!
The grass of spring covers the prairies,
The bean bursts noislessly through the mould in the garden,
The delicate spear of the onion pierces upward,
The apple-buds cluster together on the apple-branches,
The resurrection of the wheat appears with pale visage out of its graves,

The tinge awakes over the willow-tree and the mulberry-tree,
The he-birds carol mornings and evenings, while the she-birds sit on their
 nests,
The young of poultry break through the hatch'd eggs,
The new-born of animals appear—the calf is dropt from the cow, the colt
 from the mare,
Out of its little hill faithfully rise the potato's dark green leaves,
Out of its hill rises the yellow maize-stalk—the lilacs bloom in the door-
 yards;
The summer growth is innocent and disdainful above all those strata of sour
 dead.

What chemistry!
That the winds are really not infectious,
That this is no cheat, this transparent green-wash of the sea, which is so
 amorous after me,
That it is safe to allow it to lick my naked body all over with its tongues,
That it will not endanger me with the fevers that have deposited themselves
 in it,
That all is clean forever and forever.
That the cool drink from the well tastes so good,
That blackberries are so flavorful and juicy,
That the fruits of the apple-orchard, and of the orange-orchard—that melons,
 grapes, peaches, plums, will none of them poison me,
That when I recline on the grass I do not catch any disease,
Though probably every spear of grass rises out of what was once a catching
 disease.

Now I am terrified at the Earth! it is that calm and patient,
It grows such sweet things out of such corruptions,
It turns harmless and stainless on its axis, with such endless successions of
 diseas'd corpses,

It distils such exquisite winds out of such infused fetor,
It renews with such unwitting looks, its prodigal, annual, sumptuous crops,
It gives such divine materials to men, and accepts such leavings from them at
last.

[1856]

I Am He That Aches With Love

I am he that aches with amorous love;
Does the earth gravitate? does not all matter, aching, attract all
matter?
So the body of me to all I meet or know.

[1860]

Once I Pass'd Through a Populous City

Once I pass'd through a populous city imprinting my brain for future
use with its shows, architecture, customs, traditions,
Yet now of all that city I remember only a woman I casually met
there who detain'd me for love of me,
Day by day and night by night we were together—all else has long
been forgotten by me,
I remember I say only that woman who passionately clung to me,
Again we wander, we love, we separate again,
Again she holds me by the hand, I must not go,
I see her close beside me with silent lips sad and tremulous.

Unpublished version:

Once I passed through a populous celebrated city, imprinting my brain for
future use, with its shows, architecture, customs and traditions,
But now of all that city I remember only the man who wandered with me,
there, for love of me,
Day by day, and night by night, we were together

All else has long been forgotten by me—I remember, I say, only one rude and
ignorant man who, when I departed, long and long held me by the
hand, with silent lip, sad and tremulous.—

[1859]

City of Orgies

City of orgies, walks and joys,
City whom that I have lived and sung in your midst will one day make
 you illustrious,
Not the pageants of you, not your shifting tableaux, your
 spectacles, repay me,
Not the interminable rows of your houses, nor the ships at the wharves,
Nor the processions in the streets, nor the bright windows with
 goods in them,
Nor to converse with learn'd persons, or bear my share in the soiree
 or feast;
Not those, but as I pass O Manhattan, your frequent and swift flash
 of eyes offering me love,
Offering response to my own—these repay me,
Lovers, continual lovers, only repay me.

[1860]

I Saw in Louisiana a Live-Oak Growing

I saw in Louisiana a live-oak growing,
All alone stood it and the moss hung down from the branches,
Without any companion it grew there uttering joyous leaves of dark green,
And its look, rude, unbending, lusty, made me think of myself,
But I wonder'd how it could utter joyous leaves standing alone there
 without its friend near, for I knew I could not,
And I broke off a twig with a certain number of leaves upon it and
 twined around it a little moss,
And brought it away, and I have placed it in sight in my room,
It is not needed to remind me as of my own dear friends,
(For I believe lately I think of little else than of them,)
Yet it remains to me a curious token, it makes me think of manly love;
For all that, and though the live-oak glistens there in Louisiana
 solitary in a wide flat space,
Uttering joyous leaves all its life without a friend a lover near,
I know very well I could not.

[1860]

A Glimpse

A glimpse through an interstice caught,
Of a crowd of workmen and drivers in a bar-room around the stove
late of a winter night, and I unremark'd seated in a corner,
Of a youth who loves me and whom I love, silently approaching and
seating himself near, that he may hold me by the hand,
A long while amid the noises of coming and going, of drinking and
oath and smutty jest,
There we two, content, happy in being together, speaking little,
perhaps not a word.

[1860]

Sometimes with One I Love

Sometimes with one I love I fill myself with rage for fear I effuse unreturn'd
love,

But now I think there is no unreturn'd love, the pay is certain one way or
another,

(I loved a certain person ardently and my love was not return'd,
Yet out of that I have written these songs.)

[1860]

Out of the Cradle Endlessly Rocking

Out of the cradle endlessly rocking,
Out of the mocking-bird's throat, the musical shuttle,
Out of the Ninth-month midnight,
Over the sterile sands and the fields beyond where the child, leaving his bed
 wander'd alone, bareheaded, barefoot,
Down from the shower'd halo,
Up from the mystic play of shadows twining and twisting as if they were
 alive,
Out from the patches of briars and blackberries,
From the memories of the bird that chanted to me,
From your memories sad brother, from the fitful risings and fallings I heard,
From under that yellow half-moon, late-risen, and swollen as if with tears,
From those beginning notes of yearning and love there in the mist,
From the thousand responses of my heart, never to cease,
From the myriad thence-arous'd words,
From the word stronger and more delicious than any,
From such as now they start the scene revisiting,
As a flock, twittering, rising, or overhead passing,
Borne hither, ere all eludes me, hurriedly,
A man, yet by these tears a little boy again,
Throwing myself on the sand, confronting the waves,
I, chanter of pains and joys, uniter of here and hereafter,
Taking all hints to use them, but swiftly leaping beyond them,
A reminiscence sing.

Once, Paumanok,
When the lilac-scent was in the air and Fifth-month grass was growing,
Up this sea-shore, in some briars,
Two feather'd guests from Alabama, two together,
And their nest, and four light-green eggs spotted with brown,

And every day the he-bird to and fro near at hand,
And every day the she-bird crouch'd on her nest, silent, with bright eyes,
And every day I, a curious boy, never too close, never disturbing them,
Cautiously peering, absorbing, translating.

Shine! shine! shine!
Pour down your warmth, great Sun!
While we bask—we two together.

Two together!
Winds blow South, or winds blow North,
Day come white, or night come black,
Home, or rivers and mountains from home,
Singing all time, minding no time,
While we two keep together.

Till of a sudden,
May-be kill'd, unknown to her mate,
One forenoon the she-bird crouch'd not on the nest,
Nor return'd that afternoon, nor the next,
Nor ever appear'd again.

And thenceforward all summer in the sound of the sea,
And at night under the full of the moon in calmer weather,
Over the hoarse surging of the sea,
Or flitting from brier to brier by day,
I saw, I heard at intervals the remaining one, the he-bird,
The solitary guest from Alabama.

Blow! blow! blow!
Blow up, sea-winds, along Paumanok's shore;
I wait and I wait till you blow my mate to me.

Yes, when the stars glisten'd,
All night long on the prong of a moss-scallop'd stake,
Down almost amid the slapping waves,
Sat the lone singer wonderful causing tears.

He call'd on his mate,
He pour'd forth the meanings which I of all men know.

Yes my brother I know,
The rest might not, but I have treasur'd every note
For more than once dimly down to the beach gliding,
Silent, avoiding the moonbeams, blending myself with the shadows,
Recalling now the obscure shapes, the echoes, the sounds and sights after
 their sorts,
The white arms out in the breakers tirelessly tossing,
I, with bare feet, a child, the wind wafting my hair,
Listen'd long and long.

Listen'd to keep, to sing, now translating the notes,
Following you my brother.

Soothe! soothe! soothe!
Close on its wave soothes the wave behind,
And again another behind, embracing and lapping, every one close,
But my love soothes not me, not me.

Low hangs the moon, it rose late
O it is lagging—O I think it is heavy with love, with love.

O madly the sea, pushes upon the land,
With love, with love.

*O night! do I not see my love fluttering out there among the breakers?
What is that little black thing I see there in the white?*

*Loud! loud! loud!
Loud I call to you, my love!*

*High and clear I shoot my voice over the waves,
Surely you must know who is here, is here,
You must know who I am, my love.*

*Low-hanging moon!
What is that dusky spot in your brown yellow?
O it is the shape, the shape of my mate!
O moon, do not keep her from me any longer.*

*Land! land! O land!
Whichever way I turn, O I think you could give me my mate back again if you
only would,
For I am almost sure I see her dimly whichever way I look.*

*O rising stars!
Perhaps the one I want so much will rise, will rise with some of you.*

*O throat! O trembling throat!
Sound clearer through the atmosphere!
Pierce the woods, the earth,
Somewhere listening to catch you must be the one I want.*

*Shake out carols!
Solitary here, the night's carols!
Carols of lonesome love! death's carols!
Carols under that lagging, yellow, waning moon!*

*O under that moon where she droops almost down into the sea!
O reckless despairing carols.*

*But soft! sink low;
Soft! let me just murmur,
And do you wait a moment you husky-noised sea,
For somewhere I believe I heard my mate responding to me,
So faint, I must be still, be still to listen,
But not altogether still, for then she might not come immediately to me.*

*Hither my love!
Here I am! here!
With this just-sustain'd note I announce myself to you,
This gentle call is for you my love, for you.*

*Do not be decoy'd elsewhere,
That is the whistle of the wind, it is not my voice,
That is the fluttering, the fluttering of the spray,
Those are the shadows of leaves.*

*O darkness! O in vain!
O I am very sick and sorrowful.*

*O brown halo in the sky near the moon, drooping upon the sea!
O troubled reflection in the sea!
O throat! O throbbing heart!
And I singing uselessly, uselessly all the night.*

*O past! O happy life! O songs of joy!
In the air, in the woods, over fields,
Loved! loved! loved! loved! loved!
But my mate no more, no more with me!
We two together no more.*

The aria sinking,
All else continuing, the stars shining,
The winds blowing, the notes of the bird continuous echoing,
With angry moans the fierce old mother incessantly moaning,
On the sands of Paumanok's shore gray and rustling,
The yellow half-moon enlarged, sagging down, drooping, the face of the sea
almost touching,
The boy ecstatic, with his bare feet the waves, with his hair the atmosphere
dallying,
The love in the heart long pent, now loose, now at last tumultuously bursting,
The aria's meaning, the ears, the Soul, swiftly depositing,
The strange tears down the cheeks coursing,
The colloquy there, the trio, each uttering,
The undertone, the savage old mother incessantly crying,
To the boy's soul's questions sullenly timing, some drown'd secret hissing,
To the outsetting bard of love.

Demon or bird! (said the boy's soul,)
Is it indeed toward your mate you sing? or is it really to me?
For I, that was a child, my tongue's use sleeping, now I have heard you,
Now in a moment I know what I am for, I awake,
And already a thousand singers, a thousand songs, clearer, louder and more
sorrowful than yours,
A thousand warbling echoes have started to life within me, never to die.

O you singer, solitary, singing by yourself, projecting me,
O solitary me listening, nevermore shall I cease perpetuating you,
Never more shall I escape, never more the reverberations,
Never more the cries of unsatisfied love be absent from me,
Never again leave me to be the peaceful child I was before what there in the
night,
By the sea under the yellow and sagging moon,
The messenger there arous'd, the fire, the sweet hell within,
The unknown want, the destiny of me.

O give me the clew! (it lurks in the night here somewhere,)
O if I am to have so much, let me have more!

A word then, (for I will conquer it,)
The word final, superior to all,
Subtle, sent up—what is it?—I listen;
Are you whispering it, and have been all the time, you sea-waves?
Is that it from your liquid rims and wet sands?

Whereto answering, the sea,
Delaying not, hurrying not,
Whisper'd me through the night, and very plainly before day-break,
Lisp'd to me the low and delicious word death,
And again death, death, death, death,
Hissing melodious, neither like the bird nor like my arous'd child's heart,
But edging near as privately for me rustling at my feet,
Creeping thence steadily up to my ears, and laving me softly all over,
Death, death, death, death, death.

Which I do not forget,
But fuse the song of my dusky demon and brother,
That he sang to me in the moonlight on Paumanok's gray beach,
With the thousand responsive songs at random,
My own songs awaked from that hour;
And with them the key, the word up from the waves,
The word of the sweetest song and all songs,
That strong and delicious word which, creeping to my feet,
(or like some old crone rocking the cradle, swathed in sweet garments,
 bending aside,)
The sea whisper'd me.

[1860]

As I Ebb'd with the Ocean of Life

~ 1 ~

As I ebb'd with the ocean of life,
As I wended the shores I know,
As I walk'd where the ripples continually wash you Paumanok,
Where they rustle up hoarse and sibilant,
Where the fierce old mother endlessly cries for her castaways,
I musing late in the autumn day, gazing off southward,
Held by this electric self out of the pride of which I utter poems,
Was seiz'd by the spirit that trails in the lines underfoot,
The rim, the sediment that stands for all the water and all the land
of the globe.

Fascinated, my eyes reverting from the south, dropt, to follow those
slender windrows,
Chaff, straw, splinters of wood, weeds, and the sea-gluten,
Scum, scales from shining rocks, leaves of salt-lettuce, left by the tide,
Miles walking, the sound of breaking waves the other side of me,
Paumanok there and then as I thought the old thought of likenesses,
These you presented to me you fish-shaped island,
As I wended the shores I know,
As I walk'd with that electric self seeking types.

~ 2 ~

As I wend to the shores I know not,
As I list to the dirge, the voices of men and women wreck'd,
As I inhale the impalpable breezes that set in upon me,
As the ocean so mysterious rolls toward me closer and closer,
I too but signify at the utmost a little wash'd-up drift,

A few sands and dead leaves to gather,
Gather, and merge myself as part of the sands and drift.

O baffled, balk'd, bent to the very earth,
Oppress'd with myself that I have dared to open my mouth,
Aware now that amid all that blab whose echoes recoil upon me I have
 not once had the least idea who or what I am,
But that before all my arrogant poems the real Me stands yet
 untouch'd, untold, altogether unreach'd,
Withdrawn far, mocking me with mock-congratulatory signs and bows,
With peals of distant ironical laughter at every word I have written,
Pointing in silence to these songs, and then to the sand beneath.

I perceive I have not really understood any thing, not a single
 object, and that no man ever can,
Nature here in sight of the sea taking advantage of me to dart upon
 me and sting me,
Because I have dared to open my mouth to sing at all.

~ 3 ~

You oceans both, I close with you,
We murmur alike reproachfully rolling sands and drift, knowing not why,
These little shreds indeed standing for you and me and all.

You friable shore with trails of debris,
You fish-shaped island, I take what is underfoot,
What is yours is mine my father.

I too Paumanok,
I too have bubbled up, floated the measureless float, and been
 wash'd on your shores,

I too am but a trail of drift and debris,
I too leave little wrecks upon you, you fish-shaped island.

I throw myself upon your breast my father,
I cling to you so that you cannot unloose me,
I hold you so firm till you answer me something.

Kiss me my father,
Touch me with your lips as I touch those I love,
Breathe to me while I hold you close the secret of the murmuring I envy.

~ 4 ~

Ebb, ocean of life, (the flow will return,)
Cease not your moaning you fierce old mother,
Endlessly cry for your castaways, but fear not, deny not me,
Rustle not up so hoarse and angry against my feet as I touch you or
gather from you.

I mean tenderly by you and all,
I gather for myself and for this phantom looking down where we lead,
and following me and mine.

Me and mine, loose windrows, little corpses,
Froth, snowy white, and bubbles,
(See, from my dead lips the ooze exuding at last,
See, the prismatic colors glistening and rolling,)
Tufts of straw, sands, fragments,
Buoy'd hither from many moods, one contradicting another,
From the storm, the long calm, the darkness, the swell,
Musing, pondering, a breath, a briny tear, a dab of liquid or soil,
Up just as much out of fathomless workings fermented and thrown,
A limp blossom or two, torn, just as much over waves floating,
drifted at random,

Just as much for us that sobbing dirge of Nature,
Just as much whence we come that blare of the cloud-trumpets,
We, capricious, brought hither we know not whence, spread out before you,
You up there walking or sitting,
Whoever you are, we too lie in drifts at your feet.

[1860]

As Adam Early in the Morning

As Adam early in the morning,
Walking forth from the bower refresh'd with sleep,
Behold me where I pass, hear my voice, approach,
Touch me, touch the palm of your hand to my body as I pass,
Be not afraid of my body.

[1861]

A Farm Picture

Through the ample open door of the peaceful country barn,
A sunlit pasture field with cattle and horses feeding,
And haze and vista, and the far horizon fading away.

[1865]

Cavalry Crossing a Ford

A line in long array, where they wind betwixt green islands,
They take a serpentine course, their arms flash in the sun—hark to the
 musical clank,
Behold the silvery river, in it the splashing horses, loitering, stop to drink,
Behold the brown-faced men, each group, each person a picture, the
 negligent rest on the saddles,
Some emerge on the opposite bank, others are just entering the ford—while,
Scarlet and blue and snowy white,
The guidon flags flutter gayly in the wind.

[1865]

Bivouac on a Mountain Side

I see before me now a traveling army halting,
Below a fertile valley spread, with barns and the orchards of summer,
Behind, the terraced sides of a mountain, abrupt, in places rising high,
Broken, with rocks, with clinging cedars, with tall shapes dingily seen,
The numerous camp-fires scatter'd near and far, some away up on the
 mountain,
The shadowy forms of men and horses, looming, large-sized, flickering,
And over all the sky—the sky! far, far out of reach, studded,
 breaking out, the eternal stars.

[1865]

The Wound-Dresser

~ 1 ~

An old man bending I come among new faces,
Years looking backward resuming in answer to children,
Come tell us old man, as from young men and maidens that love me,
(Arous'd and angry, I'd thought to beat the alarum, and urge relentless war,
But soon my fingers fail'd me, my face droop'd and I resign'd myself,
To sit by the wounded and soothe them, or silently watch the dead;)
Years hence of these scenes, of these furious passions, these chances,
Of unsurpass'd heroes (was one side so brave? the other was equally brave;)
Now be witness again, paint the mightiest armies of earth,
Of those armies so rapid so wondrous what saw you to tell us?
What stays with you latest and deepest? of curious panics,
Of hard-fought engagements or sieges tremendous what deepest remains?

~ 2 ~

O maidens and young men I love and that love me,
What you ask of my days those the strangest and sudden your talking recalls,
Soldier alert I arrive after a long march cover'd with sweat and dust,
In the nick of time I come, plunge in the fight, loudly shout in the rush of
 successful charge,
Enter the captur'd works—yet lo, like a swift-running river they fade,
Pass and are gone they fade—I dwell not on soldiers' perils or soldiers' joys,
(Both I remember well—many the hardships, few the joys, yet I was content.)

But in silence, in dreams' projections,
While the world of gain and appearance and mirth goes on,
So soon what is over forgotten, and waves wash the imprints off the sand,
With hinged knees returning I enter the doors, (while for you up there,
Whoever you are, follow without noise and be of strong heart.)

Bearing the bandages, water and sponge,
Straight and swift to my wounded I go,
Where they lie on the ground after the battle brought in,
Where their priceless blood reddens the grass, the ground,
Or to the rows of the hospital tent, or under the roof'd hospital,
To the long rows of cots up and down each side I return,
To each and all one after another I draw near, not one do I miss,
An attendant follows holding a tray, he carries a refuse pail,
Soon to be fill'd with clotted rags and blood, emptied, and fill'd again.

I onward go, I stop,
With hinged knees and steady hand to dress wounds,
I am firm with each, the pangs are sharp yet unavoidable,
One turns to me his appealing eyes—poor boy! I never knew you,
Yet I think I could not refuse this moment to die for you, if that would save
you.

~ 3 ~

On, on I go, (open doors of time! open hospital doors!)
The crush'd head I dress, (poor crazed hand tear not the bandage away,)
The neck of the cavalry-man with the bullet through and through I examine,
Hard the breathing rattles, quite glazed already the eye, yet life struggles hard,
(Come sweet death! be persuaded O beautiful death!
In mercy come quickly.)

From the stump of the arm, the amputated hand,
I undo the clotted lint, remove the slough, wash off the matter and blood,
Back on his pillow the soldier bends with curv'd neck and side-falling head,
His eyes are closed, his face is pale, he dares not look on the bloody stump,
And has not yet look'd on it.

I dress a wound in the side, deep, deep,
But a day or two more, for see the frame all wasted and sinking,
And the yellow-blue countenance see.

I dress the perforated shoulder, the foot with the bullet-wound,
Cleanse the one with a gnawing and putrid gangrene, so sickening, so
 offensive,
While the attendant stands behind aside me holding the tray and pail.

I am faithful, I do not give out,
The fractur'd thigh, the knee, the wound in the abdomen,
These and more I dress with impassive hand, (yet deep in my breast a fire,
 a burning flame.)

~ 4 ~

Thus in silence in dreams' projections,
Returning, resuming, I thread my way through the hospitals,
The hurt and wounded I pacify with soothing hand,
I sit by the restless all the dark night, some are so young,
Some suffer so much, I recall the experience sweet and sad,
(Many a soldier's loving arms about this neck have cross'd and rested,
Many a soldier's kiss dwells on these bearded lips.)

[1865]

When Lilacs Last in the Dooryard Bloom'd

~ 1 ~

When lilacs last in the dooryard bloom'd,
And the great star early droop'd in the western sky in the night,
I mourn'd, and yet shall mourn with ever-returning spring.

O ever-returning spring, trinity sure to me you bring,
Lilac blooming perennial and drooping star in the west,
And thought of him I love.

~ 2 ~

O powerful western fallen star!
O shades of night—O moody, tearful night!
O great star disappear'd—O the black murk that hides the star!
O cruel hands that hold me powerless—O helpless soul of me!
O harsh surrounding cloud that will not free my soul.

~ 3 ~

In the dooryard fronting an old farm-house near the white-wash'd palings,
Stands the lilac bush tall-growing with heart-shaped leaves of rich green,
With many a pointed blossom rising delicate, with the perfume strong I
love,
With every leaf a miracle—and from this bush in the dooryard,
With delicate-color'd blossoms and heart-shaped leaves of rich green,
A sprig with its flower I break.

~ 4 ~

In the swamp, in secluded recesses,
A shy and hidden bird is warbling a song.

Solitary the thrush,
The hermit, withdrawn to himself, avoiding the settlements,
Sings by himself a song.

Song of the bleeding throat,
Death's outlet song of life, (for well dear brother I know,
If thou wast not gifted to sing thou would'st surely die.)

~ 5 ~

Over the breast of the spring, the land, amid cities,
Amid lanes and through old woods, where lately the violets peep'd from the
ground, spotting the gray debris,
Amid the grass in the fields each side of the lanes, passing the endless grass,
Passing the yellow-spear'd wheat, every grain from its shroud in the dark-
brown fields uprisen;
Passing the apple-tree blows of white and pink in the orchards;
Carrying a corpse to where it shall rest in the grave,
Night and day journeys a coffin.

~ 6 ~

Coffin that passes through lanes and streets,
Through day and night with the great cloud darkening the land,
With the pomp of the inloop'd flags with the cities draped in black,
With the show of the States themselves as of crape-veil'd women standing,
With processions long and winding and the flambeaus of the night,
With the countless torches lit, with the silent sea of faces and the unbared
heads,
With the waiting depot, the arriving coffin, and the sombre faces,
With dirges through the night, with the thousand voices rising strong and
solemn,
With all the mournful voices of the dirges pour'd around the coffin,
The dim-lit churches and the shuddering organs—where amid these you
journey,

With the tolling tolling bells' perpetual clang,
Here, coffin that slowly passes,
I give you my sprig of lilac.

~ 7 ~

(Nor for you, for one alone,
Blossoms and branches green to coffins all I bring,
For fresh as the morning, thus would I chant a song for you O sane and
sacred death.

All over bouquets of roses,
O death, I cover you over with roses and early lilies,
But mostly and now the lilac that blooms the first,
Copious I break, I break the sprigs from the bushes,
With loaded arms I come, pouring for you,
For you and the coffins all of you O death.)

~ 8 ~

O western orb sailing the heaven,
Now I know what you must have meant as a month since I walk'd,
As I walk'd in silence the transparent shadowy night,
As I saw you had something to tell as you bent to me night after night,
As you droop'd from the sky low down as if to my side, (while the other stars
all look'd on),
As we wander'd together the solemn night, (for something I know not what
kept me from sleep.)
As the night advanced, and I saw on the rim of the west, how full you were of
woe,
As I stood on the rising ground in the breeze in the cold transparent night,
As I watch'd where you pass'd and was lost in the netherward black of the night,
As my soul in its trouble dissatisfied sank, as where you sad orb,
Concluded, dropt in the night, and was gone.

~ 9 ~

Sing on, there in the swamp,
O singer bashful and tender I hear your notes, I hear your call,
I hear, I come presently, I understand you,
But a moment I linger, for the lustrous star has detain'd me,
The star my departing comrade holds and detains me.

~ 10 ~

O how shall I warble myself for the dead one there I loved?
And how shall I deck my song for the large sweet soul that has gone?
And what shall my perfume be for the grave of him I love?

Sea-winds blown from east and west,
Blown from the Eastern sea and blown from the Western sea, till there on the
prairies meeting,
These and with these and the breath of my chant,
I'll perfume the grave of him I love.

~ 11 ~

O what shall I hang on the chamber walls?
And what shall the pictures be that I hang on the walls,
To adorn the burial-house of him I love?

Pictures of growing spring and farms and homes,
With the Fourth-month eve at sundown, and the gray smoke lucid and
bright,
With floods of the yellow gold of the gorgeous, indolent, sinking sun,
burning, expanding the air,
With the fresh sweet herbage under foot, and the pale green leaves of the
trees prolific,
In the distance the flowing glaze, the breast of the river, with a wind-dapple
here and there,

With ranging hills on the banks, with many a line against the sky, and shadows,
And the city at hand with dwellings so dense, and stacks of chimneys,
And all the scenes of life and the workshops, and the workmen homeward
returning.

~ 12 ~

Lo, body and soul—this land,
My own Manhattan with spires, and the sparkling and hurrying tides, and
the ships
The varied and ample land, the South and the North in the light, Ohio's
shores, and flashing Missouri,
And ever the far-spreading prairies cover'd with grass and corn.

Lo, the most excellent sun so calm and haughty,
The violet and purple morn with just-felt breezes,
The gentle soft-born, measureless light,
The miracle spreading bathing all, the fulfill'd noon,
The coming eve delicious, the welcome night and the stars,
Over my cities shining all, enveloping man and land.

~ 13 ~

Sing on, sing on, you gray-brown bird,
Sing from the swamps, the recesses, pour your chant from the bushes,
Limitless out of the dusk, out of the cedars and pines.

Sing on dearest brother, warble your reedy song,
Loud human song, with voice of uttermost woe.

O liquid and free and tender!
O wild and loose to my soul—O wondrous singer!
You only I hear—yet the star holds me, (but will soon depart,)
Yet the lilac with mastering odor holds me.

Now while I sat in the day and look'd forth,
 In the close of the day with its light and the fields of spring, and the farmers
 preparing their crops,
 In the large unconscious scenery of my land with its lakes and forests,
 In the heavenly aerial beauty, (after the perturb'd winds and the storms,)
 Under the arching heavens of the afternoon swift passing, and the voices of
 children and women,
 The many-moving sea-tides, and I saw the ships how they sail'd,
 And the summer approaching with richness, and the fields all busy with
 labor,
 And the infinite separate houses, how they all went on, each with its meals
 and minutia of daily usages,
 And the streets how their throbblings throb'd, and the cities pent—lo, then
 and there,
 Falling upon them all and among them all, enveloping me with the rest,
 Appear'd the cloud, appear'd the long black trail,
 And I knew death, its thought, and the sacred knowledge of death.

Then with the knowledge of death as walking one side of me,
 And the thought of death close-walking the other side of me,
 And I in the middle as with companions, and as holding the hands of
 companions,
 I fled forth to the hiding receiving night that talks not,
 Down to the shores of the water, the path by the swamp in the dimness,
 To the solemn shadowy cedars and ghostly pines so still.

And the singer so shy to the rest receiv'd me,
 The gray-brown bird I know receiv'd us comrades three,
 And he sang the carol of death, and a verse for him I love.

From deep secluded recesses,
 From the fragrant cedars, and the ghostly pines so still,
 Came the carol of the bird.

And the charm of the carol rapt me,
As I held as if by their hands my comrades in the night,
And the voice of my spirit tallied the song of the bird.

*Come lovely and soothing death,
Undulate round the world, serenely arriving, arriving,
In the day, in the night, to all, to each,
Sooner or later delicate death.*

*Prais'd be the fathomless universe,
For life and joy, and for objects and knowledge curious,
And for love, sweet love—but praise! praise! praise!
For the sure-enwinding arms of cool-enfolding death.*

*Dark mother always gliding near with soft feet,
Have none chanted for thee a chant of fullest welcome?
Then I chant it for thee, I glorify thee above all,
I bring thee a song that when thou must indeed come, come unfalteringly.*

*Approach strong deliveress,
When it is so, when thou hast taken them I joyously sing the dead,
Lost in the loving floating ocean of thee,
Laved in the flood of thy bliss O death.*

*From me to thee glad serenades,
Dances for thee I propose saluting thee, adornments and feastings for thee,
And the sights of the open landscape and the high-spread sky are fitting,
And life and the fields, and the huge and thoughtful night.*

*The night in silence under many a star,
The ocean shore and the husky whispering wave whose voice I know,
And the soul turning to thee O vast and well-veil'd death,
And the body gratefully nestling close to thee.*

*Over the tree-tops I float thee a song,
Over the rising and sinking waves, over the myriad fields and the prairies wide,
Over the dense-pack'd cities all and the teeming wharves and ways,
I float this carol with joy, with joy to thee O death.*

~ 15 ~

To the tally of my soul,
Loud and strong kept up the gray-brown bird,
With pure deliberate notes spreading filling the night.

Loud in the pines and cedars dim,
Clear in the freshness moist and the swamp-perfume,
And I with my comrades there in the night.

While my sight that was bound in my eyes unclosed,
As to long panoramas of visions.

And I saw askant the armies,
I saw as in noiseless dreams hundreds of battle-flags,
Borne through the smoke of the battles and pierc'd with missiles I saw them,
And carried hither and yon through the smoke, and torn and bloody,
And at last but a few shreds left on the staffs, (and all in silence,)
And the staffs all splinter'd and broken.

I saw battle-corpses, myriads of them,
And the white skeletons of young men, I saw them,
I saw the debris and debris of all the dead soldiers of the war,
But I saw they were not as was thought,
They themselves were fully at rest, they suffer'd not,
The living remain'd and suffer'd, the mother suffer'd,
And the wife and the child and the musing comrade suffer'd,
And the armies that remain'd suffer'd.

Passing the visions, passing the night,
 Passing, unloosing the hold of my comrades' hands,
 Passing the song of the hermit bird and the tallying song of my soul,
 Victorious song, death's outlet song, yet varying ever-altering song,
 As low and wailing, yet clear the notes, rising and falling, flooding the night,
 Sadly sinking and fainting, as warning and warning, and yet again bursting
 with joy,

Covering the earth and filling the spread of the heaven,
 As that powerful psalm in the night I heard from recesses,
 Passing, I leave thee lilac with heart-shaped leaves,
 I leave thee there in the door-yard, blooming, returning with spring,

I cease from my song for thee,
 From my gaze on thee in the west, fronting the west, communing with thee,
 O comrade lustrous with silver face in the night.

Yet each to keep and all, retrievements out of the night,
 The song, the wondrous chant of the gray-brown bird,
 And the tallying chant, the echo arous'd in my soul,
 With the lustrous and drooping star with the countenance full of woe,
 With the holders holding my hand nearing the call of the bird,
 Comrades mine and I in the midst, and their memory ever I keep, for the
 dead I loved so well,
 For the sweetest, wisest soul of all my days and lands—and this for his dear
 sake,
 Lilac and star and bird twined with the chant of my soul,
 There in the fragrant pines and the cedars dusk and dim.

[1865]

Reconciliation

Word over all, beautiful as the sky,
Beautiful that war and all its deeds of carnage must in time be utterly lost,
That the hands of the sisters Death and Night incessantly softly wash again,
 and ever again, this soiled world;
For my enemy is dead, a man divine as myself is dead,
I look where he lies white-faced and still in the coffin—I draw near,
I bend down and touch lightly with my lips the white face in the coffin.

[1866]

The Runner

On a flat road runs the well-train'd runner,
He is lean and sinewy with muscular legs,
He is thinly clothed, he leans forward as he runs,
With lightly closed fists and arms partially rais'd.

[1867]

Sparkles from the Wheel

Where the city's ceaseless crowd moves on the livelong day,
Withdrawn I join a group of children watching, I pause aside with them.

By the curb toward the edge of the flagging,
A knife-grinder works at his wheel sharpening a great knife,
Bending over he carefully holds it to the stone, by foot and knee,
With measur'd tread he turns rapidly, as he presses with light but firm hand,
Forth issue then in copious golden jets,
Sparkles from the wheel.

The scene and all its belongings, how they seize and affect me,
The sad sharp-chinn'd old man with worn clothes and broad shoulder-band
 of leather,
Myself effusing and fluid, a phantom curiously floating, now here absorb'd
 and arrested,
The group, (an unminded point set in a vast surrounding,)
The attentive, quiet children, the loud, proud, restive base of the streets,
The low hoarse purr of the whirling stone, the light-press'd blade,
Diffusing, dropping, sideways-darting, in tiny showers of gold,
Sparkles from the wheel.

[1871]

A Noiseless Patient Spider

A noiseless patient spider,
I mark'd where on a little promontory it stood isolated,
Mark'd how to explore the vacant vast surrounding,
It launch'd forth filament, filament, filament, out of itself,
Ever unreeling them, ever tirelessly speeding them.

And you O my Soul where you stand,
Surrounded, detached, in measureless oceans of space,
Ceaselessly musing, venturing, throwing, seeking the spheres to connect
 them,
Till the bridge you will need be form'd, till the ductile anchor hold,
Till the gossamer thread you fling catch somewhere, O my Soul.

[1871]

A Paumonok Picture

Two boats with nets lying off the sea-beach, quite still,
Ten fishermen waiting—they discover a thick school of mossbonkers—
 they drop the join'd seine-ends in the water,
The boats separate and row off, each on its rounding course to the
 beach, enclosing the mossbonkers,
The net is drawn in by a windlass by those who stop ashore,
Some of the fishermen lounge in their boats, others stand ankle-deep
 in the water, pois'd on strong legs,
The boats partly drawn up, the water slapping against them,
Strew'd on the sand in heaps and windrows, well out from the water,
 the green-back'd spotted mossbonkers.

[1881]

The Dalliance of the Eagles

Skirting the river road, (my forenoon walk, my rest,)
Skyward in air a sudden muffled sound, the dalliance of the eagles,
The rushing amorous contact high in space together,
The clinching interlocking claws, a living, fierce, gyrating wheel,
Four beating wings, two beaks, a swirling mass tight grappling,
In tumbling turning clustering loops, straight downward falling,
Till o'er the river pois'd, the twain yet one, a moment's lull,
A motionless still balance in the air, then parting, talons loosing,
Upward again on slow-firm pinions slanting, their separate diverse flight,
She hers, he his, pursuing.

[1881]

Old Salt Kossabone

Far back, related on my mother's side,
Old Salt Kossabone, I'll tell you how he died:
(Had been a sailor all his life—was nearly 90—lived with his
 married grandchild, Jenny;
House on a hill, with view of bay at hand, and distant cape, and
 stretch to open sea;)
The last of afternoons, the evening hours, for many a year his
 regular custom,
In his great arm chair by the window seated,
(Sometimes, indeed, through half the day,)
Watching the coming, going of the vessels, he mutters to himself—
 And now the close of all:
One struggling outbound brig, one day, baffled for long—cross-tides
 and much wrong going,
At last at nightfall strikes the breeze aright, her whole luck veering,
And swiftly bending round the cape, the darkness proudly entering,
 cleaving, as he watches,
“She's free—she's on her destination”—these the last words—when
 Jenny came, he sat there dead,
Dutch Kossabone, Old Salt, related on my mother's side, far back.

[1888]

After the Supper and Talk

After the supper and talk—after the day is done,
As a friend from friends his final withdrawal prolonging,
Good-bye and Good-bye with emotional lips repeating,
(So hard for his hand to release those hands—no more will they meet,
No more for communion of sorrow and joy, of old and young,
A far-stretching journey awaits him, to return no more,)
Shunning, postponing severance—seeking to ward off the last word ever so
 little,
E'en at the exit-door turning—charges superfluous calling back—e'en as he
 descends the steps,
Something to eke out a minute additional—shadows of nightfall deepening,
Farewells, messages lessening—dimmer the forthgoer's visage and form,
Soon to be lost for aye in the darkness—loth, O so loth to depart!
Garrulous to the very last.

[1888]

